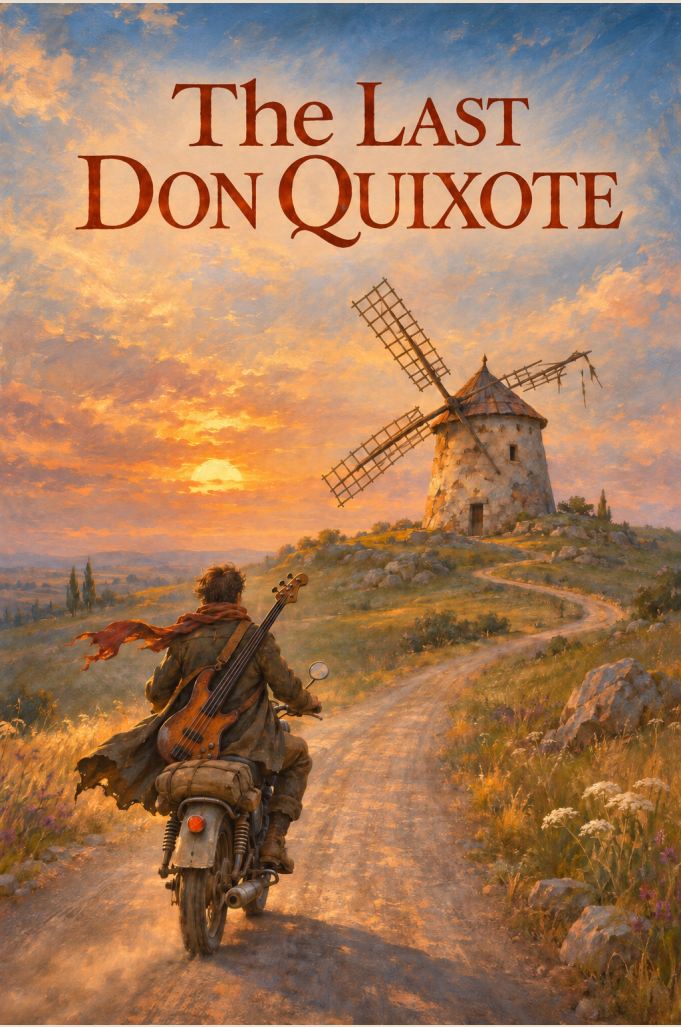

The Last
Don Quixote

The Last Don Quixote

A Tale of a Man Who Did Not Want to Be the Last

Part I: Paper

1. The Last

I was told that I was the Last Don Quixote on a Thursday, at half past ten in the morning, just as I was about to stop being one.

I had been about to for some time, admittedly. Ever since I discovered that declaring yourself the last is no less exhausting than declaring yourself the first. The first must keep proving that no one came before him. The last, that no one will come after. I had no time for either: an old mill stood on the edge of town, and its sails were under threat of demolition.

That Thursday, a summons arrived from the Office of Final Affairs. It was brought not by the postman but by a man in a grey raincoat who had apparently spent his whole life delivering unwelcome news and had therefore learnt to walk without making the floorboards creak in advance.

“Are you Citizen So-and-so?” he asked.

“That depends what it concerns.”

He looked at the envelope.

“The matter of the Last Don Quixote.”

“Then probably, yes.”

The man handed me the envelope and asked me to sign. I signed. He

asked me to sign again, because my first signature, he said, looked encouraging.

Inside was a sheet the colour of old butter. It read:

> **Notice of Conferral of Title**
> The citizen is hereby recognised as the last practising Don Quixote in the district.
> The citizen is therefore required to attend the Office of Final Affairs before sunset and confirm the existence of at least one unfinished undertaking of importance to someone other than the citizen himself.
> In the absence of such an undertaking, the title shall be deemed closed and the citizen

transferred to the category of memories.

There were two seals at the bottom. One was round, the other square. Beneath the square seal, a note in small print added: “Roundness is no guarantee of finality.”

I read the paper again and said:

“So it looks as though I shall be the Last Don Quixote after all. Hurrah!”

The man in the grey raincoat stopped buttoning his coat.

“You are pleased?”

“I haven’t decided yet. I’ve always wanted to be the last of

something. It does away with the queue."

He wrote my words in a notebook.

"Will that count as testimony?"

"Only if you apply a third stamp."

"Our third stamp is for those who have stopped joking."

"Then keep it handy. It may come in useful."

The man gave a careful bow, as though taking leave of a future he had not liked, and went away. I was left with the summons and an old, low sound drawn out of the instrument leaning against the wall.

The instrument was called a bass guitar. Its fingerboard had no frets: not a single ridge across it to tell a finger where to stop. Over many years I had grown used to finding a note by ear and by touch. Sometimes it seemed that the string noticed the road before I did. That day it quivered of its own accord, barely audibly, and released four notes from the wood.

The fifth note did not sound.

In its place came a rest.

There was nothing I could do with the rest. It was neither high nor low nor right. It simply waited.

Outside, above the roof, the wind passed by. The curtain stirred at the window, and far away, on the western outskirts, the mill's sails answered with a single slow turn.

I picked up the bass guitar, slung it over my back and folded the summons into quarters.

A fine blue line appeared on the paper. It led from my house to the Office of Final Affairs, then broke off at the town wall.

"A good map," I said. "It shows where the road ends."

I started the motorcycle.

The motorcycle was small and slightly old-fashioned, somewhere between a bicycle and a pony in size. I had named it

Maybe. It was not fast, but it knew how to start after prolonged persuasion, and on the road that can sometimes be worth more than speed.

Maybe and I set off for the Office.

The Office of Final Affairs occupied three floors of a former hotel on a square where apples and news had once been sold. Now apples were sold in a shop and news on telephones, while the square had been left empty for gatherings that were not supposed to take place.

Inside, it smelt of paper, wet wool and something else: possibly waiting. Behind the counter sat a young man with a thin little

beard and a look that could close a ticket office.

“Are you here about the Last Don Quixote?” he asked.

“I am he.”

“Passport.”

I laid my passport on the counter. The young man compared the photograph with my face and nodded cautiously.

“Yes. According to our register, you are the last.”

“Does your register have any firsts?”

“It does. But they generally arrive earlier.”

He gave me a ticket. It said: “The Last. Please wait.”

“How long?”

“In your case, until the end.”

“Of what, exactly?”

“We don’t yet know. Your turn will determine that.”

I sat down. On the wall opposite hung a clock with two hands. The minute hand went forwards, the hour hand backwards. Between them, as though they felt awkward about meeting, sat a third, very short hand. It did not move at all.

After a while a lean man in a dark suit emerged through an inner door. On his lapel was a badge in the shape of a closed book.

“Don Quixote?” he asked.

“For the moment, yes.”

“This way, please.”

The office was long and empty. On the desk stood an inkwell, a glass of water and a nameplate: “Head of the Department of Completions. Gaspar Metronomovich Ladny.” The head of department himself looked as though he had never once in his life been late, even for a thought of his own.

“Congratulations,” he said.

“On what?”

“You are the last.”

“So I have been told.”

“Then you know that it is a great responsibility.”

“So far it’s only a great sheet of paper.”

Gaspar Metronomovich smiled a little. He knew how to smile as though the smile, too, had been approved in advance.

“We conducted a census of unfinished aspirations. People were asked a simple question: ‘Is there an undertaking you will continue even if no one has promised you success?’ Most answered no. Some replied that success was already assured. One person wrote: ‘I don’t know.’ That was you.”

“I don’t remember any census.”

“You did not fill in the questionnaire. But our specialist observed you near the old mill.”

“That isn’t a census. It’s surveillance.”

“Surveillance is a word with accusatory overtones. We prefer ‘observation without prior notification’.”

“And do you observe the mill as well?”

“Of course. It has been declared unfit.”

“For what?”

“For what it used to do.”

I laid my hands on the desk.

“What do you want from me?”

Gaspar Metronomovich opened a folder.

“At midnight tonight the period allotted to the old mill expires. In the morning it will be removed from the town plan. A meteorological tower will be erected in its place. Your presence is required as the last registered Don Quixote: you must confirm that you consider this event a matter for regret.”

“And if I consider the mill necessary?”

“Then evidence will be required.”

“What kind?”

“Sufficient.”

“A useful word.”

“It fits on any form.”

He pushed a sheet towards me with my surname on it. Underneath were three blank lines: “Witness”, “Reason”, “Expected outcome”.

“How much time do I have?”

“Until sunset to confirm the existence of an unfinished undertaking. Until midnight to explain why it matters to anyone besides yourself. If you fail to explain, the title will be closed.”

“And I become a memory?”

“That is a legal term.”

“What does it mean in practice?”

“People will remember you in whatever way suits them.”

“That happens to everyone.”

This time he did not smile.

I stood up. He held out the form, but I did not take it.

“The mill has not produced flour for some forty years,” said Gaspar Metronomovich. “I understand your attachment. But people cannot go on preserving things for ever merely because they remind them of something.”

“Perhaps,” I said. “And can they go on demolishing things for ever merely because they no longer remember what they are for?”

The head of the Department of Completions looked at me closely, almost respectfully.

“That is what your turn will establish.”

I went out into the square. At noon the shadow of the former hotel fell across the clock and stopped between two marks. The wind blew from the west, but the mill’s sails were no longer turning.

I took out the bass guitar. Ran a finger along the lowest string. This time it was silent.

So I rode to the workshop.

2. The Workshop Where Things Would Not Give Up

Marta's workshop stood beyond the level crossing, in a lane that was not on the new map. If you followed the old one, the lane was called "Turn-off to the Left". If you went by memory, it was "where it always smells of hot metal".

Marta could mend almost anything except promises. She did not take those in for repair: promises, she said, ought to hold up by themselves.

When I arrived, she was lying beneath a large yellow bus, with only her boots and her voice left outside.

“If you’ve brought another clock, put it on the bench,” she said. “If it’s a dog, tie it to the post. If it’s trouble, it can wait by the door.”

“I’ve brought myself.”

“That’s usually the heaviest thing.”

She rolled out from under the bus on a trolley, wiped her hands and sat up. There were two black streaks on her sleeve and one blue one. Blue streaks, according to her, meant that the mechanism could still be saved.

“I’ve been appointed the Last Don Quixote,” I said.

Marta looked at me, then at my motorcycle.

“And what’s he been appointed?”

“Maybe?”

“No, I mean the motorcycle.”

“He’s been appointed a means of transport.”

“Then all is well. Though he ought to be on his guard.”

I told her about the mill, the Office and the demand to prove that someone needed this unfinished undertaking. Marta listened, still cleaning a metal washer. When she had finished, she laid the washer on her palm and looked at it for a long time.

“My father worked there,” she said.

“At the mill?”

“Not as a miller. He repaired the mechanism. He said it would work again one day.”

“And did it?”

“No.”

“Then why are you defending it?”

“I’m not defending it. I just remember that he used to go there.”

“That’s a reason already.”

“For you, perhaps. Not for their form.”

She stood up and tossed the washer into a box. It fell to the bottom with a clear, high note.

“There’s something else,” said Marta. “When I was little, the mill used to sing.”

“Mills usually make a noise.”

“This one sang. Not beautifully, not the way people sing. It was as though it passed the sound through the whole building, then gave it back changed. Father used to say: ‘Listen. That’s not the wind. It’s the pause between the gusts.’”

“Do you remember the tune?”

“No. All I remember is that afterwards I wanted to ask where the road went.”

I slipped the bass guitar off my shoulder and laid it on the bench.

“I dreamt today that it was playing.”

“You haven’t been asleep today.”

“That’s why I say ‘dreamt’.”

Marta passed a finger above the strings without touching them.

“And where are the notes?”

“There aren’t any notes.”

“Then how do you know there are four?”

“Because I heard four. The fifth never came.”

“Perhaps it isn’t meant to come.”

“Every song has to end some time.”

“And what if this song doesn’t want to end?”

The workshop fell quiet. A bus hummed beyond the door, a wire creaked above the roof, water whispered somewhere. The bass

guitar lay on the bench and did not answer.

Marta got up.

“Let’s go to the mill.”

“Do you believe it can be saved?”

“No. But I want to find out whether it really sings.”

“That’s almost faith already.”

“Don’t rush me. I’m only checking.”

She put on her jacket, took a brass compass from a drawer and locked the workshop. The compass had no needle.

“Is it broken?” I asked.

“No. It simply knows where north is.”

“And the needle?”

“The needle got in the way.”

Marta climbed onto Maybe behind me. The motorcycle sank by one sigh, but held.

“He’s still somewhere between a bicycle and a pony,” she observed.

“But now there are two of us. We’re getting closer to a horse.”

“If he neighs, I’m getting off.”

We rode west, towards the mill.

3. The Mill That Was Not Entitled to Wind

As far as the town wall, the road was paved with stone. Beyond the wall it became gravel, beyond the gravel earth, and then, according to the new map, it disappeared.

Marta took the paper map off the handlebars, looked at it and folded it in half.

“There’s nothing further on,” she said.

“But there is a further on.”

“That’s not the same thing.”

“We haven’t checked yet.”

Maybe snorted through his engine. We rode along the former

road, visible only in two shallow wheel tracks and in the way the grass grew sideways, unwilling to block the way.

The mill appeared on the hill towards evening. Its stone tower was taller than I remembered and smaller than I would have liked. It still had its sails, but one was cracked. On the wall hung a sign: “Structure not in use. Do not approach a conclusion.”

“Who wrote that?” asked Marta.

“Someone who’s already decided everything.”

“Or someone afraid of having it decided for him.”

Beyond the hill stood a construction crane. Its long jib

stretched out over the field like the arm of a giant looking for somewhere to rest his elbow. At the foot of the crane, workers were unreeling a cable. Marking stakes lay on the ground, each tied with a white ribbon.

My first thought was: there he is, the giant.

Marta's first words were:

"That's a crane."

"I know it's a crane."

"Then why are you looking at it as though it were a monster?"

"Because it's come to demolish the mill."

"That doesn't make it a monster."

I was about to object, but the wind rose and passed over the hill. The mill's sails stirred. First one, then another. The stone tower gave out a deep sound, so low that I felt it not with my ears but with the palm resting on the body of the bass guitar.

Four notes.

Then a rest.

Marta went pale.

"It still remembers," she said.

"What, exactly?"

"What it was meant to sing."

At the entrance to the mill we found a fresh envelope bearing the seal of the Office of Final Affairs. My name was on it. Inside

was the very same form, except that the line marked “Expected outcome” had now been filled in:

> **Outcome: confirmation of the absence of public need.**

Beneath it, someone had neatly added by hand:

> **Attendance of the Last is compulsory. Witnesses need not be brought.**

I looked at Marta.

“It seems they’re no longer expecting us.”

“We weren’t invited in the first place.”

“Good, then. We won’t have to be late.”

I tore the form in half. Then in half again, because after the first tear the document was still too sure of itself.

A new sound came from inside the mill. Not one of the four, but another. It sounded like a finger tapping quietly on a closed door.

Marta held out the compass without a needle. The brass lid trembled in her hand.

“The fifth?” I asked.

“No,” she said. “Someone is listening.”

We went in.

4. The Girl with the Wrong Map

Inside, it smelt of damp lime and grain that had not been there for years. The dust lay unevenly on the floor: a clean path ran down the middle, and near the wall were the prints of small boots. A wheel hung overhead. It was not turning, but for some reason that made it seem even heavier.

“Don’t go any further,” said Marta.

She raised her hand, and I stopped faster than I had ever stopped for an official order. A fresh splinter gleamed in the strip of light falling through the window. Marta looked up, felt

along the wall for a switch that switched nothing on, and took out a pocket torch.

“Is anyone here?”

“If you’re here about the contributions, I’m not,” came a reply from behind the motionless millstone.

A girl was sitting on a wooden crate. Beside her lay a rucksack, an apple and a large sheet of paper held down by four little stones. The apple had been bitten into so methodically that it looked as though it was being studied.

“What contributions?” I asked.

“For the school museum. To preserve history. They promised to put the mill in it.”

I looked at the tower from the inside.

“All of it?”

“A photograph. I said in that case the contributions could be a photograph too.”

Marta crouched beside the doorpost. A crack ran through the plaster, thin at the bottom, branching into two higher up.

“Have you been here long?”

“Since half past three.”

“Is anyone waiting for you?”

“My grandmother. Vera Pavlovna. She knows I’m drawing the mill.”

“Does she know you’re drawing it from inside?”

The girl pushed the apple towards the rucksack.

“Not in that much detail.”

“That’s a detail she’d better hear from you,” said Marta. “Gather your things. You can’t sit under the wheel here.”

The girl began to object, but Marta shone the torch on the splintered end of a beam, and she folded the paper without a word. Her name was Nika. She was thirteen, a fact she announced the moment I tried to take her rucksack.

“Is that your age or your load capacity?” I asked.

She looked at the bass guitar on my back.

“And yours?”

Outside, the wind smelt of grass and grease. While Marta spoke to Vera Pavlovna on the telephone, Nika spread her paper on a low stone wall. It was a map. The roads did not try to be straight, the houses were all different, and three benches had been drawn beside the hospital. In a field stood a small hare.

“Is that a map symbol?”

“It’s a hare. He lives there.”

“You’re not supposed to draw every inhabitant on a map.”

“That’s why nobody ever finds anybody with them.”

I recognised the level crossing, Marta’s workshop and the road to

the mill. Beyond the mill the road continued down towards the river, although on the town plan there was only a strip of green in its place.

“How do you know where it goes?”

Nika pointed to a tiny red house near the bottom of the sheet.

“There used to be a bus stop there. Grandma used to visit her sister. Then they took the stop away because hardly anyone used it. After that they counted the passengers. There were even fewer of them. Now the road’s gone too.”

At school they had been set the task of drawing the route from

home to their favourite place. Nika had drawn the way to her grandmother's sister's house. The teacher had asked her to correct it: the favourite place had to be within the accessible area.

"I asked, accessible to whom. She said that was a different subject."

I laughed. Nika did not smile.

"Aunt Sonya died last year. Grandma didn't get there in time. She's still alive on the map, because that's when I started it."

My laughter hung between us, absurd and weightless. I could find nowhere to put it away, and for the first time that day I said nothing.

Marta came over.

“Your grandmother’s waiting at my workshop. We’re going there now.”

“What about the map?”

“Bring it. Just don’t go back in for the other stones.”

A worker in an orange waistcoat was walking towards us from the crane. He held a mug away from himself to keep the tea from spilling as he crossed the uneven ground. He stopped just outside the entrance.

“No one’s supposed to be in there today,” he said. “I put tape up this morning.”

“The wind tore it down,” Nika replied.

“Then I didn’t put it up properly.”

He did not add that the sign had still been there. I had expected an argument and for some reason felt affronted when none materialised.

The worker's name was Semyon. He was not going to remove the sails yet: first the damaged section had to be secured. The permit for the work took effect in the morning. Today the crew were bringing in power and preparing the site.

"Is the tower really needed?" I asked.

"The weather tower? Yes. People down by the river are waiting for a forecast. With the present sensor it's either forty above zero in November or a southerly wind

all week from inside a locked shed.”

“Couldn’t it go somewhere else?”

“I can put it wherever I’m told. I didn’t choose the site.”

Marta asked whether the old mill still had a separate sound shaft. Semyon brightened. It turned out that as a boy he had brought his uncle lunch here and remembered an iron shutter beside the lower door.

“They used to send out a call from there when the water rose. Then they put in a telephone, and then the telephone stopped working. We thought they’d mend it.”

“Who’s ‘we’?”

“A bit of everyone.”

He showed us a recess visible from the threshold. In it, under a layer of cobwebs, a copper horn gleamed darkly. Four short strokes and one long one had been carved above it. Nika reached for her pencil, but Marta held her by the shoulder.

“You can draw it from outside.”

I suddenly felt that everything was falling into place of its own accord. A girl, a map, a forgotten signal, a man of the people to bear witness. A speech could be made. I had already drawn breath.

“What time is it?” asked Marta.

Semyon looked at his telephone.

“Twenty to five.”

“And when does reception close?”

I took out the notice. It said “before sunset”, but in small print at the bottom: “For applications made in person, the time of document registration shall apply.”

We rang the Office. An automated voice offered us a choice of seven completed matters. There were no unfinished ones among them. Marta pressed zero and waited for a person.

“You close at six? Thank you. We’re on our way.”

I showed her the four pieces of the torn form.

“That was a mistake, wasn’t it?”

“A spectacular mistake. The difference is the time you spend afterwards with sticky tape.”

Semyon agreed to drive Marta and Nika in the cab of the works lorry. I rode behind. Near the level crossing the lorry stopped to let Nika out and wait until her grandmother appeared at the workshop gate. A grey-haired woman in a blue raincoat put one arm round the girl and took the map with the other hand. Nika was explaining something quickly. Her grandmother listened and did not look at the mill.

We entered the Office at seventeen forty-eight. The young man with the little beard had

already put a transparent cover over his keyboard.

“Reception is closing,” he said.

Marta looked at the clock.

“Good. That means it’s still open.”

I asked for a new form. I was given an application to report the loss of the old one. I asked for another new form. The young man sighed, took out a sheet and ran his finger along the three lines.

On the line marked “Witness” I wrote Marta’s and Semyon’s names. Under “Reason” I began: “Preservation of the last bastion…”

Marta covered the line with her palm.

“What did we see?”

“A mill.”

“What else?”

I crossed out the bastion and wrote about the sound shaft, the old road and the link with the riverside settlements. We spent a long time finding an ungainly wording for the expected outcome: “To investigate the possibility of safe public use while retaining meteorological observation.” Semyon added that before any investigation the damaged sail must be secured and the entrance fenced off.

Gaspar Metronomovich came out at three minutes to six. He read the application standing up.

“You are asking to preserve a structure whose purpose you do not know.”

“We’re asking for time to find out,” said Marta.

“Because of one person’s memory?”

Semyon set his mug on the windowsill.

“Two people’s. But I wouldn’t lift a load on the strength of memories. It needs surveying.”

Gaspar looked at him more closely than he had looked at me.

“Who will undertake to gather the information?”

I raised my hand. Marta did not let me add “single-handed”.

It turned out there was a procedure for suspending a final decision when a previously unrecorded public use came to light. I asked why the notice had said nothing about it.

“Because the notice concerns the final decision,” Gaspar replied.

He signed the sheet. Until noon the following Thursday, the mill would not be removed from the plan and demolition would not begin. Only work necessary for safety was permitted. We were to provide information about its usefulness, the condition of the building and the people willing to take responsibility for it. Evidence of a beautiful past alone would not be accepted.

“And the title?” I asked.

“The existence of an unfinished undertaking has been confirmed within the allotted time. As for its significance, that remains to be established.”

A time, a number and a round seal appeared on the copy. I waited for the square one.

“Are you waiting for something?”

“No. Learning to leave at the right time.”

In the corridor Semyon photographed the order and sent it to the crew’s supervisor. Marta took the copy from me and checked the registration number once more. I was about to celebrate, but she said that first

we had to give Nika back the pencil she had left behind.

At the workshop Vera Pavlovna was giving her granddaughter tea. The map lay on a clean piece of plywood. Her grandmother was explaining where the road turned towards the river, and Nika was rubbing out a line that was too straight.

“Now it’s wrong again,” she said.

“Now it’s closer,” her grandmother replied.

I sat down beside them. Mill dust still clung to my sleeve. Outside the window it was growing dark, and for the first time that Thursday I did not feel that the evening was obliged to settle everything at once.

5. The Inn of Final Answers

In the morning we began by not setting out.

Marta told me to bring all the papers to the workbench, then opened her order book. Before the following Thursday she had a bakery's temperamental refrigerator to deal with, a bus with its gearbox in pieces and a pump belonging to a man who said "Literally just a minute" in every telephone conversation. The minute was into its third month.

"All of those are unfinished undertakings too," I observed.

“And some of them pay the electricity bill,” said Marta. “So the journey will begin after eight telephone calls.”

She did not like asking for more time. On the third call I heard the person at the other end suggest that she simply give up on the mill. Marta looked out of the window for a long time, then said that another repairer would collect the refrigerator and wrote down his name. By the time she had finished, the book contained new dates, two crossed-out sums and an arrow across the whole page.

“Father used to do that too,” she said. “Promise to finish by Friday, then go off to the mill.”

“Were you angry with him?”

“I still am sometimes. It’s awkward: he can no longer argue back.”

For the first time it occurred to me that for her the mill might be not only the place her father had gone to, but also the place they had waited for him to come back from.

Vera Pavlovna arrived with Nika at half past eight. In her hands she carried a bag of sandwiches, and on her face the expression of someone who had decided to ask the questions before the beautiful answers began.

“Where are you going? Where will you sleep? When will you be

back? And why does the girl have to go with you?”

We answered the first three questions. To the fourth, I said that Nika was our guide.

“That sounds honourable,” observed Vera Pavlovna. “Only you can find the way without a thirteen-year-old child.”

Nika opened her mouth, but her grandmother raised a finger.

“And you can ask to go because you want to. You needn’t set yourself up as indispensable first.”

Nika fell silent. Then, more quietly, she said she wanted to see Aunt Sonya’s house and travel

the part of the map she was always having to rub out.

We agreed on two days. Marta was responsible for the trip; Nika would telephone morning and evening, would not enter dangerous buildings, and no one would ride three to a motorcycle. If the plans changed, a call to her grandmother came first. Marta and Nika took the morning scheduled bus to the inn on the old highway. I went there on Maybe and arrived after the bus: at the level crossing I had had to give way to a train in which every carriage was convinced it was the last.

The inn was called the Final Answer. Above the door hung a

wooden spoon so large that it could have been used to feed a resolution of the town council.

Inside, it smelt of onions, hot bread and wet jackets. Plaques offering advice hung on the walls. “More haste, less speed” sat beside “He who hesitates is lost”. Between them stood a table for six. I decided it was a place for reconciling the parties.

The owner, a round-faced man with grey temples, was called Yakov. He set tea before Marta, milk before Nika and an empty cup before me.

“Coffee or tea?”

“Which is best?”

He pointed to the plaque over the counter: “The best is the enemy of the good.”

“Then the good.”

“We ran out this morning.”

We laughed, and Yakov brought coffee.

The inn stood at a fork. Lorries travelled along the main road; the smaller road had once taken people to the riverside settlements. Now the smaller road was barred by a sign with an arrow running into a grey square.

“What does that mean?”

“Route not serviced,” said Yakov. “It used to say ‘No through road’,

but people drove through. It didn’t look good.”

We asked about the mill’s signal. Yakov wiped the table, although it was clean, and reached beneath the counter.

In a drawer was a notebook with grease stains on its cover. Recipes filled the first pages, then came accounts, and towards the end we found a drawing of the valley. Four dots were connected by lines: the mill, the river crossing, the market, the railway school. Beside each, someone’s name had been written.

“Mother kept the notes,” said Yakov. “People used to gather here when the river rose. Then they began to gather when they

were merely expecting it to rise. They drank tea, passed on news. Mother grumbled: they'd eat all the biscuits, and there wouldn't be any rain."

"Do you remember the tune?"

He shrugged.

"As a child I thought grown-ups had signals so they wouldn't have to shout across the street. Mother had an ordinary whistle."

"And where is she now?"

Yakov looked at the shelf of cups.

"She's been gone going on five years."

I wanted to say something about memory, but in the kitchen the light went out with a crack. A

woman's voice called Yakov. He put the notebook on the table and went in, carrying a cup as carefully as though the darkness had already begun inside it.

A minute later he came back.

"Too many things switched on," he explained.

Marta looked at the clock above the stove. It said eight forty-two, although it was already ten.

"Do you often have too much on?"

"Depends how many people there are."

"And if there aren't any?"

"It happens then too."

She asked to see the fuse box. Yakov glanced sideways at the

plaque that said “Let sleeping dogs lie”, but led her into the corridor all the same. Nika and I stayed with the notebook. Nika was copying the valley. In place of the name “Pavel” beside the mill she wrote “Marta’s father?”, with a question mark as big as the handle of a suitcase.

The driver of a small van came in. He asked whether the parcel for the river market was ready. Yakov came back from the corridor and said that it was, but there was no one to deliver it today: the inn’s own van had been standing by the shed for a week, and the driver who had just arrived was turning off in a different direction.

“What’s broken?” asked Marta.

“Probably everything.”

“That rarely happens all at once.”

It turned out the van would start but stalled whenever anyone tried to drive it out of the yard. Yakov tried again every day, then covered the steering wheel with a towel. A mechanic had promised to come afterwards, without specifying after what.

“They told me I should replace the van,” said the owner.

“And before that, did they tell you it needed mending?”

“They did. That’s why I’m waiting for a final answer.”

Marta took off her jacket.

“Let’s begin by having a look.”

There was an orchard behind the inn. Apples lay beneath the trees, unpicked: this year there was no money to hire anyone, and Yakov could not keep up on his own. Nika asked permission and filled a bucket. I carried it to the kitchen and listened to Marta talking to the van. She spoke to it far more politely than she spoke to me.

There was nothing grand about it. A connection, some dirt, a small thing overlooked for a long time. But almost two hours passed before the engine ran steadily. Marta checked the brakes, lights and seat belts, and refused to let the van leave on a bald front tyre.

Yakov brought a spare wheel, then another one that fitted. It began to rain while the wheel was being changed. I held an umbrella over Marta, and everything that ran off it went down her collar.

“Could you help from a little further away?” she asked.

In the kitchen Yakov’s assistant, Tamara, was slicing apples. On the table lay a sheet of her calculations: how many pies could be baked, and how much sugar would be needed. Yakov looked in, said the pies might not sell, and Tamara put down the knife.

I felt the familiar urge to speak out at once in favour of pies. My

mouth was already open. But Yakov sat on a chair with the wet towel from the steering wheel in his hands, looking so tired that it would have been rude to make a speech at him.

“Are you afraid of using up the ingredients?” I asked.

“I’m afraid of having to explain to Tamara again why her wages are late,” he said. “There’s nothing about that on the plaques.”

Tamara leaned against the table.

“And I’m afraid of spending my whole life cooking three dishes because somebody bought them once. Let’s do one tray. Not ten.”

They began to work out the figures. Nika and I went outside

so as not to turn someone else's conversation into a performance.

The van started first time. Yakov offered to pay for the repair, but Marta asked whether she could instead deliver his parcel to the river and borrow the van for two days. Then she and Nika would have safe transport, and Yakov would have his order fulfilled. He checked the documents, wrote down to whom he was handing the keys and warned her that the left-hand door liked to be shut a second time.

"And if you're delayed?"

"I'll telephone," said Marta.

For some reason this reassured him more than my assurance that

we would certainly return on time.

Before we left, Tamara brought out the first pie. The edge was a little burnt. Yakov broke off a crumb, tasted it and held half out to her.

“Less heat next time,” he said.

“So there’ll be a next time?”

He shrugged, but was already reaching for a clean plate.

We did not take the notebook. Nika photographed the pages we needed, and Yakov gave her a copy of the sketch his mother had once taken out, folded and tucked between the accounts. On the back was a recipe for pastry. Nika

asked whether she could keep that too.

“Why would you rub it out?” said Yakov, surprised.

As we drove away, he stood at the door with a screwdriver. He had not taken down the Final Answer sign, only tightened a screw: the sign creaked and woke Tamara when she stayed the night in the room above the kitchen.

The rain had stopped. A wet leaf lay on the van’s windscreen. Nika did not brush it away before we moved off. Then the leaf rose, turned over and was left on the road face down.

6. The Rider Without a Horse

Semyon was waiting for us at the first bend.

He sat on his bicycle with one foot on the ground. A bundle was tied to the carrier. Without his orange waistcoat he looked younger, although his hair had lost none of its grey overnight.

“You take your time saving mills,” he said. “I’ve managed to go home, sleep and change my chain.”

I stopped beside him.

“What about the crane?”

“Still there. We secured the sail this morning. Put up a proper

barrier, so it won't blow away along with the prohibition. I'm off shift today."

Marta wound down the van window.

"Are you coming with us?"

"As far as the old coaching house. Then I turn off to my mother's. I'll be back by evening."

Inside the bundle was a table lamp. Semyon had repaired the switch and was going to take it to his mother. I looked at the bicycle, then at the lamp.

"You can put it in with us."

"I can. But I'll ride alongside."

"Don't you trust us?"

“I want to stretch my legs. I sit down almost all day at work. People think lifting big things makes you more active yourself.”

The bicycle creaked on every second turn of the pedals. I wanted to ride beside him, but at that speed Maybe began to take offence and stalled. In the end we agreed to meet at the turnings. At the first I waited seven minutes, at the second eleven. Between these waits the road never quite had time to become an adventure: there was always a car to let past, a pothole to go round, a petrol station to pull into.

The petrol station sold travel magazines. On one cover a man

stood at the edge of a mountain with his back to the obvious practical difficulties. I flicked through the magazine. Not one photograph showed a person searching for change to pay for petrol.

Marta filled the van, noted the expense and handed me the receipt.

“Half is yours.”

“Even if we’re travelling on a matter of public importance?”

“The petrol doesn’t know that yet.”

Semyon arrived after I had counted my money twice. He bought a bottle of water and sat on the kerb. We settled down

beside him. Nika was eating one of the sandwiches her grandmother had left and watching a man by the tyre pressure machine.

“He’s going to come over,” she said.

The man did indeed come over. He wore a clean short-sleeved shirt, although it had turned cool after the rain.

“Is it you?” he asked me.

I glanced round at Marta.

“That depends what’s happened already.”

“The one who saved the mill.”

“So far we’ve postponed the decision.”

“That’s right. Saved it. We’ve got a problem too.”

He spoke quickly, pointing constantly to somewhere across the road. The entrance to his shop had been closed off because, since the roadworks, lorries had begun turning right beside the school crossing. The shop had to take deliveries through the yard, and that was inconvenient. The man wanted me to help “set things right in a decent, human way”.

“Do children walk there?” asked Marta.

“Children walk everywhere. That’s no reason to leave a business without access.”

He took out his telephone and showed us a photograph of a concrete block. In the photograph the block did indeed look guilty: alone, grey, in the middle of a flat open space.

“What’s behind the photographer?” asked Semyon.

“What do you mean?”

“Have you got a picture from the other side?”

It turned out that on the other side was the school gate. It also turned out that the shop could perfectly well receive vehicles through the yard if an old shelter was moved. He was reluctant to part with the shelter because it had only recently been built. I

could see the conversation growing more and more unpleasant for the man who had begun it with hope.

“You want me to get the entrance reopened?” I asked, to be clear.

“To help. You’re on people’s side, aren’t you?”

Saying exactly which people’s side I was on just then proved harder than declaring myself a defender of humanity. I laid the telephone on the bonnet of his car.

“I don’t know how to assess an access route like that. I can look at the requests you’ve submitted and find out who they were

passed to. But I won't promise to get the entrance opened."

The man took back his telephone.

"I see. A mill's prettier."

He went away, and I felt ashamed. Then ashamed of wanting to run after him and earn back his good opinion.

Semyon finished his water.

"He didn't lie to you about the inconvenience," he said. "The inconvenience is real enough."

"And the rest?"

"The rest you need to see from both sides. That's why one camera isn't enough on a crane."

I looked back at the shop. Beside the blocked entrance a woman

was leading a boy by the hand. The boy was trying to step only on the white stripes of the crossing, and the woman was not hurrying him. For a second they both disappeared behind the concrete block.

We went on.

The old coaching house stood in a hollow. Once horses had been supplied there, then carts had been repaired, then it had been used as a store for road signs. Now a family lived in one half of the building, which they rented, while the other half still housed signs. In the yard stood three no-overtaking signs, a temporary bus stop and one sign pointing to the sea. The sea was much too far

away, even on the most benevolent map.

Semyon greeted a woman hanging out washing. She brought him a mug of water and asked about his mother. Then she saw me.

“Are you a musician?”

“Sometimes.”

“Our school amplifier isn’t working. The children are performing tomorrow. Could you take a look?”

I was already reaching for the bass guitar, as though the instrument could answer a question about wiring for me. Marta looked into the back of the

van, where the tools lay, and sighed.

“Show me. But I’ll tell you now: I may not be able to mend it.”

The amplifier stood on a kitchen stool in the former stable. Beside it, a boy of about sixteen was untangling a cable. He explained that during rehearsal the sound had disappeared, then a noise had started up as though someone had switched on a small power station inside it. We plugged everything into a socket we had checked. The amplifier hissed, but words spoken into the microphone could still be heard.

“This isn’t my field,” said Marta after examining it. “You need someone who repairs sound

equipment. I'm not going to poke around at random."

The boy's shoulders drooped. The younger classes were supposed to sing in the yard the next day. No one wanted to cancel, and there was no money for other equipment.

"How many children?" I asked.

"Twenty-two."

"And how many in the audience?"

"If all the parents come, about sixty."

I looked at the yard, the walls and the open-sided shelter.

"Let's listen without the amplifier first."

The boy put the microphone aside doubtfully. He called two girls who were helping their mother with the washing. We put them by the wall, then under the shelter, then back by the wall, a little further from the corner. Nika stood by the gate and raised her hand whenever she could no longer make out the words. I did not conduct: I only asked them not to shout over one another and moved a bench. They sang a school song they knew; I did not know the words and made no attempt to pretend I did.

In the end they could be heard by the wall. Not equally well by everyone. We decided to leave the first two rows for the elderly

and let the little ones sit on blankets at the front. The boy wrote down where to put the benches.

“And if it rains?”

We looked at the sky. Marta pointed to the shelter.

“Then two smaller performances. Or postpone it. You’ll have to decide in the morning.”

The woman brought out a plate of warm potatoes. I was about to decline, but Semyon had already sat down at the table and was unwrapping the salt.

Over lunch it emerged that he had once gone to Marta’s father to learn how to use an old winch. Pavel would not let him touch the

handle until Semyon could name everyone standing near the load.

“I thought it was a memory test,” said Semyon. “He made me walk round the site first. The fourth time I realised that people had time to move.”

Marta ran her spoon round the edge of her plate.

“He didn’t talk to me like that.”

“How did he talk to you?”

“He said, ‘I won’t be long.’ Perhaps he didn’t know the right way to teach someone to wait.”

Semyon put down his bread.

“He let me down once too. Didn’t come for an inspection. His mother had fallen ill, I found out

afterwards. But he didn’t tell me, and I stood there for half a day.”

Marta looked up.

“I didn’t know.”

“I haven’t told you everything about him. People usually tell you what someone taught them.”

Something softened in her face, but she did not thank him. Meanwhile, Nika was drawing a little roof on the map. Beside it she wrote: “You can hear here without wires.” Then she crossed out “here” and made it more precise: “By the wall, if it’s quiet.”

Before we left, we carried the amplifier out of the damp stable and into the house, and the boy wrote down the number of a

workshop where it could be taken. Then he went to arrange the benches by the wall. I helped carry the last one. The boy told me to put it a little further to the left, looked from the gate and was satisfied.

At the fork Semyon took back his lamp. We helped him tie it to the carrier. He checked the ropes, then checked them again. I asked whether he regretted signing as a witness.

“I’ll know this evening,” he said. “The boss wanted to give me the Saturday shift. Now it probably won’t happen.”

“Because of me?”

“Because of the postponement. But you asked for it.”

I lowered my eyes. Semyon adjusted the bundle.

“Don’t pretend just now that you know how to make it up to me. Just remember that delay costs someone something too.”

He rode off along the side road. The lamp swayed on the carrier but was firmly secured. At the bend Semyon raised his hand without looking back.

We watched him until the bicycle disappeared behind the bushes. Then Marta got into the van, Nika fastened her seat belt, and I started Maybe. Riding turned out to be easier when I didn't have to try to look like a horseman.

7. The Road They Forgot to Draw

After ten kilometres the main road went to the right, and our map suggested continuing straight ahead.

Straight ahead, grass was growing.

Not everywhere: along the edges two wheel tracks could still be made out, with stiff stalks sticking up between them. Further on, beyond a low rise, something like water gleamed.

Nika got out of the van and spread the map on the bonnet. The paper billowed in the wind. I held it down with my palm,

covering precisely the turning we needed.

“Could you not hold the river down?” she asked.

I moved my hand onto the hare.

In Yakov’s notebook the road was confidently marked with a broad pencil line. On Nika’s sheet it had come out thin and uneven. The telephone suggested turning round, driving twenty-seven kilometres and returning to almost the same point from the other side.

“So we’ve found the forgotten way,” I said.

Marta looked at the water ahead.

“Or an old drainage channel. We don’t drive until we’ve looked.”

We walked to the rise. The water turned out to be a large puddle, but the roadbed beneath it had softened. Marta prodded the ground with a long branch. The branch went in deeper than I would have liked.

I began to explain that the motorcycle could get round the edge. She nodded.

“Possibly. And the van?”

I looked at Nika. She stood on a dry patch, holding the map in both hands.

“We could send you round the other way,” I suggested.

“And where would you end up on your own?”

I had an excellent answer to that: wherever the road led. At once it seemed an awkward way to arrange a meeting place.

To the left ran the fence of a garden plot. Behind it a man was laying a pane of window glass on a frame. We greeted him and asked whether we could drive through here to the river.

He put down the glass, took off his gloves and came over to the fence.

“Depends what you’re in. And what for.”

I began with the mill, but he raised his palm.

“That can wait. What are you in?”

We pointed to the vehicles.

“The van will get stuck. The little bridge further on collapsed back in spring. You can go by the upper track, behind the water tower. Only the gate there is mine.”

I felt relieved and had already decided that the obstacle had been found in the person of the gate’s owner. All we had to do was come to an arrangement with him, and the forgotten road would be open again.

“Could you unlock it?”

“I could. But there’s a ditch; I dug it out yesterday. We’d have to lay boards over it first.”

The man spoke without irritation. He was clearly accustomed to

travellers who, on seeing a lock, stopped noticing anything else.

His name was Arkady. The gardens along the old road belonged to different people. When the regular bus service was cancelled, the ditches stopped being cleared. Three owners had agreed to maintain the upper track; a fourth had sold his plot, and a fifth lived in another town. Sometimes machinery came, but it went only as far as the place covered by its contract. After that the water carried the responsibility further on by itself.

Arkady showed us the low ground beyond the gardens. A little wooden bridge lay there, or

rather half of one. The other half had been washed into the bushes.

“Don’t go over there,” he told Nika.

“I wasn’t going to.”

“Good. Then we’ve agreed without shouting.”

He brought two boards out of the shed, but Marta dismissed them at once: too thin for the wheels. Arkady fetched others. We spent a long time trying to judge what would take a small van and eventually decided not to guess. We could reverse round the garden to the upper road on firm gravel without crossing the ditch, if we moved three crates and took a gate off its hinges.

It took almost an hour. With the owner's permission, Nika gathered fallen apples from the track so that the wheels would not crush them. I carried the crates; one turned out to be much heavier than the others. It held not apples but iron parts.

"You could have labelled it," I said, putting the crate down.

Arkady pointed to the lid. It said "Iron".

"I thought it was an old crate."

"The crate is old. So's the iron."

When the way was clear, we stopped beside the gate we had lifted off. I asked whether Arkady needed a witness to help get the road back onto the official plan.

He wiped his hands on his trousers.

“I do. Only don’t promise me a bus tomorrow. First I need an answer about who’s going to clear the pipe under the embankment.”

Marta wrote down the plot number and the location of the pipe. Nika added the upper track to the map with a dotted line. Beside it she wrote: “Private. Ask. Check after rain.”

Arkady looked at the paper.

“Good. Otherwise you’ll draw a road and the whole town will come driving through my place.”

He gave us a bag of apples and made me promise to let him

know whether we reached the river. I took down his number. We had not saved the road. But now I knew whose voice would answer if I dialled those digits.

Beyond the gardens the ground rose. The van went slowly, bouncing on the gravel, and I kept my distance to avoid swallowing dust. Now and then the valley appeared through the trees. The river shone in it, narrow from up here and probably quite different down below.

At one point we stopped beside an old signpost. Two letters survived on it: “Ba”. The rest had faded.

“Two Banks,” Marta read.

“How do you know?”

“We came here when I was a child. Father used to bring parts to the pumping station. I’d sit beside him, angry because I wasn’t allowed to touch the levers.”

She ran her finger along the board.

“He promised to show me the bridge. We didn’t have time then. It was already dark when we drove back.”

Nika asked where her grandmother’s sister had lived. We took out the photographs of the notebook and the old address. The house was on the near bank, in a street that had been renamed

twice. The telephone recognised the latest name but did not know the first. On Yakov's sketch the street ended in a circle marking a well.

"Don't they rename wells?" asked Nika.

"I'm not sure," I said. "But usually less often."

She rang her grandmother. First she told her about the van, the pies, Semyon and the road. Vera Pavlovna listened, then asked her to pass the telephone to Marta. Marta went a few paces away. I heard "by evening", "we'll book" and "two separate rooms", and realised that grown-ups' journeys also consist of conversations that

do not look like adventure even from a distance.

Nika stood by the signpost, fiddling with the corner of the paper.

“Are you expecting the house still to be there?” I asked.

“I don’t know.”

“We can look from the road first.”

She nodded.

“Only if there are other people there, don’t tell them straight away that they’re living in our past.”

I looked at her. She blushed.

“That’s what Grandma said. When I wanted to write to the

new owners and ask them not to change anything."

Marta came back, returned the telephone and checked that we had enough water. We each took a few sips. Arkady's apples turned out to be sour. Nika said that Aunt Sonya used to make a thick jam from apples like those, but she herself had not liked it. For some reason I was glad of this detail: the disliked jam brought the dead woman closer than all the proper things I might have said about her.

The road began to descend. Halfway down the slope, Maybe started rattling as though a whole box of spoons had woken up inside him. I stopped and waved

to Marta. She drove up, listened and told me to switch off the engine.

The luggage rack's fastening had worked loose. The bass guitar's case was knocking against the rear grab handle. While I held the torch, Marta fitted a washer and tightened the nut. Nika sat on a stone with one boot off: it had filled with dirt.

"Your father would be pleased," I said to Marta.

She stopped turning the spanner.

"You didn't know him."

"I meant…"

"I know what you meant. Only I don't know myself whether he'd

be pleased. He didn't much like me taking his tools."

She went back to the nut. I held the light steadier.

After a while she said:

"I like mending things. That's mine. You don't have to take me back to him every time."

"All right."

"Will you remember?"

"I'll try."

She checked the luggage rack and handed me the spanner.

"Keep this yourself. In case the trying runs out before the road does."

I put the spanner in my pocket. It was warm from her hand.

Towards evening we reached the first houses. The little town of Two Banks did indeed consist of two banks, between which the river flowed looking as though it knew nothing of any need to form a single whole. On our side stood a school, a shop and several houses with gardens. On the other, steeper bank, the market, town hall and a chapel without a bell crowded together.

The bridge was visible at once. Narrow and old, with iron railings and a new barrier across the entrance. Someone had put a pot of flowers beside the barrier. A ferry was coming towards us from the opposite bank.

First we found the street with the well. Aunt Sonya's house turned out to be yellow, not green as Nika remembered. Two young trees grew by the gate, and the old pear tree was gone. The smell of frying fish came through the window. A woman in rubber gloves came out to throw away some water and noticed us.

Marta said hello. Nika stood silently. I was trying very hard to be silent too.

"Are you looking for someone?" asked the woman.

"My great-aunt used to live here," said Nika. "Sofya Pavlovna."

“Yes. We bought the house from her son. Would you like to come in?”

Nika shook her head.

“Could I just look at the well?”

The woman opened the gate. The well had a new lid but its old handle. Nika ran her fingers over it. The owner said they used mains water now, but had not filled in the well: last summer it had come in useful for the whole lane. Then she asked whether Sofya Pavlovna had liked the flowers with little blue cups. They came up by the shed every year, and she did not know whether to weed them out.

“I don’t know what they’re called,” Nika answered. “But she used to water them from a cup.”

“Then we’ll leave them,” said the woman. “I like them myself.”

She did not promise to keep the whole house as it had been. Nika did not ask. We thanked her and left. On the map the girl changed the colour of the roof. She did not rub out the pear tree, but wrote beside it the year when it had still been standing.

The lamps by the river were already lit. I sent Arkady a short message to say we had arrived and received a photograph of the closed gates in reply. Underneath it said: “Thanks for putting the gate back straight.”

The ferry nudged the bank. On deck a man in a dark jacket caught up a rope and tossed it over a mooring post. He waited for two passengers to get off, then nodded to us.

“Across?”

I looked at the bridge, the barrier, the river. On today’s journey we had spent more time stopping than travelling. I wanted at last to reach somewhere something big would happen.

“Across,” I said.

Marta asked us to find out where we could spend the night first.

Part II: The Road of Proper Things

8. The Bridge Between Two Banks

The ferryman said we should ask Lida about somewhere to stay: she was inspecting the bridge just then. We left the vehicles by the landing and went up a short flight of steps. Nika went first, holding the handrail. Two kinds of map were on sale beside the bridge. On one, Two Banks was shown as a single town; on the other, as two, with a river between them so wide that the paper had to be folded to accommodate it. The seller kept his maps under glass,

their corners weighted with batteries.

“Is it for travelling or for proving a point?” he asked.

“Travelling.”

“Then you’d do better to ask.”

He pointed behind us, at a woman with a long measuring rod. She was walking along the bridge, stopping at every post. She laid the rod against the decking, wrote something in a notebook and would not move on until she was certain the figure was legible. A barrier stood across the middle of the bridge. The woman reached it, leaned out over the water and came back.

Below, the river carried the evening light. I had always thought you could see the whole of the opposite bank: there were the trees, there were the houses, everything plain enough. Here the bridge hid part of the bank in its shadow, and vapour rose from the water. On our side there was a smell of frying onions. From the other came a knocking: someone was taking crates apart.

“Can’t we cross?” I asked.

“No,” said the woman.

“Not even on foot?”

“I wouldn’t recommend falling on foot either.”

She propped the rod against the hut and took off her glasses.

There were white lines where the arms had been.

“Lida. I’m in charge of inspections. Who have you come to see?”

Marta told her about the mill, the old signalling network and the station logbook. I was already taking out the notice granting the extension, but she put a hand on my arm. Lida was listening without any paperwork. When Marta mentioned the four notes, the woman glanced at the case over my shoulder.

“Are you a musician?”

“When circumstances call for it.”

“Well, what we need at the moment is someone who can test

a telephone cable. When circumstances call for it."

She smiled, so that we would not mistake her for another Office.

The book, Lida said, had survived in a room above the pumping station. But there was no point going there that evening: the duty shift was busy preparing for work on the upper spillway. Saturday morning would be easier. In the meantime we could stay with her aunt on the left bank. To get there, we would have to go down to the ferry.

"Why is the bridge closed?" Nika asked.

Lida opened her notebook. On the page were three drawings of the

same pier, each slightly more crooked than the last.

“The ground gave way in winter. The pier sank. You can hardly see it in a photograph, so everyone thinks I’m being difficult.”

“Not everyone,” said a man who had been silently choosing a map. “I think you closed it too late.”

Lida turned towards him.

“Too late. I should have insisted in January.”

He stopped shuffling the sheets. He had evidently prepared for an argument and now did not know what to do with his preparations.

“My wife’s leg still hurts,” he said.

“I know. Tell her I’ll call round tomorrow.”

He bought the map on which the town was one town and went off along the embankment.

I wanted to ask why nobody was repairing the bridge, but Lida was already explaining to Nika what had happened to the road marked on her sheet. She was not in the habit of talking over the girl’s head. She laid the notebook on the parapet and traced the diversion with her finger: down to the ferry, across the river, then along the warehouse. A direct crossing would have cut the journey to almost a third. Lida knew that better than anyone.

On the way down we met a woman carrying two empty milk cans.

“Getting ready to open it again?” she asked, seeing the rod. “I don’t want any of your ceremonies. Get the underneath sorted first.”

“We’re not, Antonina.”

“Mind you don’t. My son drives his lorry over there. He’ll say he can get across. Don’t you believe him.”

She went off, the lids clattering. I remembered the crane on the mill hill, and Marta, who had been the first to see it as a crane. I was beginning to think I had mastered that useful skill.

The ferry lay in a low wooden recess by the bank. It was broad, flat-bottomed and had once been painted green. Now only the wheelhouse was still green. On deck lay two car tyres and a broom with a surprisingly new handle.

Roman, the ferryman, put down his mug and looked Maybe over.

“Won’t leak, will it?”

“Out or in?” I asked.

“The first concerns me more.”

First Marta followed his signals and drove the van into the middle of the deck, switched off the engine and applied the handbrake. Roman chocked the wheels with wooden blocks. Then

Marta checked the tap on Maybe's tank. We stopped the engine and wheeled the motorcycle up the gangway. Roman showed us where to set it at right angles to the side and what to secure it to. I took the bass off my back: the sight of the water had suddenly reminded me that wood does not float in all the circumstances in which one might wish it to.

Nika helped a woman with a shopping basket carry a heavy parcel across the gangway. Jars clinked inside. The woman called the girl the captain's assistant. Roman corrected her at once:

"A passenger. I'd have to pay an assistant."

The wheelhouse smelt of wet felt. The ferry pulled away, and the town, which a minute earlier had seemed cut in two, began moving around us as a whole. Houses slowly changed places; a mast on the right bank disappeared behind a bell tower on the left. Three fishermen sat by the bridge, although above them hung a sign prohibiting fishing, parking and certain unspecified intentions.

“If they mend the bridge, will you be out of work?” I asked Roman.

He looked at me as one looks at a man who has decided to take an interest in your life before paying his fare.

“There’ll be other work. In summer I take people upriver to their vegetable plots. In winter I build boats. And with the bridge, my mother will be able to walk to the doctor on her own. She can’t get down those steps now.”

“That wasn’t what I meant.”

“It’s what you said.”

I paid. Roman gave me a ticket, damp along one edge, and went back to the wheel.

In the middle of the river, Lida pointed upstream. Between the poplars we could see a concrete wall and several low buildings.

“They’re testing the gates there tomorrow. The water will flow differently from usual. Not a

great deal, but they'll notice it on the lower plots."

"Have people been warned?"

"We've put notices up. Sent messages. Roman's told the people whose phones don't work."

The ferryman did not turn round.

"Everyone I could find. Lyubov Fedotovna sleeps at her plot. I'll tell her again today."

"What about the old network?" Marta asked.

"There's a wire left across the water. And a horn at the school. The last cable broke with the bridge. Signals used to be repeated from the high bank.

Now they assume everyone will read a message."

Roman tapped his jacket pocket.

"My phone's told me three times about getting my tyres changed and not once about the water. It's a good thing I know how to listen to Lida without a phone."

Lida winced. Plainly she knew about this fault, and did not find it at all amusing.

Waiting at the landing were a cyclist, a sack of flour and a boy of about seven whose grandmother was holding him firmly by the hood. Roman first tied up the ferry, checked the gangway and only then let us disembark. Those in a hurry had

time both to become indignant and to calm down again. I watched him take the woman's basket and thought there was something of a good musician in his movements: not a wasted effort, an exact knowledge of someone else's weight. I did not dare say so aloud. After the conversation about the bridge, I had little trust left to draw on.

Lida's aunt lived above a former bakery. Her name was Taisia. Before asking our names, she asked whether everyone ate cabbage. We were given two rooms, and a folding bed was put in one of them for Nika. Marta called Vera and handed the phone to the girl. Nika explained

in detail why the bridge could not be opened, even though you could see which way to go in both directions. Then Vera asked Marta to confirm that none of the bed’s springs was broken.

“None broken,” said Marta, feeling along the edge. “One’s stretched. We’ll put a board underneath.”

“Now I believe you,” Vera replied.

Over supper, Lida spread an old plan across the table. Four stations were marked on it. Our mill stood at the very edge, almost beyond the fold. Short arcs spread from each point, like marks left by a cup.

“Is that how far they could be heard?” I asked.

“In theory. And these little crosses are the places where people couldn’t hear. For some reason they didn’t make it onto the nice copy.”

Nika drew the paper towards her. Crockery clinked on the other side of the wall; from the river came the long blast of the ferry’s horn on its last crossing. I took out my notice. Next Thursday, noon. Five full days remained before the deadline, and the rest of an evening I had already grown used to counting as spare.

Lida looked at the clock.

“There’s a gathering in the square tomorrow morning. Come along. People will tell you where they can’t hear. Just don’t begin by saying you’re about to save them.”

I folded the paper and put it in my pocket.

“I’ll try.”

“Better have something to eat,” said Taisia. “Even after they’ve been saved, people still need their washing-up done.”

After supper I took my place at the sink. Through the open window I could see the bridge, closed at both ends. A separate lamp shone on each bank. The water between them remained dark; you could make out its movement only by the reflections, breaking and stretching out again beneath the piers.

9. The Square of Festivals Already Held

In the morning Taisia woke us with the smell of bread. The bakery beneath her rooms had long since closed, but she still fired the kitchen oven faithfully, explaining that they had taken the sign off the house, not off her hands. Nika was asleep with her nose buried in her own jacket. Marta sat down beside her, called her softly and only then opened the shutters.

First we went to the river market. Marta handed Yakov’s parcel to the person whose name was written on the wrapping, obtained a receipt and sent a

photograph of it to the innkeeper. He replied almost at once: “Arrived. Thank you.” Only then did we walk to the square, where a string of faded flags was being stretched between the trees. They were made of good cloth and had survived so many rainstorms that they now looked like coloured handkerchiefs. Three display boards had been set up beneath the clock. One read: “Bridge Opening Festival.” Another: “Ten Years of Uninterrupted Communication.” The third: “Our Shared Tomorrow.”

All three had photographs.

“Are they celebrating today?” I asked.

“Today they’re showing how they celebrated,” Lida replied. “There was no money for anything new. There was money for keeping the old.”

Yevgenia, the caretaker of the local House of Culture, was attaching a card with a date to one of the boards. She heard us and turned round with drawing pins in her mouth.

“Would you rather it had all been thrown away?”

I hastened to assure her that I would not. Yevgenia took the pins out, put them in a box and explained that the older people themselves asked for the photographs to be displayed. Many had no other pictures left.

At the opening of the bridge they were still standing beside those who had later died or moved away. Names were written on the back of the third board, and every summer someone would come along who recognised an unlabelled person.

I went round the board. Behind the grand promise of a shared tomorrow, small handwriting read: “Far left, in the white cap, probably Pyotr from the forestry office. Check.”

Nika was already studying the bridge in the photograph. It was intact, with a string of little boats passing beneath it. On a platform by the pier, a woman in a dark

dress held something like a small funnel to her lips.

“Is that a signal?” Nika asked.

Lida bent down.

“A hand-held speaking trumpet. But I don’t know who the woman is.”

“I do,” said Roman. “But help me move the table first. I’ve already taken the lighter end.”

He had brought two boards and folding legs. On the table Yevgenia set a flask, a stack of paper cups and a box of photographs for which there had been no room on the boards. People did not arrive in ranks or at an appointed minute. Some stayed for a cup of tea; others

said, “Yes, that’s my uncle,” and went off to buy bread.

Roman found a better picture. The woman with the speaking trumpet stood in profile, the wind pressing her dress against her knees. Behind her, two men were unrolling a wire.

“Ada Severina,” he said. “Taught music at the railway school. She made those signals too. My mother sang with her until her voice gave out.”

Marta took the photograph by its white border.

“Does she live here?”

“Beyond the settlement, in the school building. If she’s at home.

She has pupils all over the valley. Goes to one, then another.”

I felt a familiar relief: our road now had a person at its end. A person is always easier than a cause. You can find them, ask them, persuade them, then tell yourself that everything now depends on them.

Lida brought a portable loudspeaker out of the hut. It wheezed, said half her name and stopped.

“There,” remarked a man in a checked cap. “Exactly the same the day before yesterday.”

“I’ve brought a spare battery,” she replied.

“You didn’t the day before yesterday.”

Marta asked for the device. While she checked the connector, Lida explained to those gathered that we wanted to ask them about the old signals and try a few notes in the square. This was not an alarm, not a message about the water; simply a test, of which the surrounding shops had been warned in advance. Work on the upper section would follow a separate schedule, and afterwards she would read the official warning out again.

“Will you play?” Marta asked.

I took the bass out of its case. Without an amplifier it was a homely little thing: my fingers

slid along the smooth fingerboard and the wood answered against my stomach. It was not enough for a crowd. Roman brought an empty crate and suggested resting the bottom of the instrument on it, as people once used to do with small radios. The sound became clearer beside the table, but already by the display board people were craning their necks.

“I can see you’re playing,” said Yevgenia. “As for what, I’m still guessing.”

So I sang the four notes. Roman joined in, lower at first, then finding a comfortable pitch. He had a quiet, rough-edged voice. The woman with the shopping

basket whom we had met on the ferry answered him from the other side of the table. In her voice the third note rose a little higher. I nearly corrected her, but Marta touched my elbow.

“Wait.”

The woman finished. From beneath a tree came a reply from a young man holding his little daughter’s hand. He did not sing: he simply tapped a coin against the railings. His daughter laughed and repeated the tapping with her palms.

It was disorderly. Two people began together, one did not understand when to answer, and someone else decided the tune needed finishing and added a

pretty flourish. I felt the irritation you feel when the people you are trying so hard for will not help you try.

“Once more,” I suggested. “Just listen.”

“We are listening,” said the woman with the basket. “You’re not hearing all of us.”

Her words hit closer to the mark than I would have liked. I lowered my hand.

Lida asked people to answer one at a time, naming the place from which the sound had come. Not to guess the notes, but to confirm that the signal had reached someone at all. Nika unfolded her map of the square. We stationed

three people at the entrances and one by the bread shop, round the corner. Roman took a metal mug. Yevgenia waved a white napkin to the person standing beside the road: there the noise of engines swallowed the voice.

There was no answer from the shop.

I repeated it louder.

Silence.

Nika looked at Marta, waited for her nod and ran round the corner. She came back with the baker, who was wiping his hands on his apron.

“I heard,” he said. “Only I’ve got both hands in dough. And I can’t

see anyone. Who am I supposed to answer?”

He was marked on the map. The man in the cap admitted that he could barely hear in his left ear. To make out what was happening, he needed to face the person speaking. Two people in the back row had not understood at all why we left an empty space after the fourth note: they thought I had run out of breath.

The test took more than an hour. Nika drew arrows, crossed them out, drew them again. On her sheet the square ceased to be a neat rectangle and sprouted projections, dead ends and other people’s windows. A man who arrived later asked her to draw in

a passage to a well that was not on the plan.

Meanwhile, Lida read out the real warning. From noon until four, the low-lying areas below the pumping station were to be kept clear. No strolling down to have a look, no searching for things lost in the grass. Roman repeated the announcement for those arriving on the ferry.

Lyubov Fedotovna, a slight, wiry woman with two baskets of potted flowers, moved one of them irritably.

“I can’t leave them there overnight. The nights are cold already.”

“We’ll manage before noon,” Roman said. “Put them on the upper shelf in the shed. As soon as I’ve finished my crossing.”

“You’ll forget.”

“I’m writing it down in front of you.”

He took out a notebook, wrote it down and let her look. She checked the entry over her glasses, as though accepting a receipt for something far more valuable than a few dozen pots.

After the gathering a man with a camera came up to me.

“Are you the Last everyone’s talking about?”

I said I was, according to the paperwork.

“May I take a picture for the local paper?”

I agreed and stood beside the bass. He asked me to lift my head so the sign behind me could be read in full. It said, “Our Shared Tomorrow.” I noticed, but did not move away. After the ragged singing, it was pleasant to find myself in a frame where everything was already properly arranged.

Marta was watching from the far end of the square. Then she helped Yevgenia carry the table away without calling me. For another few minutes I answered questions: about the mill, the extension, our journey. I said the old network could be restored.

Somehow the word “test” got lost in that conversation.

When we finally gathered to go to the pumping station, Nika showed me her map.

“You can’t hear from here. And here you can hear, but you can’t answer. Those are different.”

I praised her attentiveness and did not look at the second sheet. On it she had written down, separately, the words of people who did not want to rely on a shared signal again.

Lida coiled the cable of the repaired loudspeaker. In the distance, beyond the poplars, a large engine started up. Its steady hum set the water in a paper cup faintly trembling. I disliked that sound even before I learnt what it was doing.

10. The First Real Giant

The pumping station was larger than it had looked from the river. From a distance only the upper windows were visible, with the lower floor hidden in the slope. Now we stood at the fence, and the wall dropped away towards a broad collection basin where an old car inner tube was slowly turning.

Not all the machines were humming. One ran steadily; another was switched on briefly from time to time. When it started, I felt a faint vibration through the soles of my feet. Inside, behind the tall windows, people in ear defenders moved

about. Their faces were indistinguishable; their yellow jackets, all alike under the lamps, seemed to be parts of the machinery.

A broad-shouldered man with grey stubble met us at the wicket gate.

“Zotov, the shift supervisor,” Lida introduced him. “This is about the old book.”

“Not the best time.”

“I know. I’ll get it myself. Just open the cupboard.”

He looked at us, at the case, at Nika.

“No unauthorised people inside. Will you wait here? Stand clear of

the drive. There's a vehicle coming."

We moved away. Nika immediately sat on a concrete block beside the van, took out her second sheet of the square and began adding things from memory. Marta opened the side door to get some water. I stayed by the wire fence.

Zotov did not leave at once. Lida explained which mill we were trying to preserve. He asked whether we had a report on the shaft support. I said the survey had yet to be done.

"Start with that, then."

"We're gathering evidence of its usefulness to the public."

“Usefulness is good. Provided nothing falls on it from above.”

There was no mockery in his voice. That was more irritating: I knew how to argue with mockery, but I was less successful with someone who was both busy and right.

Marta asked about the station’s work. Zotov gestured towards the low roofs across the river.

“If we stop for long, they’ll have water in their cellars. And the upper gate needs repairing. So today we’re taking part of the flow here, a little at a time. Passing it through the side channel, keeping the level below those vegetable plots. Wind, rain, inflow: we take everything into

account. It's not a tap on a washbasin."

He glanced at his watch and called Lida. They went through the gate, which swung shut on its spring. He kept the key.

I walked along the wire. From the lower area I could see a rectangular gate and a footbridge over the channel. The old part of the station was built of dark brick, with a concrete box added beside it and another, metal one on top. The building had grown storeys and pipes as though, for many years, it had been trying to manage its appointed work by giving itself more arms.

A bird sat on the roof. It puffed out its throat, but could not be heard.

“A giant,” I said.

Marta came over with a bottle of water.

“Don’t start.”

“I mean the size.”

“Then yes.”

She handed me the bottle and stayed beside me. I wanted to talk to her about the photograph in the square, to explain how the newspaper might help the mill. But Marta was examining the fence fixings.

“There’s been high water here recently,” she said. “See how high the rubbish is caught.”

“And they’re letting more through.”

“They’re diverting it. Zotov has just explained.”

“Towards where people grow food.”

Marta turned her head towards me.

“Did you hear how much water there’ll be?”

“I heard what they promise.”

“That’s all we know so far.”

I said nothing. It seemed to me that she was too ready to take someone else’s side. Yesterday, by

Arkady's garden, I had patiently carried crates and waited while she checked the road. Today, after the photograph, I wanted once again to do something that could be shown without a lengthy explanation. There was little time left until Thursday, and my folder still contained mostly other people's doubts. I was already dividing people into sides, although that morning I had intended to learn from them how to listen.

Beyond the fence, a yellow light came on. The engine changed pitch. On the footbridge one worker waved to another, who answered and took hold of the handrail. Below, beside the

water, a pale slit opened and gradually widened. The flow passed through the concrete throat, leaving foam on the walls.

A small maintenance lorry drove down from above. A young worker came out to open the large gates. He pulled one leaf back, then the other, called, “Back a little,” to us and turned his attention to the vehicle, which had little room to turn.

Then someone shouted below.

I could not make out the words. I saw Roman on the riverside path. He stood beside his little workboat, waving to someone beyond the bushes. Nearby, Lyubov Fedotovna was moving with a basket. At that distance I

could not tell whether she was hurrying or simply walking over uneven ground.

I called to the worker at the gates.

“There are people down there!”

He looked down, then back at me.

“Wait outside the fence!”

“People down below!”

He raised his palm. Not threateningly, simply asking me to stop. But I was already hearing: do not get in the way of us doing what we have been told.

I could have called Marta. I could have waited for Lida, who was twenty paces away behind a wall. I could have shown the worker the precise spot and made certain

he understood. Afterwards I went through these possibilities so many times that each had time to become a separate memory of something I had not done.

I walked through the open gates.

The lorry stood between me and the lower platform. Its body hid me from Marta for a few seconds. Someone called to me. I quickened my pace so that I could explain everything to the man at the mechanism, rather than to someone who would send me outside again.

The platform smelt of hot metal. A man in ear defenders was working beside a closed protective frame. He was looking through the grille at an indicator,

one hand beside the intercom. I told him about Roman and the woman. He did not hear. I repeated it louder and touched his shoulder.

The man stepped back and pointed behind me.

“Get back!”

At that same moment another shout rose from below. Roman was holding out an oar to Lyubov Fedotovna to help her across a wet ditch. I know now what he was doing. Then it looked to me as though the woman was being swept away.

I pointed down. The worker looked, said something into the intercom. He acted quickly, but

not as quickly as the picture already formed in my head demanded. I saw water, a man behind a grille, an enclosed control unit. There was no longer room for anything else.

At the side of the protective frame was a long lever with a worn handle. I decided it could stop the flow at once. Why I decided that, I could not afterwards explain even to myself. Red paint on metal seemed sufficient knowledge.

The worker caught my sleeve.

“Don’t touch it!”

I pulled my arm free.

It was the most precise movement I made all day. I did it

deliberately. Something had got in my way, and I removed the obstruction.

At first the lever would not move. I put my whole weight against it. There was a dry click, scarcely audible above the noise of the station. The handle moved too easily. I lost my balance, struck my knee against the edge of the platform and found myself on the ground with a piece of metal in my hand.

The hum changed.

There was no explosion, no flash, no enormous wave that would have explained at once what had happened. Deep inside the mechanism, something gave several short knocks. The yellow

light went out; another lit up beside it. The worker snatched the radio from his belt and ran towards the wall.

I got up.

“I wanted to stop…”

He pushed me towards the fence. This time I did not resist. Below, the water kept flowing. The pale slit grew wider, and the foam stretched beyond the bend, towards the place from which the voices had just come.

Zotov ran out of the building. Behind him came Lida, without her glasses, an open book under her arm. She saw the metal in my hands and stopped mid-step.

“What have you done?”

I said nothing. Now that the question had been asked precisely, I had no precise answer.

Zotov was already speaking into his radio. The young worker shepherded me back to the gates, where Marta stood. She caught me by the jacket, led me clear of the drive and examined my face. Not tenderly. Checking whether I could understand words.

“Nika’s in the cab. You are not to go near her. Stay here.”

She went back to Lida. They exchanged a few sentences I could not catch. Marta pointed to the van and took out her toolbox. Zotov nodded to her and indicated the upper platform.

Marta waited until Lida had taken Nika out of the van and led her to the hut outside the fence, and only then followed him.

I watched through the wire. Inside, people worked, spoke to one another, ran to where they were needed. The huge station no longer looked like a creature. Its separate parts could not coordinate their movements, and people were trying to give them back the ability to act together.

Nika appeared at the hut window. She looked at me through the glass. I wanted to make a reassuring gesture, but both my hands were occupied: in one I was still holding the broken handle, while the other was pressed against my injured knee.

I put the metal on the ground. From beyond the bend in the river came the long, insistent blast of the ferry's horn.

11. A Mistake That Cannot Be Undone

Later it seemed to me that everything had happened at once. In fact, between the first blast of the horn and the moment I saw water on the vegetable plots, there was time to do a great deal. And people did it. A porter was brought out of the low-lying warehouse. Two boys were called away from their fishing. A gardener who could not be reached by phone turned out to be visiting neighbours on the high bank. His boots were found before he was, giving everyone time for a fright.

Lida was speaking into the radio, writing addresses on the back of some announcement. Nika sat beside her in the hut. She was wearing Lida's jacket, much too broad across the shoulders. When I came over, she turned towards the window.

"What should I do?" I asked.

Lida finished speaking and looked at me. Her eyelids were red from the dust.

"Here's a list. You'll go along the upper road with the duty worker. Call the people out of these three houses. Don't go down. Don't do anything on your own initiative. Repeat that."

I repeated it.

The duty worker's name was Artyom. He was the same worker who had opened the gates. He listened to Lida, took a radio and set off without waiting for me. I caught up with him by the poplars.

The first house was empty. We knocked on the windows, rang the number on the list; the owner answered from a shop and said her mother was at her sister's. At the second house we were met by a man in a vest, already holding a parrot cage. He had heard the horns, looked down from his porch and was getting ready to leave. Two pensioners lived in the third. They did not understand

why they could not simply close the cellar door.

Artyom explained calmly. He waited while the woman found her medicine and her husband turned off the cooker. He did not hurry them where haste would only get in the way. I carried their bag. Sewn onto it was the emblem of a sanatorium they had once visited together.

“Something up above again?” the man asked.

“There’s a fault at the station,” Artyom replied.

I opened my mouth to say, “It was me.” But the old man was watching his step, helping his wife across a pothole. He had no

need of my confession just then. I steadied the bag so it would not knock against the woman's knee and walked on in silence.

From the upper road we could see all the vegetable plots. The water was not raging. It occupied the paths between the beds, spreading over them in an even sheen, lifting light planks. Where yesterday there had been dark rectangles of soil, the sky was now reflected. It looked almost beautiful until I recognised Lyubov Fedotovna's basket in one of the floating objects.

Roman was by the shed. She stood beside him in a wet coat, holding her left arm out as though she could not understand

how mud had got onto the sleeve. Roman was talking to a paramedic. His right hand was wrapped in a towel.

I started towards them, but Artyom stopped me.

“We’ll get these people there first.”

We took the elderly couple to the House of Culture. Yevgenia was setting chairs out beneath the photographs of past festivals. The third board lay on its side: it had been blocking the emergency door. Someone had brought a kettle, someone else phone chargers. People gave their names and Yevgenia marked them off in pencil. They were angry, asked about cats, tried to

remember whether they had locked the gate. One woman was ashamed of having come in her slippers.

Back at the river, I found the ferry at the high landing. The usual approach was flooded. Roman sat on the stern bench, holding his bandaged hand against his chest. With his left he was trying to undo a wet button, but the fabric kept slipping. I took a step towards him.

“Don’t,” he said.

I stopped.

The paramedic told Lida that Roman would be taken for an X-ray: severe bruising, a deep cut, the tendons needed checking.

Roman tried to object that he could not leave the ferry. Lida named someone who would take over for the evening. Then he got up.

I walked beside him as far as the car. He did not look at me.

“Roman, this is because of me.”

“I’ve heard.”

“I thought you were being swept away. I wanted…”

He turned so sharply that the paramedic steadied him by his uninjured shoulder.

“I wasn’t being swept away. I was helping her over the ditch. Then the water came. She went back for the basket. I pulled her away

from the shed and the door hit my hand. Shall I go on?”

“No.”

“You need to tell it. Just not to me.”

The car door closed. I stood beside the tyre tracks. The folded paper in my jacket pocket was in the way: my deadline, my mill, my extraordinary office. For the first time in two days I did not want to take it out.

At the station one engine fell silent. The discharge began to lessen. Marta came out through the fence with someone else’s rag over her shoulder. Her hands were shaking from the strain, and she did not get the cap back on

the bottle at once. I wanted to take the bottle, but she tightened the cap herself.

“They’ve brought it under control,” she said. “Now they’ll pump the water off the low ground. Until this evening, perhaps longer.”

“Did you mend it?”

“I helped. Their people did the work. The unit’s been stopped. That doesn’t mean it’s fixed.”

She sat on the concrete block where Nika had been sitting that morning. For a while we looked at the wet mark beneath the lorry.

“But I did see them there,” I said.

Marta leaned forward, her elbows on her knees.

“You saw them. And you heard people calling you. Did you hear me?”

I remembered her voice. Not the words, but the voice, which I could have recognised among the running machines. I had heard it and decided I would explain later.

“Yes.”

She nodded, as though that was precisely what she needed to establish.

“Nika was frightened for you. Then she understood what had happened. Don’t make her comfort you.”

Zotov and Lida came out of the building. A dark streak of oil crossed Zotov's forehead. He carried a bag of broken parts and a report form. My handle lay separately.

"The specialists will investigate," he said. "But this is what we can already see. A fragment got into the drive. The regulator jammed, and the discharge couldn't be reduced when it needed to be. While we were diverting the flow, the water reached the lower plots."

He showed me where I had to write my account.

"And we'll have to give our own. How you reached the unit, why the barrier didn't stop you, why a

part like that broke. That doesn't absolve you of what you did. And what you did doesn't remove our questions."

I thought it generous that he did not intend to hide his own responsibility. Then I understood: he was talking about work that would have to be done anyway. My relief was of no interest to him.

I sat in the hut and wrote that I had passed through the open gates despite being told to remain outside. That the worker had forbidden me to touch the lever. That I had pulled my arm free and hauled on the lever without knowing its purpose. The word "rescue" appeared in the first line

and was crossed out in such a way that it remained legible.

Lida read it. She asked me to add the time and sign every page. Then she gave me a copy.

By evening it was known that nobody had died and nobody was missing. Eight vegetable plots had been damaged, along with the lower store at the ferry shed and part of the boardwalk. The cellars of two houses were wet; the water had not reached the living rooms. Lyubov Fedotovna had lost the flowers she grew for sale. Another owner's sacks of seed had been carried away. The figures changed as people came back and opened their doors.

I offered to pay for everything at once. Zotov gave me a weary look.

“You don’t know how much there is yet.”

We drew up a preliminary list. I wrote down my address and telephone number, agreed to pay for the confirmed damage and, before the assessment, to buy materials for the most urgent repairs. I had enough savings for that, put aside for winter and repairs to the motorcycle. The rest would take time, work and perhaps the sale of things I had not yet even begun to say goodbye to in my mind.

Beside each entry we left room for an amount and confirmation from the owner.

On my way out I saw the bass case leaning against the van. Marta had taken it out of the cab when she fetched her tools. I lifted the case and felt its familiar weight on my shoulder.

Nika came out of the hut. In her hands she held the map, folded in half.

“Just don’t play now,” she said.

“I won’t.”

She sat down beside Marta. I secured the instrument to the motorcycle, checked the straps twice and followed the van back to someone else's house, where that morning we had been given bread.

12. A Return Without Victory

Taisia opened the door before we knocked. She already knew. On the little table in the hall stood a basin, soap and an old sheet torn into strips.

“Shoes first,” she said. “Then hands. Let me see that knee.”

I sat on a stool. While she soaked the dried-on fabric, I clenched my teeth. Taisia noticed and told me not to play the hero: if it hurt, I could say so. I said so. She wet the fabric again and waited.

In the kitchen Marta was talking to Vera. The door was open, and I heard my own action in someone

else's precise account. No great machine, no shout I had taken for a cry for help. A man had entered an operating facility, damaged a device and caused harm to other people. Nika had been outside the working area, with adults. She had not been physically hurt, but she had been frightened.

Vera asked to speak to her granddaughter and for them to be left alone. Marta came out into the corridor and closed the kitchen door. We sat at opposite ends of a narrow bench and listened to Taisia emptying the dirty water downstairs.

"I'll stay tomorrow," I said.

"We're all staying tomorrow. At least until lunchtime."

“I mean I’ll stay altogether. Until I’ve put it right.”

Marta turned her face towards me.

“First find out exactly what needs putting right, and who wants to see you in their yard.”

I wanted to say I was not trying to earn forgiveness. But that was exactly what I intended to stay for: to work until someone said the words I needed. Marta was too tired to discuss it with me. She took a nut out of her pocket, accidentally carried away from the station, set it on the windowsill and began to look at it.

Nika came out a quarter of an hour later.

“Grandma says I can stay with Marta until tomorrow evening,” she said. “She’ll call again in the morning. I want to go to Yevgenia. Her photographs got wet, the ones that were downstairs.”

“I’ll take you,” Marta replied.

The girl went towards her room. I stood up.

“Nika.”

She stopped without turning round.

“I’m sorry. I frightened you. And I didn’t listen when people tried to stop me.”

She was silent for a long time.

“You didn’t listen to us this morning either. When we were writing things down. You were more interested in having your picture taken.”

“Yes.”

“Don’t say ‘yes’ as if that means I’m not allowed to be angry any more.”

She closed the door. I sat down again.

In the night I woke to the sound of water in the pipes. I got up and went to the window. Far away, the work floodlights were still burning. Small figures moved beneath them, and I tried to guess how far the water had now

retreated. My phone showed three o'clock. I opened the list of damage, read it, closed it. I wrote Roman a message and deleted it. There were several hours left until morning, and nothing I could do with them would pay him back for his sleep.

On Sunday we went to the shed early. Wet gloves hung on the gates. Roman stood on the bank, his right arm in a sling over which he had pulled a cut-open plastic bag. At the hospital they had cleaned the wound and put in stitches. They had found no fracture. They said it would take time to know how well he would be able to move his hand.

“I’m not allowed to work,” he said, seeing my glance. “And I’m not working. I’m watching other people make a mess of it.”

Three neighbours were by the shed. One was dismantling the boardwalk, two were carrying things out. Nobody sent me away, but nobody made room for me either.

“May I help?” I asked.

Roman pointed to a dry patch.

“Stack the boards. Good ones separately. The warped ones over there. Boris will decide which ones are good.”

Boris proved to be a stocky, taciturn man in glasses spattered with clay. He gave me a crowbar,

then changed his mind and took it back.

“Just your hands for now. Watch the nails.”

I put my gloves on slowly so that my fingers would not start shaking. Then I began carrying boards. Picked them up, carried them, laid them where I was told. Some were heavier than they looked: water had filled the cracks. They smelt of river, old oil and crumbling wood.

An hour later Marta came. She had left Nika with Yevgenia at the House of Culture, having first called Vera and given her the address. The girl was helping to spread photographs on clean cloth, while the adults made sure

the pictures did not stick together. It was easier for me to know she had something to do that had nothing to do with my remorse.

Marta examined a portable pump they had pulled from the shed. She forbade anyone to try switching it on. She wrote down what needed drying and checking, then turned to a trolley stuck in the mud. Roman watched her with an attention one does not usually give someone repairing one's trolley: today anything might prove to be the last thing still working.

I went to buy materials with Boris. He chose fixings, lengths of timber and two packs of gloves. I

paid and put the receipts into a clear folder. The shop assistant asked whether we needed the most expensive boards.

“We need suitable ones,” Boris replied.

On the way back I suggested several more purchases. He told me not to rush: first we had to open up the back wall of the shed and see what had survived. There was no wish to punish me by making me wait in his refusal. He simply knew the order of the work.

By noon the lower boardwalk had been dismantled. It could not be rebuilt that day: the ground needed to dry out and the supports needed checking. Boris

agreed to come on Monday with an assistant. We wrote down his estimate and agreed that Roman would approve any changes first. I left money for the first stage and asked for photographs, receipts, anything that would be needed for the final reckoning.

“That isn’t for the hand,” Roman said.

“I know.”

“As for the hand, I don’t yet know what to say to you.”

I nodded.

He looked at my dirty gloves.

“Don’t nod at everything. It makes me feel as though I’ve already come to an agreement with you.”

I took off my gloves. Beneath them my palms were white and damp.

“I’ll come back after Thursday. If you agree, I’ll work wherever you tell me to. I’ll pay for the treatment and lost earnings too, once we know how much. And if you want to make a formal claim, I’ll confirm what I wrote yesterday.”

“We’ll see,” he said.

That was all. I tried to hear precisely those words, turning them into neither consent nor refusal.

Lyubov Fedotovna met me at her plot. A thin grey film lay on the dried surface. She sat on an

upturned bucket, picking wooden labels bearing the names of varieties out of the soil.

I offered to buy new flowers.

“You can’t buy ones like these now. I’d been growing them since February.”

We looked at the broken stems. She gave me the cost of the seed and the approximate number of pots she had intended to sell. She asked me to note separately that the small plants by the fence could still be nursed back, but the flowering batch would have to be counted as lost. They had been ordered for a school celebration. You could not grow another batch in a week.

“Will you go over there?” she asked, nodding towards the end of the plot. “Pick up my labels. Only I’ll show you where to step first.”

We walked along the sodden paths until she said that was enough.

Lida found us by the van. She had brought the station logbook in a new bag. An inked figure had spread across the cover; it was an old stain, nothing to do with yesterday. She gave us permission to photograph the pages we needed, but wanted to keep the original in her own cupboard.

The log contained records of tests, the names of duty staff,

complaints that the signal was hard to hear. Ada Severina’s signature appeared beside several entries. One mentioned our mill; another, the school amplifier, which had never been connected to the shared line.

Marta spent a long time looking at a page listing fixings.

“Dad’s handwriting,” she said.

I moved closer, but she did not pass me the phone at once. She gave herself time to finish reading, run a finger over the screen, enlarge the short entry. That notebook held more than the answer to my problem.

Lida asked us to keep the pages with refusals and tests that had

not taken place as well. I photographed the whole section in order, without selecting what suited us.

While I gathered the receipts, Marta called Yakov. The van's return date was approaching, and we could no longer promise him we would make the journey in time. She told him where we were and why we had been delayed. Yakov let us use the vehicle until Thursday evening: he had found another driver for the next delivery. Marta wrote down the new deadline and promised to let him know beforehand if anything changed.

Then we called Vera again. Nika spoke first. She wanted to go with

Marta to see Ada: she had seen the school porch in the photograph and thought the next part of the map might be kept there. Vera asked whether she wanted to go for herself or thought she ought to finish what she had begun. Nika considered this and said she wanted to. They did not discuss me.

It was agreed that we would give an exact address and details of the sleeping arrangements by evening. Until then, permission extended only to the day's journey. Going home remained an option: Marta could take Nika back separately, and I would carry on alone.

Before we left I went into the shed once more. Roman sat on a crate, dictating measurements to Boris. I asked whether he needed anything else that day.

“Not today. Don’t be late afterwards.”

I went out. Lyubov Fedotovna’s basket lay overturned on the bank. I picked it up, carried it to the gate and set it down with the handle facing out, so its owner would not have to bend down to the wet ground again.

13. The Settlement of Unfinished Business

We drove towards the railway school along a road that began at a working level crossing and ended at a dismantled one. Between them lay a settlement of two long streets. Some of the houses had identical porches, but over the years their residents had painted them different colours, added canopies, replaced the steps. Only the distance from the rails remained the same.

A concrete display stood at the entrance. Once it had shown the settlement's future: a playground, a fountain and a small glass building. Now the white paint

had peeled, part of the fountain had disappeared, and on the surviving glass building someone had written the telephone number of a man who collected scrap metal.

We stopped by the shop. Marta wanted to buy bread and check the road ahead. I switched Maybe off. My knee had stiffened, and I had to dismount carefully, holding the handlebars.

A man in a work coat sat outside the shop. In front of him stood a trolley with its wheel taken apart. Washers were laid out on the tarmac, covered with newspaper against the wind.

“Going to Severina’s?” he asked when Marta mentioned the

school. “Drive round. Don’t go across the yard here; the edge has washed away.”

Nika took out her map.

“What about on foot?”

“You can go along the fence. Just shut the gate afterwards. The hens get out.”

He did not ask her to explain why a child needed a map, and Nika squatted down to mark the gate. The man moved the newspaper aside, making a dry space for her.

In the shop we were told that Ada was not back from her lessons yet. She returned towards evening, if the bus did not get stuck by the quarry. It was not far from here to the school. We could

wait in the tearoom, but that was not open either.

“Why?” I asked.

The shopkeeper looked through the glass at the house opposite.

“Because it never opened.”

A sheet saying “Soon” hung on its door. Beneath the rain streaks, two more layers of the same sheets were visible.

“Not enough water?” Marta asked.

“There’s water. There’s an oven. The owner has no money left after last time. And no wish to borrow again either.”

She weighed the bread, put a small bun on top, then took it out

and asked separately whether we wanted it. Nika nodded before I had time to answer for all three of us.

The man with the trolley introduced himself as Stepan. He was taking the wheel off for the second time. The first time he had replaced the bush, but it had turned out to be unsuitable. To get a new one meant going into town. The trolley belonged to Olga, the owner of the tearoom that had never come to be. She used it to carry heavy trays from the oven to the back room, and now could only use it as a table: a brick had been put under one wheel.

Marta asked to see the old part. Stepan handed it over with the newspaper. Along one side was a smooth, shiny mark.

“It’s seated crookedly here,” she said. “The wheel itself may still be sound. If you like, we can take it apart on a clean table.”

“I’d like that,” he said. “Only no promises about five minutes. I’ve had those already.”

We carried the trolley to the house opposite. Olga opened the door in an apron, although the tearoom was not open. Inside it smelt of baked onions. It turned out that every Sunday she made several trays of food for families who ordered in advance. Opening the place to everyone meant

hiring someone, buying more stock and once again living with last month's debt.

"On our display it's all been finished for years," she said, noticing me looking at the empty tables. "That glass thing was supposed to be a medical centre. Only the doctor never came. It's a store now."

"And nobody tries?" I asked, out of old habit.

Olga put a basin of cloths in front of me.

"What do you mean, nobody? Stepan tried. I tried. A neighbour started a sewing group. Then they charged her to heat the whole

hall. Would you like a list, or one at a time?”

I said nothing and washed my hands.

On the wall hung a calendar with delivery days marked. Some of next week’s squares were still empty. Olga took orders in advance: how much flour she could buy depended on how many squares were filled.

Marta and Stepan settled by the window. They spread the parts on an old tablecloth, and Marta began explaining to Stepan exactly what had gone out of alignment. Olga asked me to help carry a sack of flour from the doorway into the storeroom. I asked exactly where to put it, and

she showed me two dry battens by the wall.

Then the neighbours came out. One brought a stool, another his own broken door handle, a third simply wanted to know who had arrived. Marta said at once that today she was taking on only the wheel. The man with the handle was disappointed, but wrote down the workshop's number. He stood watching her hands for a little longer, then wrapped the handle in newspaper and took it away.

Stepan told us about the shared shelter at the bus stop. They had started building it three times. The first time, the wrong uprights had been delivered. The second,

they collected money but the craftsman fell ill; the money went on his treatment, and nobody asked for it back. The third time, the residents could not agree where to put it: by the shop was better for the old people, by the school for the children. Now the materials lay under someone else's roof, and everyone thought the next step should be taken by whoever had objected before.

"We're a settlement of unfinished business," Olga said. "Only don't take photographs with us in the background. We've had people come and do that already."

I put my phone away, although I had taken it out to check the time.

A neighbour asked whether it was true that we were saving the mill. He had seen the photograph in the local paper: the editors had managed to publish it on Saturday morning, before the incident. I felt relieved that we could start the conversation with something good. Then I looked at the dressing on my knee.

“We’re trying to preserve it,” I said. “And yesterday I damaged a device at the pumping station. Because of that, the low-lying plots were flooded. Roman is injured.”

It grew quiet round the table. Stepan raised his head.

“That was you?”

“Me.”

“They wrote that something went wrong during the work.”

“It went wrong after I interfered.”

Nobody said anything encouraging. Olga asked about Lyubov Fedotovna. They knew each other: she brought herbs, and the year before had helped with seedlings. I told her about the flooded flowers and the order for the school celebration.

Olga went into the back room. She returned with her phone and called her herself. They talked about varieties, dates and a neighbour’s greenhouse. When she had finished the call, she asked us to take some empty

crates to Two Banks, if there was room. I said I would first agree the route with Marta.

Marta gave me a brief glance and went back to the wheel.

The work took longer than five minutes. The seating had to be cleaned, the axle checked, a suitable spacer found. Stepan found an offcut that would do in his shed. Marta did not do what he could do for himself: she held things, showed him, sometimes asked him to stop and check. When the wheel was back in place, they first rolled the trolley empty, then loaded it with the sack I had just carried into the storeroom.

I had to carry the sack back again. I did so without resenting the circulation of flour.

The trolley rolled smoothly. Olga took the handles and walked between the tables several times. On a turn the wheel squeaked; everyone stopped, Marta bent down, Stepan tightened the fixing. After the second test, Olga decided it could be used.

“Will you open the tearoom?” I began, then stopped myself.

She laughed for the first time in the whole conversation.

“The trolley’s mended. The tearoom isn’t yet.”

She poured us tea, brought pieces of pie and named the price. Marta

paid for three. On the wall calendar Olga added another small figure. Nika asked whether she could mark the tearoom on her map if she wrote that food had to be ordered in advance. Olga agreed and dictated the number herself.

We stayed until the shadow of the display stretched across the road. A girl carrying a flute case walked down the street. Stepan said she was one of Ada's pupils, which meant the bus had arrived. The girl turned towards the school, but soon stopped, went back to the shop and waited for her mother. Her mother came out, and they went off towards

the level crossing, discussing something of their own.

Marta checked a message from Vera. They had agreed to speak as soon as we had seen the school and could say where Nika would be that evening. I gathered my things. Stepan pointed to the bass case.

“So you never did play.”

“It didn’t work out today.”

He nodded and took one end of the trolley to carry it over the threshold. I took the other. The doorway was narrow; we turned the trolley sideways, waited while Olga moved a bucket and carried it in without touching the fresh paint on the frame.

14. The Woman Who Would Not Be Dulcinea

The school stood side-on to the railway. It had been built in the days when children were supposed to look out of windows at things moving, rather than at the wall of the next house. The nearer track was now overgrown with grass. The farther one was still in use: as we walked round the washed-out yard, a short goods train passed along it. The windowpanes trembled, and whitewash flaked down from the porch ceiling.

The fittings for a sign remained above the entrance. A new note hung on the door: “Lessons in the

room on the right. Do not enter the left wing.” Beneath it, in another hand, someone had added: “Because of the floor.”

Ada Severina sat on the bottom step, shaking sand out of her shoe. Beside her stood a large shopping bag from which protruded a ruler, herbs and a thin folder tied with tapes. When she saw us, she did not hurry to put her shoe on. She tipped out the last grains, felt inside the toe and only then stood up.

She was older than the woman in the photograph. This struck me as a discovery, although there was no reason to have expected otherwise. Her hair had greyed at the temples, her face had grown

sharper, but her movements retained the same unhurried precision as in the photograph where she held the speaking trumpet.

“Have you come to see me?” she asked. “I only have two today. And both have already been.”

Marta introduced herself. At Pavel’s name Ada went still, then came closer.

“His daughter? I remember you when you were tiny. You used to hide nuts in your coat pocket.”

“Father would look for them afterwards.”

“I know. We spent half an hour taking the table apart to find one particular one.”

Marta smiled. Ada did not say that she had not changed at all. She was looking at the grown woman before her, noticing things about her she did not yet know.

I told her about our business, the deadline and the mill. Ada listened and took her keys from the bag, but did not open the door yet.

“So they’ve got round to it after all.”

“You knew they wanted to take it off the plan?”

“I knew. I wrote. They replied that my letter had been placed on file. They didn’t specify which file.”

“We have an extension until Thursday, until noon.”

She asked what the extension allowed. I listed it: a survey, the gathering of evidence, a proposal for safe use; all works other than necessary strengthening had been halted. I had already learnt to say this part without promising that seven days would change everything.

Ada looked at the case.

“And what is that for?”

“Four notes. They found an answer in the mill. We’re looking for where they came from.”

“Not far from here. Only the story’s longer than the tune.”

She invited us onto the porch. Nika sat on a higher step. Ada moved her bag to make room for her. Marta sat beside her. I remained standing with my instrument, like someone they had forgotten to give a place in the orchestra.

The window in the room on the right was open. Pupils' exercise books lay on the sill. It smelt of chalk and apple peel. Farther inside I saw an upright piano covered with a sheet, several chairs and a table on which stood a small, dismantled amplifier. It all immediately formed a picture for me: a woman who had preserved a forgotten call was

waiting for us to come and carry on her work.

I had scarcely had time to be alarmed by this convenient picture before I began to speak.

“I think we’ve found our Dulcinea.”

Ada raised her head.

“Whose?”

I tried to smile.

“That came out badly. I meant the person for whose sake…”

“There’s no need to do anything for my sake. I haven’t asked you yet.”

She said it calmly, without any willingness to take part in my embarrassment.

“I want the school guttering repaired,” she continued. “I don’t want my pupil to have to cross the freight track. And I want to finish the teaching manual for which I haven’t managed to find a quiet month in three years. If that will fit into your story, put it in along with me. But I’m not going to stand out in front with a pretty name while you decide for me what I’ve been waiting for.”

I sat on the edge of the porch, leaving the bag between us.

“I’m sorry.”

“Let’s start again instead. Can you play what you heard?”

I looked at Nika. She shrugged.

“You can here,” she said. “I meant yesterday.”

I took out the bass. Adjusted the strap, touched a string. In the open air the sound was quiet. The first note crept a little sharp; I put my finger back in place and repeated it. Then I played the other three.

We waited.

Behind the school a dustbin lid clattered. The rails still held the faint ringing of the departed train. Ada added nothing.

“Yes,” she said. “That’s our call. Only it was played differently in different places. Lower at the mill, higher by the water. The

instruments were different, and so were the people.”

“Did you compose it?”

“I wrote down the sequence. I was looking for one that sounded different from a horn and an ordinary doorbell. Then we tested it. Pavel thought of a way to use the old air pipe in the mill. Other people helped with transmitting it. Usually only one surname remains on the sheet, so it looks as though the person did everything alone.”

Marta took out the photographs of the station logbook. Ada asked her to enlarge one page, then another. For a long time she looked at an entry by Marta’s father giving the dimensions of

fixings and a brief, irritated remark about unsuitable metal.

“That was after the rain,” she said. “We were soaked to the skin. He wanted to finish, but stopped the work. The measurements on wet wood were coming out wrong.”

Marta did not answer. Ada handed back her phone.

“There’s no fifth note written down,” I said.

“That space is left for an answer.”

“What sort?”

“From whoever heard. We agreed how each person could answer. Sometimes by voice. Sometimes a short knock. At a distance we needed another way, a light or a

telephone. The tune itself doesn't tell you how much water is coming or where to go. It attracts attention. Then the person has to receive the message and confirm that they understand it."

Nika took out the second sheet of the square. The very one I had not looked at yesterday morning.

"What if they can hear, but their hands are in dough?"

Ada took the sheet and read it carefully.

"Then you've chosen a poor way of getting an answer from them. You need to change the way. Or ask someone else who'll be nearby. Is this a bakery?"

They began to go through the map. Ada did not praise it wholesale: she asked for the time of the test, the wind direction and whether the shop door had been open to be marked. Nika added what she remembered. She left the rest with a question mark.

I sat beside them and listened. Through the open window I could see the edge of the table with a pupil’s exercise book. There was a name on the cover that meant nothing to me. This person had a lesson of their own on Monday, and Ada did not intend to cancel it for the sake of our mill.

“We need the old calculations,” Marta said. “And Father’s papers. Whatever’s survived.”

“In the design office archive. I was going there tomorrow anyway. I can take you in if you come by eight. I’ll leave a key for a pupil first, then we’ll go.”

I began to thank her, but she stopped me.

“Will you tell me about yesterday?”

My face went cold.

“You know?”

“Lida called. She said you would be coming. I want the details from you.”

I took out the copy of my account. The paper had crumpled in my pocket, with a grey line appearing at the fold. Ada read the first

page, turned it over, then looked at me.

I told her. I did not begin with my childhood, with my love for the mill or with how difficult it had been to obtain the extension. I said that I had seen Roman, decided he was in danger, failed to check, gone inside and broken the device. That a worker had tried to stop me. That other people had dealt with the consequences.

Ada listened, holding the sheet on her knees.

“Will this be in the material about the mill?”

I looked at Marta. She did not help me answer.

“It will,” I said.

“Not in an appendix that can be overlooked. If you’re asking people to trust a shared signal again, they should know how you behave yourself when you won’t wait for an answer.”

She asked us to add information about the consequences and the compensation plan to the folder, without presenting any sums as final. I wrote down her request. Then she set her bag beside her, took out the folder tied with tapes and cleared a dry corner of the step for our sheets.

While I arranged the papers, Marta called Vera. Ada gave her the school’s address, explained which rooms were fit to sleep in

and invited Vera to call her directly. In the right wing there were a former staffroom and a small guest room. Marta and Nika could stay there; I could sleep at Stepan's, if he agreed. Ada rang him in front of us.

Vera spoke to Nika separately, then to Marta again. She gave permission for the journey to continue until Thursday, on condition of morning and evening calls every day and the option of returning earlier at any time. She promised to arrange the schoolwork herself. Nika was to help with maps and pursue her own work, not be present when people were working on machinery. Marta confirmed

each condition without hurrying the conversation.

Stepan agreed to take me in. I took the motorcycle and case to his house, left my things in a small room above the shed and walked back to the school. A light shone in the window. Nika and Marta were already inside, and I could hear them moving a bed to get its head out of the draught.

Ada stood on the threshold with her keys.

“Eight tomorrow,” she reminded me.

I handed her the folder. My account of the pumping station lay on top. She checked the order of the sheets, put the folder in a dry bag and held the door while I carried the two remaining bags over the threshold.

Part III: The Archive of Things That Never Happened

15. A Room with Doors to Different Tomorrows

On Monday I was woken twice. First Stepan, at whose house I had spent the night, rattled a trolley about in the yard. Then, once I was at the school, the bell rang for break. The bell lay on a table with no wires attached, and Ada was striking it with a spoon.

“Breakfast will get cold,” she called from the corridor.

Marta and Nika had spent the night in the usable right wing of

the former railway school. I had arrived from Stepan's too early and, while waiting for breakfast, dozed off on a chair beneath a chart explaining how not to miss your train. The last passenger train had passed through here many years ago. The chart remained impeccably correct.

I sat up, carefully straightening my knee. Overnight, yesterday's weariness had managed to find new places. Outside the window, rain soaked the rails of the nearer track; the grass between them was so thick that only herbivorous trains could use it now. Nika's socks were drying on the windowsill. One had been

turned inside out. The other, apparently, was resisting.

In the kitchen Ada put a fresh exercise book in front of me.

“Make a fair copy of yesterday’s account. And leave room for additions.”

There was a ship on the cover. I wanted to ask for a different exercise book, one without water.

Marta was ladling out porridge. Nika sat by the window with the phone, telling her grandmother that they provided towels here, and that the ceiling in the bedroom did not leak. She said “in the bedroom”, although she had slept between a cupboard for class registers and a portrait of

the man who had invented the brake.

“No,” Nika was saying. “I’m not upstairs. I’m up already, anyway. Marta’s here. I’ll put her on.”

Marta took the phone and went over to the door. I wrote out the date and then: “I disrupted the operation of the pumping station.”

Ada set a mug in front of me.

“Say exactly what you did. You were more precise yesterday.”

I crossed out the line.

The letters came slowly. I had to name the lever I had broken, the warning I had disregarded, the water in eight vegetable gardens, in the cellars and in Roman’s

shed. I did not know the exact cost of the damage and wrote that it was still being established. Roman's right hand, injured as he pulled Lyubov Fedotovna out, took up one line. I left three blank ones after it: however much I wrote, the lines still came out shorter than his pain.

Nika finished eating and looked over my shoulder.

"You've written 'saving people'."

"That's about Roman."

"And about yourself?"

I read the sentence above. It said: "I tried to avert danger."

Nika said nothing else. She took her bowl away to wash it.

I replaced those words with others: “I decided that I understood what was happening better than the station workers did.”

While I was copying it out, Ada took a slim folder from the cupboard, slipped several sheets of drawings into it and tied the tapes. On the top sheet I saw her name and the title of the manual she had mentioned yesterday. The folder’s corners were worn.

“Will you take this?” I asked, showing her the exercise book.

“No. You will. Put the fair copy at the front of the folder, as we agreed yesterday. If you show the archive one half of your journey,

nobody will fill in the other half for you.”

We set off for the archive on foot. Yakov’s van stood by the school gates: Marta had arranged the extension until Thursday evening while we were still at the river. Maybe stayed under the lean-to beside an upturned wheelbarrow; Marta said it would do him good to spend time with people his own age. The road ran along the embankment. Ada carried her folder under her arm, checking on the way whether the gate at a former pupil’s house was shut. Someone waved from the window. Ada pointed to the gate; the woman nodded and came out with a

piece of rope. Neither had time for the teacher's ceremonial return to history.

Shortly after eight we reached the archive, which occupied the former drawing office of the railway workshops. In front of the entrance stood a locomotive lamp on a stone plinth. The lamp had not shone for a long time, but a vigorous gooseberry bush grew on the plinth. Nika peered under its branches. The last berries were already shrivelled, and she left them for the birds.

At a desk by the entrance sat an archivist in a knitted waistcoat. Three pairs of spectacles lay on the desk, each entitled to its own saucer.

“Ada Severina,” she said. “Will you be complaining about the catalogue description again?”

“If it hasn’t been corrected.”

“It has. It no longer says ‘unrealised brass band’. It says ‘experimental audible warning network’.”

“Thank you, Inna Sergeyevna.”

“A thankless choice of words. People used to ask for the band, at least.”

She issued us with pencils. Mine was very short, as though the archive were limiting the scope of discovery in advance.

“Leave your pens here. No food. Show us your exercise book on the way out, so we don’t mistake

it for one of ours. The girl is the responsibility of the accompanying adult. No entering the storage rooms without me."

I was about to give my title, but Inna Sergeyevna had already entered me as a visitor. It proved an unexpectedly comfortable position: all a visitor had to do was not drop things.

The first room had five doors. Four were closed. Above one hung "Northern Bypass", above another "Station Garden", and above the third "New Settlement". The last was called "Preservation of the Existing Situation". A cupboard stood against it.

“To preserve the situation?” I asked.

“To stop water dripping from the wall onto the documents.”

The doors remained from the former offices. Behind them were the papers for projects that, in their time, were supposed to have transformed the district. Schoolchildren had once been brought here. The exhibition album even contained a photograph of children pointing towards a bright future with three different fingers. Later the visits were discontinued, but nobody took the signs down.

Inna Sergeyevna opened “New Settlement”.

On a large table stood white houses, trees made of green sponge, and a tiny bus delayed for ever outside a glass-fronted shop. Snow made of yellowing cotton wool lay round the edges of the model. This settlement was a comfortable place to live at a scale of approximately one to five hundred.

Nika crouched in front of it.

“Where do you go to school?”

“Here’s the school,” said the archivist.

“There are steps here. Why does the path on the other side stop?”

Inna Sergeyevna pulled out a drawer beneath the table and took out a thick bundle of letters.

On the top sheet, a woman explained that her son walked with support and would not be able to climb the grand entrance steps every day. In the margin a designer had written: “Provide accompaniment.”

Marta took the sheet by its edge and looked at the note for a long time.

“Will the person accompanying him get a ride up those steps too?”

“After the discussion they designed another entrance,” the archivist replied. “Then it turned out they were putting the settlement on land that flooded. The new entrance stayed on paper with everything else.”

I walked round the model. A brown strip of cardboard stuck out behind the handsome community hall. Nika asked what it was.

“Land they didn’t get round to decorating.”

“Did people live there?”

“There were vegetable gardens. And two houses.”

I felt uncomfortable at how readily I had been about to pity this entire town that had never come to be. From above it looked defenceless. From below, from those two houses, the view was probably different.

Ada asked for the folder containing the discussions of the

sound network. Inna Sergeyevna said she would have to fetch it from the lower storeroom and suggested we look at the “Northern Bypass” in the meantime.

Behind the next door, roads hung on the walls. They crossed fields, curved round slopes and crossed the little river in several places at once. Red arrows argued with blue ones. At one bend a photograph of an old oak had been pasted on; at another, an estimate for moving the cemetery fence. I recognised a stretch of the road we had driven along on Friday. On the plan it was crossed out.

“Did they forget it?” Nika asked.

“They left it out of the final version. They never built the bypass, but they’d already excluded the old road. Not all the documents were corrected.”

Nika took off her rucksack and brought out her map.

“May I mark where people drive along it?”

“On your own map, yes.”

She settled by the window. Marta sat beside her, holding down the edge of the map, which was curling in the damp. I looked at them and thought of Thursday for the first time that morning. We had three days and a few hours left until noon. We had already found doors to four different

tomorrows, but none yet led to a working mill.

The archivist returned with a trolley. On it stood two boxes. The upper one was tied with a dark ribbon; the lower one was sealed with a strip of paper bearing a stamp.

“This one is available,” she said, touching the upper box. “There’s an official visit concerning the second one today. If copying is authorised, we’ll look at it together.”

I read the label on the upper box: “Hill Station. Mechanical Section. Acoustic Device. Shared-Use Premises.”

Marta looked up.

“My father used to call it ‘the hill station’.”

There was no joy in her voice. Only, so far, the attentiveness with which she listened to an engine before deciding whether it could be started.

Inna Sergeyevna pushed the trolley towards the light. One wheel caught in a gap between the floorboards, and the three of us lifted the boxes so that she could free it. After that the future reached the reading table without further assistance.

16. The Archive of Things That Never Happened

The dust in the box smelt of dry bread. Inna Sergeyevna took off the lid, counted the folders and looked at us as one looks at guests before bringing out the family china.

“We preserve the order. Even if it seems wrong.”

“And if it is wrong?” I asked.

“We make a note. Otherwise the next researcher will have to study you as well.”

The first drawing took up half the table. It showed the mill in section: the staircase, the stone walls, the upper shaft, the

millstones that had long been still. A fine red line ran through all of it. It linked a small chamber beneath the roof to openings below and ended in the annexe, where a workbench had been drawn.

Marta bent so low that the archivist asked her to take off her scarf.

“You’ll catch the corner.”

Marta obeyed without taking her eyes off the sheet.

“His handwriting.”

At the bottom, beside the designer’s signature, were corrections in pencil. In one place a neat eight had become a six. Beside a flight of stairs were the

words: “Keep passage clear. Do not store belts here.”

“He wrote that at home too,” Marta said. “Only about my boots.”

She touched her own wrist, as though checking it for oil, and turned to the next sheet.

It turned out that the mill could sing for several reasons. Its old air duct contained reeds like thick metal petals. When air moved through them, each sounded at its own pitch. When the wind changed, the sounds did not always come in order; the lower stone cavity amplified certain frequencies and all but swallowed others. Part of the device predated Ada’s project.

Marta's father had modified it, trying to produce a recognisable call sign.

Ada took a sheet with a table of test results from her folder.

"This is where I met your father. He knew the old reeds all had their own temperaments. I wanted notes of equal length, and he explained how much my tidiness would cost in iron."

"He knew how to explain costs," said Marta. "Other people's, especially."

She said it without anger, but Ada immediately stopped smiling.

The project listed four points: the hill station, the river post, the market square and the railway

school. At the bottom was a warning that sound could not reliably be heard directly from one point to another. Confirmations were to be backed up by wire, and later by radio. Sound was used to summon those on duty and attract attention; information about water and weather was transmitted separately.

I reread the warning.

“So nobody was planning to report the water level in the bass clef?”

“We were,” Ada replied. “In the very first version. And I was one of those people. Then, during a trial, a carpenter heard ‘come to the bridge’ instead of ‘keep away

from the bridge’. That was the end of musical hydrology.”

Inna Sergeyevna set another folder beside it.

“The first version has been preserved too.”

It contained a great many beautiful notes. Beneath them came drawings of signalling flags, with several exceptions beside each drawing. I tried to remember at least two and immediately confused them. Nika confused only one, but it was the one that sent a person to the bridge.

Ada asked us to put the sheet back.

“That was the version we rejected,” she said.

The box held more than drawings. There were lists of people who needed a heated room, requests for permission to repair household utensils in the evenings, a timetable for teaching metalwork. One woman asked for a wide table for cutting fabric. The reply informed her that sewing did not come under the mechanical section. She had sent the reply back with a note: “My machine does.” On the reverse, Marta’s father had drawn a place by the window and written: “Fit a socket.”

Marta smiled. Then she took a bill out of an envelope and stopped smiling.

Her father had paid part of the bill himself. Beside it lay a note about postponing his leave.

“We didn’t go to the seaside that year,” Marta said.

Nika stopped drawing.

“He explained that his pay had been held up at work. I spent the whole summer cursing his boss.”

I wanted to say that he had been doing something good. The words were already in my throat, ready to dispose of somebody else’s summer free of charge.

“You didn’t know?” Ada asked.

Marta shook her head.

“I didn’t know about the seaside either,” said Ada.

They sat on opposite sides of the table. Between them lay the drawing with its neat passage that had to be kept clear. At last Marta pulled her exercise book towards her and copied down the amount owed, along with the date.

“We’re copying this too,” she said. “He could perfectly well have asked the people whose money he spent.”

A pipe hummed behind the wall. Nika looked up, and I looked up with her. For a moment I thought

the familiar four notes were about to emerge from the paper.

“They’re testing the pipes,” Inna Sergeyevna informed us. “We have an acoustic period after every repair.”

She went to the door and called down the corridor that they were not to turn the water on in the far riser yet. An angry male voice answered from the corridor. The archivist returned, took a basin from under the table and put it beneath the radiator. It was enamelled, with a painted strawberry. One of the best-prepared objects I had encountered in the past few days.

By noon we had reached the inspection reports. Here the mill

looked worse than in the pictures. The masonry had cracks, the shaft support required monitoring, and it was recommended that the damaged sail be removed before any trials. A note stated that a workshop could open only after a separate inspection of the lower room and the provision of a safe exit. Underlined in red were the words: “Use as an operational wind-powered installation is outside the scope of this project.”

I felt resentful towards the paper. It had been lying here for all these years and still found time to contradict me.

“But they were preserving it so that it could work.”

Marta unfolded a sheet I had not yet looked at.

At the bottom, in her father's handwriting, was written: "Do not set it turning out of respect for my earlier efforts. I would prefer nobody to be hurt."

She did not read it aloud. She simply left the sheet in front of me.

We had lunch in the corridor, because eating in the reading room was forbidden. Ada had brought bread, cheese and four apples. I offered one to Inna Sergeyevna, but she pointed to her dentures and asked me to slice it. Marta had a knife. I cut it on the lid of a food container, trying to make the slices thin.

This small task made it easier to sit among other people's great decisions.

The archivist told us how she acquired papers from organisations that were closing down. Sometimes bundles arrived without labels. Sometimes only the final design was left, as though people had neither argued nor calculated nor made mistakes before arriving at it. One box had been found by a rubbish bin; another had been handed over with apologies: it had contained too much information about those whom the previous plan had inconvenienced.

“Why ‘things that never happened’?” Nika asked. “So much happened here.”

“The visitors invented that. Officially it’s the Future Development Section.”

“Do future developments eat apples too?” I asked.

“If you don’t stop dropping crumbs, they’re about to be given a broom.”

After lunch Inna Sergeyevna allowed us to copy the pages we needed. The machine stood on the other side of the corridor and dealt confidently with half a sheet. The other half had to be fed through separately. Marta marked matching points, Ada

kept track of the order, and Nika labelled the edges in pencil. I turned the feed handle and was at last useful in an area that did not require me to make sense of the world.

The copy of the drawing came out with a pale stripe. It had erased precisely the signature of Marta's father.

"We'll do it again," I said.

"The signature separately," she replied, checking it against the original. "It's more important that we can see the crack just now."

A door slammed in the lower corridor. Footsteps followed, and a calm voice at which my

shoulders assumed a visitor's posture of their own accord.

Gaspar Metronomovich Ladny appeared with a briefcase and a paper cup. He stopped at our table, saw the spread-out halves of the mill, then Ada. The lid of the cup gave slightly beneath his fingers.

"Good afternoon," he said.

"That depends on the folder," Ada replied.

Inna Sergeyevna took the keys to the lower storeroom. On the trolley beneath the reading table, the second box still stood with its seal intact. I made way for Gaspar, but he did not pass at once: he was looking at the crack, which the copier had preserved far more faithfully than the signature.

17. The Man Who Set the Final Seal

Gaspar Metronomovich took off his coat and hung it over the back of a chair. The lining caught on a protruding screw. He carefully freed the fabric, felt the tear, and only then asked whether we all intended to stay.

“The documents are open to the public,” said Inna Sergeyevna. “The box was sealed when it was transferred. I warned you yesterday that readers would be here.”

Ada nodded.

“I asked for the unpacking not to be put off. There isn’t much time before Thursday.”

So this was not a meeting fate had arranged for our benefit. Ada had telephoned, the archivist had submitted a request, and the official had brought permission. Fate had plenty of opportunities to help us, but so far we had to make our own calls.

Inna Sergeyevna checked the seal number, slit the paper strip and folded it into an envelope. Gaspar signed the record. Then she signed it. I watched his hand: the same angle of the pen with which he must have entered me among the last people.

The box contained minutes, photographs and a thick green folder. On the folder were the words: “On Bringing the Valley Warning Network into Trial Operation”. A thin black line had been drawn through the word “Trial”.

Ada put her own copy beside it. In hers the word remained in place.

Gaspar sat down opposite.

“I know what you want to show.”

“Then show it yourself,” she said.

He did not answer at once. He took the photographs, separated out several sheets and laid them in order. First came the opening of the river post. People stood on

the steps; a young Gaspar held a large key that fitted none of the visible locks. Then came a photograph of water on those same steps. The key was no longer in it. The water stood higher than the place where his knees had been.

“Were you involved in the network?” I asked.

“I was responsible for bringing it into service.”

In the first photograph he was almost unrecognisable. Not because he was young. He was leaning his whole body towards the person he was speaking to, like a man afraid of missing a good idea. Now he sat upright,

holding the edge of the folder with two fingers.

In an early memorandum, Gaspar proposed allowing small community projects to proceed without a promise of immediate benefit, provided they had people responsible for them, a spending limit and a date for review. I read it twice. The phrase about the spending limit belonged to someone quite familiar. Everything else seemed a mistake on the bookbinder's part.

"Did you write this?"

"You can compare the handwriting."

"But then why…"

He looked up. I did not finish.

Inna Sergeyevna brought another chair for Nika. The girl sat beside Marta with her feet tucked up and opened the map on her knees. She did not want to leave a room where the adults had finally stopped talking like tour guides.

Ada took out a list of unfinished work. The river post had no independent power supply. Two sections lacked backup communications. Not enough people had been recruited for night duty. Below the table were the words: “Final acceptance is not recommended until the deficiencies have been remedied.”

“Is this your report?” Marta asked.

“Mine,” Ada replied.

The next document stated that the deficiencies did not prevent the network as a whole from entering service. Beneath it were three signatures. Gaspar pointed to the last.

“Mine.”

He said it so matter-of-factly that I wanted to check whether the others had heard.

According to the papers, the money for backup equipment had been diverted to urgent repairs to the embankment. Duty shifts were to be paid for from another fund, but the fund had

never opened. Equipment already installed might have been taken away if the facility was not accepted before the end of the reporting period. Gaspar had signed the acceptance certificate, expecting to finish the rest afterwards. An order declaring the network operational had gone out to the settlements. People had been told that warnings would now reach them in time.

“And the water?” Nika asked.

“Came earlier,” he said.

Ada slid the diagram towards her, not the photographs. She showed her the upper catchment, the river post and the low-lying yards. She spoke calmly, without

details that would not have made anything clearer to a child. Communications had failed in bad weather. Some warnings had been delivered in person; some yards had been reached too late. People had got out in time, but had not managed to get their animals out, carry away their stores or lift their furniture. There had been injuries. Several houses had later been dismantled.

“Yours too?” Nika asked Gaspar.

“My brother’s. Denis’s.”

He moved his cup onto the saucer the archivist had given him.

“He’s alive,” Gaspar added, seeing her face. “He works. He tells me

off on Sundays when I ring him. Sometimes with good reason, sometimes simply because we don't have many subjects in common."

For the first time I imagined someone who could tell Gaspar Metronomovich, "Don't ring before lunch."

"Did he know you'd signed?" Marta asked.

"I took him a copy myself. At first I wanted to explain about the funding. He asked where our order said that things should be kept on the top shelf. It said the system was ready."

Inna Sergeyevna turned towards the window. Someone was

dragging a ladder along the corridor. The sound went on for a long time, with pauses, and nobody in the reading room tried to speak over it.

I took out my exercise book with the ship on it.

“At the station in Two Banks I broke a safety lever,” I said. “I was told to step back. I didn’t.”

Gaspar looked at the exercise book.

“I was sent a report.”

“This is what I can confirm myself. And what I don’t know yet. The list of damage is being checked with the residents. I’ve undertaken to pay my share and help with the restoration.”

“Your share?”

“What I caused. I’ll correct the wording.”

He read the page. I waited for a verdict and suddenly caught myself waiting for something still more unpleasant: I wanted his old signature to make my lever lighter. I wanted two guilty people to give each other a discount for understanding the circumstances.

Gaspar handed the exercise book back.

“Append this to the application. Don’t state amounts until you’ve agreed them with the people affected. Your intention to pay

does not put a price on their losses.”

Marta took out a pencil and noted the point. Now I was ashamed, too, of having hoped to hear something less useful from him.

“After the flood, did you start shutting down everything that couldn’t be guaranteed?” Ada asked.

“I started requiring evidence.”

“You require results before work begins.”

“And you once thought a trial was justification enough for beginning.”

“I required a backup power supply. It’s written right here.”

She did not raise her voice. She simply pushed the table of deficiencies towards him again. Gaspar looked at it and took his hand off the folder.

“Yes,” he said. “It is.”

I had expected a great quarrel, but the argument lasted only a few more minutes and consisted almost entirely of dates. Who had sent comments to whom. When they had been included in the minutes. With what wording they had been passed on. Ada would not let the shared disaster obscure individual decisions. Gaspar corrected two dates and agreed with the third. Inna Sergeyevna made notes for the catalogue description.

Then his phone rang. I caught sight of “Denis” on the screen. Gaspar excused himself and went into the corridor.

“No,” we heard. “I can’t tomorrow. Thursday either… I remember about the window. I’ll get someone in. I’ll only make it worse myself.”

He returned a minute later and finished his cold tea.

“This doesn’t make the mill any safer,” he said.

“We’re not asking to admit people yet,” Marta replied. “We need the drawings and all the surveys. Including the inconvenient ones.”

“You’ll have them.”

“And an opportunity to propose another use,” Ada added. “If we find one.”

Gaspar fastened his briefcase.

“Until twelve o’clock on Thursday. The extension granted last Thursday remains in force. I promise no further extension. An independent technical assessment is mandatory. You understand that an idea found in an archive does not replace one?”

We nodded. I was the last to nod: I was still trying to preserve some part of my original certainty and could find nowhere to put it.

At the door Gaspar paused to adjust his coat. Marta pointed to the screw in the back of the chair.

“Wait.”

She asked the archivist for a screwdriver and sank the head into the wood. The work took a few seconds. Gaspar thanked her.

When he had gone, Inna Sergeyevna put the green folder back in the box. She placed the paper strip with the severed seal on top, in a separate transparent envelope. Nika asked why she was keeping a broken seal.

“So people will know when it was opened and why,” the archivist replied.

I copied the document numbers into my exercise book. There were still plenty of blank pages beneath the ship.

18. Four Notes and a Rest

On Tuesday morning Ada brought five chairs into the classroom and asked for help with the sixth. When asked whom we were expecting, she replied:

“Whoever sits down.”

Yesterday we had returned from the archive in the rain. Nika had rung Vera, given a detailed account of the day’s route, and only then gone to change. We had had to shelter the copies beneath our jackets, and until midnight the school had been hung with drawings like a public laundry with intricately cut linen. They were dry now, slightly bowed. On one sheet the mill staircase had

grown steeper without any intervention from the designer.

Marta took the chair by the door, Nika the one by the window. I took out the bass guitar. Ada wheeled a small amplifier out of the cupboard, its handle wrapped in blue tape. While we were connecting the instrument, a woman with a shopping bag came into the yard.

“I’ve only got twenty minutes,” she said.

“That’ll do, Zoya.”

The former station watchman arrived next. He had brought a flask, although nobody had asked him to. He took the sixth chair.

“What are we saving?” he asked.

“For now, we’re checking what can be heard,” Ada replied.

She pointed to a sheet of paper on the door. In large letters it read: “Practice Sound Test. No Danger.” Ada had warned the neighbours in advance. I appreciated this foresight when I remembered how recently the word “danger” alone had given me the right to take charge of other people’s levers.

I played the four notes I had carried with me since last Thursday. On the second note my finger slipped a little too high. I corrected it, but Ada asked me to stop.

“Again. Without trying to please.”

“I was actually trying to hit the note.”

“Then hit it.”

D. A. C. E.

In the empty classroom the sound was drier than in Marta’s workshop. The floor passed it into the chair legs; the window glass rattled slightly. After the E I held my hand still, waiting for something to follow. Meanwhile Zoya checked the time.

“And what am I supposed to do?” she asked.

I looked at Ada.

“There,” she said. “That’s the right question.”

She wrote the notes on the blackboard. Then she circled the rest and wrote beside it: “Who can hear?”

“The call sign gets people’s attention. After that, a person has to know where to get information and how to reply. If we expect four notes to explain by themselves where the water is coming from, you’ll be getting wet again.”

“I listen to the radio at home,” said the watchman. “If the call comes from here, I’ll hear it. If it comes from the hill, I won’t.”

“Which is why nobody is promising that every point can hear all the others directly.”

Ada drew four circles, but did not join them with solid lines. A dotted line appeared between the schoolyard and the mill. Beside it were a telephone, a radio and a small square for a written log. She gave Nika the chalk and asked her to mark where she had lost her signal along the way.

The girl went to the board. The chalk squeaked.

“In the hollow by the bridge. But only on my phone. Lida’s worked.”

“Then that’s exactly what we write. Not ‘no signal at all’.”

Nika rubbed out half the words and rewrote them. Marta remarked that we would need

different means of confirming receipt, otherwise a single fault would shut everything down at once. I thought of the network that had been solemnly accepted into service, whose papers we had been drying on the radiator, and turned down the amplifier. Nobody had asked me to, but I no longer wanted my four notes to fill the whole classroom.

Ada suggested that Zoya answer first.

I played. Held the pause. Zoya said:

“I can hear.”

I played again, this time with more feeling.

“I said I can hear! I still haven’t bought my potatoes.”

Nika laughed. I took my hand off the strings.

“I thought you’d answer with a sound.”

“What did I just answer you with?”

An aluminium mug stood on the table in front of Zoya. Ada suggested that she try tapping it with a spoon. The short knock that resulted would not fit into my tune. Every time, I wanted to finish it for her, give it a respectable shape. On the third attempt I caught myself leaving Zoya no time.

“Now sit a while,” said Ada.

I sat a while.

A trolley clattered outside the window. The watchman sipped his tea. Zoya tapped: two uneven blows, the second with a rattle. I heard the short answer travel across the classroom and die away by the door.

“Understood?” Ada asked.

“Not all of it.”

“Good. You can ask.”

Ada asked us to name the location after each reply: otherwise all we knew was that someone had hit a mug. Nika asked whether everyone had to know how to sing.

“No,” said Ada. “And not everyone has to agree to take part, either.”

Zoya stood up.

“That suits me. I’m working until Thursday. Tell me how it went afterwards.”

She went to buy potatoes, taking one-sixth of our first gathering with her. Nika moved her empty chair to the wall. It did not look like a failure, although in my earlier tale the heroes would probably have been expected to give up potatoes at once for the sake of history.

The watchman listened to the second test by the window, then asked to swap places with me. He

heard less well in one ear, and from the door everything merged into a hum. We turned the amplifier round. That made it better for him and worse for Marta, who sat opposite. Ada wrote down both complaints without choosing the more deserving one.

“Important signals will have to be seen as well as heard,” Marta said. “In words on a board, with a light, with an agreed gesture. And anyone who can’t see the board needs a person beside them. That’s work too.”

“It doesn’t usually appear in the estimate,” the watchman remarked.

He poured Ada some tea. The tea was strong and smelt of apple peel. We sat among the instruments, discussing who would go over to people for whom hearing a single bell was not enough. Naturally, twenty minutes did not settle it.

The watchman left, forgetting the lid of his flask. While Nika ran after him in the yard, Marta tapped her fingers on the chair. Not a signal: she was simply repeating the knock of Zoya's spoon, shifting the second beat a little. I put a low note beneath it. Marta lost the rhythm, laughed and began again.

Ada, putting the chalk away, stopped by the blackboard. Then

she hummed something short, unlike our call. I followed her up the fingerboard; she repeated the tune more slowly, giving me time to find the last note. That simple meeting of notes set a tickle in my chest. Nobody needed summoning, there was nowhere we had to be in time. Even Marta stopped looking at her watch.

Nika came back and stopped in the doorway. We finished playing, and she asked:

“What was that?”

“I don’t know yet,” said Ada, and wrote two lines in her exercise book.

Then she opened a long wooden case. Inside lay an old reed

assembly, once removed for comparison with the one in the mill. The copper plates had darkened. On one, a little mark made by Marta's father was still visible.

Marta did not touch it.

"Alive?"

"Individual reeds sound. Nobody has tested the whole assembly for a long time. It will be different at the mill, even if we find identical ones."

I asked why the melody ended on E in particular.

I handed her the bass. She placed a finger on the smooth fingerboard.

“Because after that I wanted to hear someone else. You can’t compose their answer for them in advance and then announce that they’ve responded.”

She played only the first two notes, handed the instrument back and went on packing the case.

I sat on the chair, holding the bass between my knees. All along the road it had seemed to me that I was carrying the missing part of a song. Now it was turning out that I might know how to carry it, but had not yet learnt to put it on the table at the right moment.

Nika asked how I had known those notes in the first place.

“I don’t know. Perhaps I heard them here once. Or near the mill.”

“Or perhaps they weren’t quite those notes,” said Ada. “Memory rearranges tunes too.”

She did not try to take away that first morning of mine, when the string had seemed to answer the wind of its own accord. But in the working notebook we wrote down four ordinary notes and separately recorded who had played them and where we had listened.

By noon we had to leave for town. Vera was waiting for Nika at the bus station, where we had arranged to meet. Ada bought herself a bus ticket; Marta and Nika were travelling in Yakov’s

van, and I separately on Maybe. We divided the drawings into two bundles, so that one rainstorm could not destroy all our evidence at once. The originals stayed in the archive.

Before leaving, I saw a poster on Ada's table: this coming Saturday she was planning a class for people who thought they had no ear for music. At the bottom were four surnames and a question mark.

"Will you be back by Saturday?"

"I'll leave town by Wednesday evening at the latest. The test point here at the school needs preparing. And on Friday I have my own notes to go through."

I felt a little embarrassed by “my own”, which she had said without emphasis. In my mind I had already moved her somewhere nearer the mill.

At the gate Ada put up a notice rescheduling a class and telephoned two pupils. Then she checked the lock, ran her palm over the flaking doorframe and walked to the bus stop. Nika was carrying a box of music folders, trying to close it with her chin. The metal device stayed in the cupboard.

Maybe started on the second attempt. Marta strapped the drawing tube behind the van seat, checked Nika’s seat belt and

asked me not to overtake on the bends.

“Visibility is poor further on.”

“I remember.”

“Good. Then I won’t have to watch two children at once.”

We let Ada’s bus go ahead. Through the van window Nika held up four fingers to me, then opened her hand. I opened mine in reply. Both vehicles turned towards town.

19. Almost the End

The town greeted us with the smell of wet stone and fresh paint. On a wall by the bus station, an old notice was being painted over. “Everyone must” still remained, but the workman’s roller was already approaching “everyone”.

Vera stood beneath the awning with a bag of buns. First she hugged Nika, then held her at arm’s length, inspected her knees and asked why her voice was hoarse.

“Because I’ve been talking.”

“I noticed. Usually you’re silent non-stop.”

Marta told her briefly about the road and said that tomorrow we would need copies of Nika's map. Vera said she would be there after lunch tomorrow, but today the map, its author and all the pencils were going to wash and go to bed. Nika did not argue. She only asked us not to declare anything saved without her.

"We'll try not to rush," I said.

"Don't try. Don't declare it."

She took a bun and left with her grandmother. Over these past few days she had acquired several new ways of not believing me. None could be called unfair.

Marta, Ada and I drove to the mill. Semyon met us by the

barrier. He wore a work waistcoat and a hard hat, and held a plastic bag containing his empty lunch boxes.

“Did you find it?” he asked.

I raised the drawing tube.

“We have drawings, minutes, the intended uses of the rooms.”

“Good. Only we’ve found something here too.”

He took us into the site cabin, not into the mill. Photographs of the upper shaft support lay on the table, taken during the authorised work to reinforce the structure. In one picture a fine line crossed the metal collar. In another the same line had been outlined in white chalk.

Marta stopped undoing her jacket.

“How long?”

“Spotted it yesterday while cleaning. Stopped everything except the work to make it safe. The site manager sent the report to the Office.”

I bent over the photograph. The crack looked small. I wanted to ask why it had more right to our story than all the people who had taken part in it. Instead I asked whether it could be welded.

“On site, and by Thursday, no,” Marta replied. “And in any case we need an assessment first. This isn’t a saucepan handle.”

Semyon showed us the preliminary enquiry sent to a repair workshop. Making and delivering a suitable part would take weeks. The price, including the work, was such that at first I mistook one of the figures for a telephone number. Then I saw the word “roubles”.

“Could we leave it as it is?” I asked.

“We could leave it still,” said Marta. “But a stationary system needs checking too. What’s holding what, how much load is on the supports. And the damaged sail can’t just be left hanging there.”

We came out of the cabin. Nothing about the mill had

changed. The same stone tower, the same slanting shadow, the same sail I had come to love for being out of true. Now that flaw had weight, and could fall on a person.

Ada asked to be shown the area from which inspection of the lower sound duct was permitted. Semyon called the site manager, who led her and Marta along a fenced passage. I stayed outside. Gravel crunched under my sole. A workman to one side was putting tools into a case, checking each item against its cut-out space in the soft lining. I had nothing to check, which made me particularly eager to interfere.

They returned twenty minutes later. Ada held her notebook open.

“Part of the duct is blocked. We can’t assess the reed assembly from outside. Access above is closed for now. I can’t state that the mill is ready to give a reliable call sign.”

“But it did make a sound.”

“I believe you heard a sound.”

“Marta did too.”

“I’m not talking about hearing. I’m talking about what we can promise people.”

I took out the copy of Marta’s father’s drawing. It slid from the tube with an unpleasant rustle, as

though the paper already knew what it was being used for.

“It’s all described here. If you sign to say that the design…”

“I can sign to say that we found the design. But here,” she tapped the photograph of the crack, “I don’t know anything yet.”

“Then they’ll demolish it.”

Ada fastened her notebook.

“You’re asking me to decide which lie to tell for the sake of your fear.”

I turned away. On the other side of the barrier, the wind stirred the white tapes. There were fewer than two days left until Thursday, and we had brought

back detailed proof that we could promise nothing.

Semyon sat on the step of the cabin. I went over and asked him when the crane would start work again.

“On written instructions. For now, only making things safe. After noon on Thursday, it depends on the decision and the engineer’s assessment.”

“And if there are people at the gates?”

He looked up at me.

“What people?”

I fell silent.

“Don’t turn my shift into a threat,” Semyon said. “I work

here. And if the sail has to come down, you'd better give me room."

I grew hot inside my jacket. I had already pictured myself at the gates with the bass guitar, with the final word that everyone, for some reason, was obliged to hear out. In that picture there had been no room for either Semyon's shift or the wind.

I said I would go into town. Marta handed me the workshop key and asked me to buy milk.

"Nothing else?"

"Milk for now. We'll see after that."

I did not reach the grocer's. I turned off towards the music

shop, where they sometimes changed the strings on instruments belonging to people still able to pay for them. A new guitar stood in the window, gleaming without any effort on the owner's part.

The shopkeeper recognised me and asked whether I needed strings.

"I'd like a valuation on the bass."

He took the instrument carefully, checked the neck, the socket and the strap fittings. He did not ask why I was selling it. The absence of that question hurt me more than the question itself could have done: so no sacrifice was visible from the street.

The sum he named would not cover even a small part of the mill's repairs. It would, however, restore a great deal in the flooded yards. I took out my phone and opened the list of expenses we had begun compiling by the river. The money for the next agreed payment was set aside. After Thursday I was to return to the restoration work, and no decision about the mill could cancel that agreement. I had already been wondering whether I could borrow from it briefly and put it back after saving the mill.

Boris, who was coordinating the damage assessment, had sent a revised statement. Roman's treatment and lost earnings

appeared on separate lines. Next, Roman himself sent a photograph of boards for the shed. The message was short: “These. The others are warping. Tomorrow I’ll tell you how many they’re bringing.”

I rang him.

He did not answer immediately. Metal clanged in the background, and I was afraid he was working with his injured hand.

“That’s Lida,” Roman said. “I’m sitting here giving orders. Nobody likes it.”

I asked about his hand. He said it had hurt in the night but was more bearable today. Then he fell

silent, waiting for the point of the call.

“The next payment still stands as agreed. I wanted to confirm it.”

“Don’t promise it again every day. Just transfer it on time.”

“All right.”

I wanted to tell him about the crack, but Roman had to explain which of the wet boards were fit for a floor. I did not take up his time with my bits of iron.

The shopkeeper handed back the bass.

“Will you be leaving it?”

“No. Not today.”

I went out, put the strap on and at last bought the milk. In the shop I

had to wait while a woman established why two identical cartons had different prices. I stood with the instrument on my back and understood her wish for a clear answer. In such a queue, I would once have saved three mills in my head already.

Marta sat in the workshop at a table piled with copies. Ada was by the window, on the phone to a technical specialist. Yakov's van was locked in the yard; Marta had hung its key separately, with a note about Thursday's return deadline. I put down the milk, hung up my jacket and took out the sheet on which I had begun writing a speech for the people at the gates.

It contained only two words: “You must”.

I crossed them out, turned the sheet over and asked:

“What if it doesn’t turn at all? What if nobody goes into the tower until it’s been checked? Is there anything we can actually demonstrate outside?”

Marta took the sheet. She did not smile or say that she had been waiting for precisely this question all along.

“There’s the separate lower duct. There’s an outside area, if the engineer permits it. There are people who know how to answer. But the application will need limits, costs, people responsible

and the right to stop everything without your consent.”

“Without mine?”

“Without the consent of anyone who happens to want a beautiful ending at that moment.”

Ada finished her call.

“Lev Schyotchikov can come on Thursday morning. He’s independent, so we can’t expect him to commit in advance to the conclusion we want. I told him we weren’t asking for that.”

She pulled up an empty chair. I sat down and poured milk for everyone. On the first blank sheet Marta wrote: “What Is Forbidden Whatever the Outcome of the Trial”. Below it she left plenty of room.

20. The Night When No One Slept

If that night were being described by someone fond of beautiful titles, he would certainly have reported that no one slept. Nika was asleep from half past nine. Vera rang Marta, told her so and switched off her phone. The workers from the mill had gone home to rest too. The three of us stayed in the workshop, and by eleven it was already clear why normal institutions had shifts.

We had to clear the table of a carburettor, two boxes of fastenings and an electric kettle waiting for a new lead. Beneath all this we discovered an old

newspaper. It promised that an exemplary future would soon be provided for us; Marta spread it under the wet mugs.

Ada drew four rectangles on a large sheet. I prepared to hear about stations, but they turned out to be four different questions: what we wanted to test, what it would require, what we were not testing, and who had the right to stop it.

“You begin,” she said.

I wrote: “Test the possibility of bringing the mill back to life.”

Marta read it and put down her pencil.

“And how will we measure whether it’s alive?”

I had to start again. We planned to test whether, from an authorised area beside the mill, we could send out a recognisable call, receive confirmations from four predetermined locations and find out who had failed to hear, understand or answer. The plan retained the outdoor area, the closed tower and the stationary sails. Everything I had meant to set in motion had to be outlined with a different line.

It was less beautiful, but I could read what I had written without raising my voice.

Marta added a separate line: “The trial is not an operational public warning system.” Ada underlined

the requirement to stop the test in a real emergency.

When we reached the sails, the argument returned. I wanted to write that they would be secured. Marta crossed out “would” and left room for the engineer’s assessment.

“Lev may rule out even the outside area,” Ada said.

“Where do we try it then?”

“Somewhere else. And write honestly that we didn’t use the mill that day.”

I ran a hand over my face. Stubble rasped under my fingers. In my former picture, defeat had always arrived with the seal of the Office. Now it might come

from a man to whom we ourselves had entrusted a tape measure.

At half past eleven Semyon arrived. He had not come to work: he was collecting a charger he had left with Marta that morning. Seeing the plan, he took off his jacket and sat on the edge of a stool.

“Ten minutes. Then home.”

He circled the proposed place for spectators and put a question mark beside it.

“Don’t promise people this side of the hill. The vehicle will be standing here if the damaged sail needs removing.”

I began to explain that the public must not see the crane as an enemy, but Semyon was already drawing the access route. He needed room for the outriggers and a way to drive away. That had nothing whatsoever to do with our relationship with giants.

He gave the cost of the crew's work and explained separately which part was already included in making the site safe and which would require a new, paid assignment. We entered both lines without rounding them in hope's favour. I suggested that to begin with we could all work for nothing.

"I've already lost some shifts because of the stoppage," Semyon

said. “I can help. I can’t give you all my wages.”

“That’s not what I meant.”

“Then write something else.”

Marta pushed the expense sheet towards me. Several boxes in the “Source” column were still empty. We did not shade them in. Semyon checked his section, stated when he would be available, and left. His ten minutes had become seventeen. I recorded that too, although I did not yet know where to present the bill.

The meteorological tower appeared in our plan after midnight. Until then, every time I saw it in the mill’s place, I had

crossed it out in my mind. Ada laid a copy of the site plan beside it and asked what exactly bothered me: the measurements or the location.

“What bothered me was that it would replace everything else.”

“Then let’s find a place rather than abolish the instruments.”

A neighbouring vacant plot was marked in the papers. We did not know whether it would suit a separate foundation, so we entered the need for a check. The purchase of modern equipment was to be retained in the proposal. Moving the tower remained a separate question for the town and the engineers.

For the first time I drew the mill and its proposed replacement on the same sheet. There proved to be enough paper between them. Whether there would be enough land remained to be seen.

Marta opened the window. Cold air drifted in from the street, with the smell of the bakery, where the early shift was beginning. All the mugs in the workshop had gone cold. I brought Ada a blanket, but instead she made me go outside and walk to the corner.

In the street a single telephone kiosk glowed, without a telephone. Its glass reflected my bass guitar, leaning against the workbench inside. I thought of the music shop, of the money for

Roman, and went back for my exercise book.

Among the expenses was a line reading “Applicant’s Personal Funds”. I separated out the money already earmarked for compensation. I wrote down the exact sum I could really give to the trial and showed Marta. She did not praise me. She checked the addition, found an error and deducted a little more.

“What are you getting home on?”

“Maybe.”

“As far as I know, he doesn’t run on hope.”

We left money for petrol and food. It was the most

humiliatingly sensible part of my knightly budget.

Ada drew up the confirmation procedure. Each point had to have a responsible adult, a backup means of communication and someone who recorded more than just the successes. If a confirmation did not arrive, it could not be filled in from a neighbouring voice. If someone withdrew, their place remained empty. At the market square, the time still had to be agreed so as not to disrupt trade. At the river post, people were not to be distracted from repair work. The school would participate only from its safe yard and under Ada’s supervision.

“But you’ll be here,” I said.

“Until tomorrow evening. Then I’ll go back to the school and take charge of the point myself. I’ll prepare an adult helper, but confirm my attendance separately. For now we mark it as still to be arranged.”

There were more empty boxes. Strangely, this made the plan start to look feasible: every gap now had the name of a question that could be put to a living person.

At two o’clock Marta insisted on a break. We spread a towel on the table and set out supper, which was still hoping to count as supper. Ada ate in silence. I asked

whether she had lost much because of the old project.

“I don’t want to talk about that today,” she replied.

“All right.”

She nodded, and we went on eating. Her refusal stayed on the table beside the bread, getting in nobody’s way.

Then Ada lay down on the couch for an hour, Marta closed her eyes in the armchair, and I appended the agreed part of the damage list to my statement. The final assessment was not yet complete; the sheets still had room for new entries.

Towards the end I checked the names of the project’s developers

against the archive copy. Pavel stood between Ada and the man who had run the wire to the river post. I credited Ada as the author of the call sign and the rules for its use. Beside Nika’s map I left space for her signature and a note that the route had been checked only along the sections she had travelled.

The printer woke Marta. It swallowed three pages and jammed on the fourth. We opened the cover, carefully removed the paper and discovered that all the safety restrictions had printed on top of each other.

“A very dense presentation,” Marta said.

We had to print it again.

At dawn Ada read the finished pages aloud. We crossed out what we could not promise. “At no cost” vanished entirely. Beside the right to stop the trial, Marta drew a thick line. I reached to turn the page and froze: both her eyes were closed. She was still holding the pencil.

I signed my section. The word “Last” did not appear beside the signature.

At six in the morning we turned off the lights we did not need and went our separate ways to sleep until the Office opened. Two folders stayed on the workbench: one with what we knew, the other with what still had to be checked. Marta put a heavy box of nuts between them so that a stray draught would not mix their contents.

21. The Town Receives a Notice

We drafted the notice to the town over breakfast on Wednesday. The first version began: “The fate of our mill is being decided.” Vera, who had brought Nika and some pies, asked why the mill was ours if it was to be repaired with other people’s money.

I changed the opening.

The second version announced that tomorrow residents would have an opportunity to become part of history. Nika asked for her pie back if that was what it was being handed out for.

The third was shorter. We invited people to discuss a trial beside the old mill and at three other points. We stated that permission had not yet been granted, how much money would be needed, and the deadline for a decision. At the bottom we left room for questions. The word “rescue” would not fit, and I did not reduce the type size.

“Now that’s readable,” said Vera. “Though you’d do better to eat first.”

While we ate, Nika copied her map onto a clean sheet. At the old crossing she drew a large cross.

“Don’t go this way. It only looks dry from the road.”

Marta checked the marking and added whose observation it was. Nika crossed out my earlier caption, “Map of Possible Routes”, and wrote: “Map of Checked Paths. Not Everything Has Been Checked.” Vera liked that heading better.

At the Office, a young man with a thin beard asked us not to put the folders on the glass: it was cracked at the edge, and the replacement had not arrived yet. I moved them and explained what I had brought.

“An application for completion?” he asked.

“For a trial.”

He looked at the clock, then at me.

“By tomorrow?”

“By tomorrow we need a decision on whether it’s permissible. And a result, if it is.”

“Those are different documents.”

“We’ve brought both. The second has no result yet.”

He leafed through the pages, stopped at my account of the accident and looked up. I prepared to answer, but the young man only asked whether the appendix was included in the inventory. It was.

The folder was accepted. Our copy was stamped with the time: ten seventeen, Wednesday. I

studied the impression with an attention I had denied certain beautiful things in my life.

Gaspar came out to us himself. There was fresh thread in his coat beside the tear left by the archive chair.

“The technical assessment?”

“Tomorrow morning,” said Marta. “Lev Schyotchikov has confirmed he’s coming.”

“Has he confirmed he’s coming, or that a trial is possible?”

“That he’s coming.”

Gaspar nodded and took the sheet of restrictions. He read it for a long time. He made marks beside several points but did not cross them out.

“You may use the hall in the former hotel for the discussion. It’s free from six to eight. Put the furniture back afterwards. This is not permission to begin work.”

I assured him that I understood.

“The deadline remains twelve o’clock tomorrow,” he added. “If the assessment is negative, you do not start an experiment just to produce a record that you have started.”

“Yes.”

He looked at me for another second. Then he handed the sheet back. This time I did not feel that he was checking for the presence of Don Quixote. Rather, whether

an adult human being was fit to use the word “yes”.

We took the notices to places where interested people might come. At the shop by the market, the manager allowed us to put a sheet beside the board advertising private services, but asked us not to cover the notice about a found dog. At Marta’s workshop we left several copies on the windowsill. The same text, with the same conditions, appeared on the town’s page. Nika wanted to add a drawing of the mill, but Vera took her away to have lunch, and the drawing waited for its artist until after the soup.

We met the man in the grey raincoat near the Office, carrying an ordinary postbag.

“Are you giving notices now?” he asked.

“I’m trying.”

He read the sheet and pointed to the line with the address.

“Put ‘entrance from the yard’. They don’t let you through the main entrance in the evening.”

I added it. He did not take any copies for other people’s doors: he had his own work. But he promised to come along if he finished his round in time.

Towards lunchtime Lida rang. Someone had already told her that we were planning to warn

the town about a real rise in water levels with music.

“That’s not true,” I said, and read her our notice.

“Then say it aloud at the meeting. And again before the trial. I can provide an adult observer at the river point if there’s no urgent work tomorrow. Roman isn’t included. His hand needs rest.”

I wrote down the name she gave me and the condition for taking part. Then I sent Lida the draft communications procedure. She corrected the time of one confirmation, crossed out an unnecessary call and added the number for the duty service. We kept all her corrections.

Meanwhile Ada was preparing the test point at the school. On the table lay her notes, an ordinary telephone, a portable loudspeaker and a sign with large lettering. She was explaining over the phone to an adult helper she knew that tomorrow nobody was to guess what a signal meant. If they did not understand, that was what they were to say. If the equipment failed, they were to record a failure, not keep turning up the volume until victory.

The last bus to the school left after the evening meeting. Ada bought a ticket and put her bag by the door. I had seen her all day, yet the bag still surprised me: Ada had an actual route

home, one that did not depend on my story continuing.

By six in the evening the hall of the former hotel was half full. The chairs stood unevenly. In the front row sat a woman who sold dairy produce at the market, with a man in a builder's jacket beside her. Three elderly residents of the western outskirts had settled near the window. Vera and Nika took seats by the door. Semyon came in his work clothes but without a hard hat. People I did not know whispered in the back seats.

I went up to the table and realised I had not prepared an opening for my speech. On the sheet before me were only

restrictions, costs and questions. I read out the restrictions.

“What have we come for, then?” asked the man in the jacket. “If nothing’s allowed.”

“To find out what is,” I replied, and immediately heard how like an evasive answer it sounded.

Marta stood up and showed the plan. She explained the possible uses of the lower room after inspection, the space for shared tools, the classes, the opening hours and the links with the points. She stated separately that tomorrow people would remain outside, and that a single musical trial would not lead to a workshop opening.

“You’ve got a workshop of your own,” observed the woman from the market. “Do you want a second?”

“No. I have to run mine on the money I earn. A shared one needs different rules. I’m willing to help set it up and give a few hours of teaching, but not to support the whole thing alone.”

She named the hours she could actually spare. Vera wrote them on a large sheet, because from the back row my handwriting looked like a picture of the wind.

An elderly man by the window asked about noise. His wife slept poorly in the daytime, and after all the previous festivities he did not want another reason to shut

the window vents. Ada suggested limiting the hours in advance and checking how audible it was at the nearest houses. He said he would not take part. We recorded the complaint and did not record him as a helper.

The man in the builder’s jacket asked about money. Semyon pointed to two separate lines: the safety work already required and the additional work. It turned out that some people thought the crane was free because it belonged to the town, and the people who came with it were already standing there anyway. Semyon explained that he, too, ate by the day rather than by the final decision. Some people

laughed; others shifted with displeasure.

No money was collected in the hall. We agreed first to publish the final estimate with the authorised scope of work, and tomorrow to use only what was already funded and agreed by those doing the work.

“And if the engineer doesn’t like it tomorrow?” asked the woman from the market.

“Then there’ll be no trial on the hill,” I said.

“So why did we come today?”

I had no comfortable answer to that. I said it was better to find out in advance whether there were people for the work to come

than to promise the town a room for which nobody was responsible. The woman thought, then offered to provide a table for record-keeping at the market for one hour, provided we did not block the trading aisle. For now she promised nothing more.

The man in the grey raincoat came in shortly after seven. He sat by the wall and put his bag between his feet. At that very moment someone asked why we should trust a man who had already flooded other people’s vegetable gardens to take part in the trial.

I recognised the voice but could not remember the face.

“You shouldn’t,” I said. “My mistake is described in the appendix. I won’t be operating machinery. I’m obliged to pay for the damage and do the work I promised, whatever is decided about the mill.”

“And you’ll be the musician?”

“If the participants agree. Any of the people in charge will have the right to stop me.”

Someone in the back row suggested leaving me in charge of only the volume, but Marta said the person at the equipment would do a better job of that too. This eased some of the tension. Complete trust did not descend on the hall.

Nika showed her map. She spoke briefly, pointing out the dangerous crossing and the place where the path on the plan diverged from the real one. One of the elderly residents corrected her: the gate there had recently been moved. She asked him to show her where, took another pencil and circled the stretch as needing to be checked. They bent over one corner of the sheet, blocking half the town from our view.

By eight, specific promises had appeared on the large sheet. Two people could keep records. The woman from the market was providing space for an hour. A neighbour agreed to meet the

observer at the lower path. Vera took responsibility for accompanying Nika and one other child, only within the authorised area. Semyon remained part of his paid crew. The others took away copies, questions and the right not to come.

We put the chairs away together. Ada said her goodbyes quickly: there was little time before the bus. I helped carry her bag to the stop.

“We’ll meet over the line,” she said. “The school will answer if it’s ready. If it isn’t, you’ll hear that it isn’t ready.”

“I’ll write it down.”

“Better listen.”

The bus pulled away. Inside, Ada immediately opened her folder, and I returned to the workshop without trying to invent a final word for her.

Marta was checking the pages for Lev. I handed her the minutes of the meeting, the new marks on the map and the signed restrictions on my own work. She put everything in a stiff folder. The engineer was arriving on Thursday morning; there were fewer than fourteen hours left until noon.

Late that evening we went out towards the western street. Work lights shone on the hill. They lit the barrier and the lower area,

leaving the top of the mill dark. The sails were still. Behind them stood the crane.

A phone rang in the workshop: Ada had reached the school and was checking the connection. Marta went to answer it. I stayed at the gate, holding it while a neighbour wheeled a folding table in to us on a trolley.

Part IV: Not the Last Line

22. The Man Who Measured Everything

On Thursday I woke to find someone measuring my shadow.

I had come to the hill before dawn and, while we waited for the engineer, sat down beside Maybe. Now my shadow was long, and I was asleep against the wheel. A man in a pale jacket stepped over my legs, stretched a tape to a peg and wrote something in a notebook. I decided that the Office of Final Affairs had at last found a use for

its last citizen: they were using me to tell the time.

“Please don’t move,” the man said.

“Is it time already?”

“Not yet. You’re sitting on the tape.”

I stood up. The tape withdrew into a little yellow case with such an angry rustle that it seemed to have been planning to do so for some time.

“Lev Schyotchikov,” the man introduced himself. “Independent engineer.”

He held out his hand, but it turned out to contain a pencil. We both looked at the pencil, after

which he put it in his breast pocket and tried again.

“The Last Don Quixote,” I said.

“I saw that in the application. I need your ordinary name.”

I gave it. He found the appropriate line and ticked it. And so, for the first time that week, I met someone who took no interest whatever in my title.

Below us the town was waking. White smoke stood above the bakery; an early lorry crawled along the road to the market, bouncing in the same spot as though it could never remember the pothole. Dew hung on the temporary fencing. Semyon was already at the crane. He leaned

his bicycle against a support, took two eggs from his pocket and laid them carefully on the lid of a crate.

Marta came round the mill holding our folder in both hands. It had grown so much overnight that it was no longer clear whether we were preserving the mill for the sake of the papers or the papers for the sake of the mill.

“Good morning,” she said to the engineer. “The bearing’s up top, as in the photographs. We’ve marked the crack. We haven’t covered anything up.”

“Good.”

“That’s the first good word in three days,” I observed.

Schyotchikov looked at me over his glasses.

“I said it was good that you hadn’t covered anything up.”

He did not look like a man who meant to forbid everything. That was what worried me most. I knew how to talk to a man who forbade things: he had his prohibitions, I had my objections, and we could keep one another in work for hours. Lev Schyotchikov wanted to know what was happening to the stone, wood and iron. The stone might tell him something very inconvenient indeed.

He began on the lower level. He would not let us follow until his assistant, who had arrived in a small van, had finished inspecting the entrance. She had a grey plait tucked under her hard hat and a habit of folding her gloves palm to palm when she took them off. Marta gave her the key and told me to go back behind the fence.

“I’ve been walking round here for a week,” I said.

“I noticed,” she replied.

Schyotchikov stood beside the wall for a long time, occasionally bending down and shining a light into the cracks. His hand appeared for a moment in the doorway. Morning light came

into the mill through an unglazed window; it looked as though the engineer was holding a rectangle of sunshine in his palm and checking whether that, too, had cracked.

Then he came out and asked for the old drawings.

Marta spread them on the table under the canopy. One still bore the mark of her father's mug. I knew that mark by now: the coffee ring crossed the outside staircase and turned it into a crescent moon. Marta always held the sheet a little higher up, without touching the circle.

"A workshop was planned here?" the engineer asked.

“Yes.”

“Regular occupancy of the second level?”

“In that version.”

“Not possible in its present state.”

Marta nodded, but I saw her press one finger against the edge of the sheet.

“And the sails won’t turn,” he went on. “Not after these repairs. Even if we had three months instead of a morning.”

The crack of eggshell came from behind the crane. Semyon was listening without turning his head.

“What about the room downstairs?” I asked.

“No visitors go in there today. Once the necessary work has been done, an inspection carried out and a decision made about opening it, we can return to the question. Today your trial is outdoors.”

He spoke calmly, without raising his voice on the word “no”. For some reason I felt better: it allowed no exception for the last, the most devoted or the most willing to die.

Marta took our overnight version out of the folder. A workshop under the canopy, a table for meetings, a resonator outside, a disconnected drive, a possible site for the weather station next door. The engineer’s eyebrows stirred.

“Now, let’s look at this.”

“Let’s look” had once seemed to me a variety of refusal. Now I drew up a chair for him.

He sat down, took an apple from his bag and laid it beside the ruler. He read every page from beginning to end. From time to time he asked a question, addressing it to whoever had signed at the bottom. My presence was not considered a sufficient answer on everyone else’s behalf.

“Who’s staffing the river point?”

“Lida and her relief,” Marta said. “Roman has only agreed to observe from the bank, without using his hand.”

“And if they’re both busy at the bridge?”

I had already opened my mouth to say “We’ll find someone”, but Marta touched my hand.

“Then the point is unavailable,” she replied. “That’s what will go in the log. The official warnings will go out as usual.”

“Write that larger.”

He turned the sheet. A line appeared in the margin, circled in pencil.

At half past seven Vera came up the hill. She had brought Nika by the hand, although the girl kept trying to free it for her large cardboard folder. In her other hand Vera carried a saucepan.

“You’ve all had engineering works for breakfast already, I see,” she said. “Now you’re having porridge.”

Nika wanted to show us her revised map at once, but her grandmother put a bowl in front of her.

“Spoon first. Scale afterwards.”

I ate standing up. The porridge smelt of milk, dry dust drifted from under the canopy, and the two smells unexpectedly brought back the feeling of an ordinary morning. On an ordinary morning a person might miss a bus. There were fewer than five hours left until noon, and for the first time in a week I wanted simply to ask who had made the

porridge and whether there was enough for everyone.

The engineer asked for seconds.

“Nika will be with me at the market,” Vera announced. “At the table by the clock. If you need her notes, bring them down to us.”

“I have a phone,” Nika said.

“And grown-ups have short memories. Better to tell them again.”

Schyotchikov noted the observer’s position and the name of the adult accompanying her. Nika drew a small circle round the market clock on her map. Then she thought for a moment and drew a saucepan beside it.

“Is that a landmark?” he asked.

“That’s Grandma.”

“I see.”

By nine Schyotchikov had called together everyone who would be working on the hill. He assumed no solemn expression. He put his apple on the folder to keep the pages from blowing away and set out the conditions. Specialists would remove the damaged sail. The drive would remain secured. Spectators would stand to one side, behind the marked boundary. The trial would take place with no one inside the tower. The old acoustics would be tested separately from the new station’s equipment: neither was to stand in as proof that the other worked.

“If I say ‘stop’, everything stops,” he said. “If Semyon stops the lifting work, it stops. If any participant sees a danger, they can demand a halt. Explanations come after we’ve stopped.”

He looked at me.

“That includes you.”

“Especially me,” I said.

“No. Everyone equally.”

Semyon nodded. Marta put down her pencil. Nobody laughed. I was grateful for that, and ashamed at the same time that everyone remembered the reason for my answer.

The river water had left a pale crust on my boots. I had scraped it off the day before, but it still

showed white in a crease of the leather. In my memory the lever I had broken cracked again. I had been in a hurry then, too: other people's work had seemed a delay before something only I understood. I took my foot off the rung of the chair so that I would not see the crease, then put it straight back.

"Could you write in that I'm required to comply with a stop without arguing?" I asked.

"It's already written in for everyone," the engineer replied. "You won't get a line of your own to be proud of."

We signed. Schyotchikov's signature turned out to be broad, almost cheerful. For some reason

I had expected a neat column of figures.

The weather service van arrived. Two workers unloaded a portable mast and boxes of instruments. For now they were taking measurements here, from ground level; the permanent tower's site still had to be approved. Only the new pegs stood in the neighbouring plot. Marta went to greet the foreman. They were soon talking about fixings, and I was left standing beside something I had spent the whole week regarding as our future defeat.

Schyotchikov noticed my look.

“You’ll find its readings useful. Old timber doesn’t report wind speed in figures.”

“It reports it in creaks.”

“We’ll listen to the creaks too. Only before anything falls down.”

He bit into his apple and went over to his assistant. His work consisted of a great many small actions, none of which promised salvation. I picked an empty bowl off the grass, took it to Vera and returned to the table. There was not yet a single final signature on our permission. But for the first time I knew exactly where we were allowed to stand.

23. The Mill Begins to Listen

Almost everyone heard the first rehearsal, and hardly anyone understood it.

I stood beside the external resonator we had fitted under the canopy, holding the bass as carefully as though the fate of the whole valley depended on the angle of my elbow. The instrument’s old wood had warmed against my stomach. My fingers, slightly unfamiliar after two short nights, found D, A, C, E.

The notes came out unevenly. I held the third too long. In the open air they seemed smaller than in the workshop, and the

mill wall added a short, dry tail to each. I waited through the rest.

At the market someone struck a metal hoop. Twice. Then three more times, with a certain irritation. The blows reached us through the phone's loudspeaker: the market itself was too far away.

Vera's voice came from the phone on the table:

"People here are asking whether this means cucumbers or fire."

Marta closed her eyes.

"We put up a notice."

"There are cucumbers on the notice now."

Nika was talking rapidly beside her grandmother. Then came the clatter of containers being moved and an aggrieved male voice. The notice was uncovered.

The river point did not answer. A plaintive blast from the school horn came over the phone. A lorry driver who had come up to the table to look at the musician glanced anxiously back at his vehicle beside the road.

“We’re stopping,” Marta said.

I had already raised my hand to play again, but laid my palm across the strings.

Schyotchikov sat at the edge of the canopy. A watch and four sheets of paper lay in front of

him. He looked neither disappointed nor satisfied. Notes appeared in the appropriate places.

“Let’s try louder,” suggested a man who had volunteered to help on the hill. All I knew about him was that he had brought an extension lead yesterday and was now trying to think of a way to make his contribution sound more convincing.

“First let’s find out what happened,” Marta said.

We waited for Lida. Her voice came over the phone, breathless, with the splash of the river in the background.

“There was no answer,” I said.

“Because there was no one by the device.”

“We did agree a time.”

“And at the agreed time a wheel came off a trolley at the crossing. I was helping get it out of the way. Roman mustn’t lug iron about with that hand. My relief was at the bridge mechanism.”

There was no apology in her words. She was reporting where things were: the trolley, the wheel, the people, the injured hand. I watched Schyotchikov put them all into one short line: “Point unstaffed at time of call.”

“Then we need to appoint someone else,” I said.

“Appoint someone,” Lida replied. “Only ask them first.”

I wanted to say that I had not meant it as an order. I did not.

Roman took the phone. He spoke from a little further away from the microphone, and his words came mixed with wind.

“I can sit here until eleven. I know how to sit. Doctor after that.”

“Don’t put it off because of us,” I said quickly.

“I’m not. That’s why it’s until eleven.”

Marta wrote down the time. I heard Roman settling on the bench and asking for something to put under his elbow. The

wooden creak beside the distant river seemed clearer than any of my four notes.

Ada called from the school herself.

“I have two people here who can only hear the highest note,” she said. “A third gets a whistle in his hearing aid. And a woman who’s come from next door has a phone older than your motorcycle. If the plan depends on everyone hearing the tune in the same way, you can cross it out now.”

“We were testing whether it was recognisable,” I said.

“And now we’ve tested that. Time to get to work.”

She asked us not to play for the next twenty minutes. I took off the instrument and leaned it against a post. Accustomed as I was to filling every hitch with sound, I found this strangely difficult.

While the line was silent, an elderly woman from the market came up to the canopy. A bag of greens hung from her shoulder; a hearing aid in a transparent case stuck out of her pocket.

“My name’s Natalya,” she said. “I asked you about the bench yesterday.”

I remembered. Yesterday, while we were discussing the fate of the mill, the bench had seemed unimportant to me.

“The place where you want to put the duty table has the sun in your face. If someone reads lips, all they’ll see is a head in silhouette. And you can’t see your little sign from the street.”

Marta stood up.

“Will you show us?”

The three of us walked round the canopy. Natalya stopped beside a low stone wall.

“From here I can see what you’re saying. And this is where people come up from the road. Your rope had cut them off over there.”

Schyotchikov came out to check the new position. The rope was moved without bringing the walkway any closer to the tower,

and the table was turned sideways to the sun. We brought a long plank on two steady supports. Natalya sat down, put her bag beside her and patted the wood.

“That’ll do for now. Only give it a back later. Everything here assumes people will spend their whole lives standing up.”

At the market Nika was already rewriting the explanations. She sent a photograph of the sheet. Instead of little words round the notes, it now had four large boxes: “We can hear”, “We can’t hear”, “We need help”, “We’re not here at the moment”. I called and asked her to change the last one.

“Why?” she asked.

“If you’re not there, who’ll hold up the sign?”

She was silent for a moment.

“Then no answer is a separate thing. And you mustn’t assume it means everything’s all right.”

“Yes.”

In the photograph sent a few minutes later, the last box had been heavily crossed out. Vera stood beside Nika’s table, holding the sheet down against the wind with two carrots. As far as I knew, no designer of town schemes had ever allowed for fixings of that kind before.

On a new sheet Vera wrote in large letters: “Communications test. Not an alarm.” When Ada

saw the photograph, she asked for it to be raised above the cucumbers and left there until the end.

I had once imagined how I would play one day and the town would fall silent. Now the market was doing quite the opposite: weights clinked, people argued over change, the fishmonger banged his knife. Among all this noise, Vera announced the time of the next check. She did it in the voice she normally used to call Nika in from the street, and she could be heard superbly.

Ada devised a simple sequence. First an announcement and a visible starting signal, then the call, then time for a reply. If there

was no reply, the person responsible would contact that point separately. Nobody was to go on playing for ever, demanding that people turn up. We moved the start so that Lida would have time to finish and Roman would not be late for the doctor.

“Breathe out,” Marta said when I lifted the bass again.

“I am breathing.”

“You’ve been breathing for the entire structure for ten minutes.”

I breathed out. Ada’s chuckle came over the phone.

The second time I played more quietly.

Natalya, sitting by the wall, did not lift her head. She was watching the person with the sign. At the market Vera waited until the end of the rest before giving the signal. Roman’s voice came from the riverbank:

“In position. We can’t hear well, but we’ve received the message.”

“Write it down just like that,” said Lida beside him.

The school answered with a short, low blast. It did not fit my last note. I wanted to shift my finger and make the sounds come together. I kept my hand still.

By the road, the same driver leaned out of his cab.

“This time I know it’s not my lorry,” he informed us, and drove on.

Marta was the first to laugh. I heard her laughter, alive and tired, and realised how long it had been since I had heard anything from her but instructions.

Schyotchikov circled the time on his sheet, but did not declare the trial a success. Another check was needed after the sail had been removed, with everyone in their final positions and independent communications in place. He asked us to record the first failure along with the corrections.

“Everyone heard it anyway,” I said.

“In a month they’ll remember it differently.”

I took a blank sheet and wrote: “The river point did not answer because the people there were doing other work. At the market the signal was mistaken for an alarm. At the school some participants could not distinguish the sounds.” My handwriting was unpleasant. I read it through and signed.

An old board creaked on the tower. The secured sails stood motionless, while under the canopy a phone rang, people argued about where the bench should go, and someone asked for the extension lead back after noon. Surrounded by ordinary voices for the first time in many years, the mill no longer seemed empty. I rested my palm against its wall. The stone had warmed on the eastern side and was still cold to the west.

24. The Duel Is Called Off

Before the sail was taken down, a man in a red scarf came up to me. It was a warm day, and he had probably put the scarf on for the occasion.

“We’ll be beside you,” he said.

“Thank you. Only behind the fence.”

He looked at the crane, then at the bass over my shoulder.

“When they start, you go up to the wheel. We’ll sit across the road. Let them try.”

I recognised him: yesterday he had stood at the back of the meeting and said almost nothing.

Now a rolled strip of cloth stuck out of his pocket.

“What’s on it?” I asked.

He unfolded one end. Black letters declared: “THE LAST WILL NOT GIVE IN.”

The final letter was not yet dry.

“Did you write that yourself?”

“With my wife. All night. She’s gone to work. I brought it.”

I touched a dry corner. The cloth turned out to be an old bedsheet, neatly darned.

“The sail has to come down,” I said.

He did not understand at once.

“Yes, that’s what they’ll tell you.”

“It’s damaged. They won’t leave it hanging over people.”

“Then they’ll take down the second one. Then the fence. Then they’ll put up a kiosk. They preserved our bathhouse that way. At first they only promised to dismantle the roof.”

He spoke without hysteria. There was something familiar in his voice: he had stood beside a building that had been promised a return, and now he saw a smooth wall in its place. I could offer him no proof after the fact.

“Did they bring the bathhouse back?” I asked, though the answer was clear.

He put the sheet away.

“Made a car park.”

A few paces off, Semyon was putting on his gloves. He could see us and was waiting without interfering. Beside him stood two workers who in a few minutes would have to deal with the actual weight of the timber, while we settled the question of what that weight meant.

“They might break their promise here too,” I said. “That’s why we’ll record where the sail’s been put and what will happen to it. But I’m not going to sit you down underneath it.”

“I’ll sit down myself.”

“Then they’ll stop the work. And we’ll still have a damaged sail

over our heads. You can ask the engineer without me."

The man looked at the tower for a while. I braced myself for the worst: that he would call me a sell-out, a fraud or simply a coward. He asked something else.

"Where are they going to put it?"

We went over to Schyotchikov together. He showed us the place behind the storehouse where the supports were already standing, and explained exactly what would be kept and what would have to be removed because it had deteriorated. The man asked awkward, detailed questions. The engineer answered; once he said that he did not yet know and would find out once it was down.

I moved away. Five minutes later the stranger was already photographing the empty supports with a sheet of newspaper showing today's date laid against them. He had taken off his scarf.

Semyon beckoned me over.

"What's up with you?" he asked.

"I was getting ready for a duel. And now it turns out I'd only have been getting in the way of a working day."

"Plenty of you get in the way of a working day. Just keep out from under the jib."

He said it without reproach. Then he showed me the gap between the fence and the parked van.

“People will cut through here. Stand outside and send them round. Don’t grab anyone. If they won’t listen, call whoever’s in charge.”

I had been given a job that required no title. It consisted of politely informing pedestrians of a very minor inconvenience.

The first to approach was a man with a bag of bread.

“I only want to get through,” he said.

“You can’t just now. The way through is over there.”

“I’ve walked this way all my life.”

“They’re taking a sail down today.”

He looked up, sighed and went round. The second pedestrian asked the same question. The third was Natalya. She turned aside of her own accord, but asked me to move a stone that people would trip over. I moved the stone. So far, this was the most indisputably useful work I had done at the mill.

Marta stood beside the engineer. From a distance she looked calm, but she had the fastening of her jacket clenched in her fist. I knew that her father had climbed many times to the place where the specialists were working now. I had never met him, yet for several days his pencil lines had

been stopping me from doing simple and wrong things.

The removal began without grandeur. Someone checked communications, someone asked for the area to be cleared once more, and for quite a long time nothing visible happened. People who had expected the instant downfall of antiquity began talking about other things. A boy with a scooter stopped on the road. His father tugged at his sleeve, then became absorbed in watching too.

The wind rose when the sail’s weight was already resting in the slings.

Not a storm, not the sort of wind for which prophecies are

composed. An ordinary gust swept off the hill, turned up the edge of the engineer's sheet and stretched out the sleeve of an empty jacket hanging on the fence. The reading on the portable instrument's screen suddenly dropped to zero.

"Stop," said Schyotchikov's assistant.

Almost at the same moment, Semyon halted the movement.

I felt my whole body gathering itself to run. My feet had already found the direction of the crane, although neither my hands nor my head had any work to do there. I gripped a fence post.

The boy with the scooter asked:

“Is it going to fall now?”

I did not say “never”.

“They’ve stopped the work. Let’s go back to your dad.”

His father laid a hand on his son’s shoulder himself. We moved further back along the walkway.

Semyon sat motionless in the cab. The workers spoke briefly, without shouting. Schyotchikov was comparing the readings on another instrument; his assistant was checking the device that had stopped transmitting data. The sail hung still. I watched the taut sling and Semyon’s hand, visible through the cab window.

A contact in the portable meter had come loose. The cause was

recorded. The instrument was taken out of service until it could be checked, and the pause lasted several more minutes before the wind allowed work to resume within the specified limits.

The man with the red scarf came up to the fence.

“Something of theirs broken?” he asked.

“The meter,” I replied.

“Will it go in the report?”

“It’s in already.”

He nodded and said nothing more.

When the sail came away from the tower, I was expecting a loud noise. Instead there was a dry

crunch and a little dust trickled down. The mill seemed to have turned sideways, although it had not moved. Light fell on a patch of masonry that had been hidden before.

Marta lowered her hand. The fastening slipped from her fingers.

I wanted to go over, but she came to me herself once the sail was lying on its supports.

“That’s where Father patched it,” she said. “Can you see the pale board across it?”

I could see the board, darkened almost as much as its neighbours.

“I remember it new, when I was little. Father brought the offcut

home. It became the shelf for the radio.”

We stood outside the working area and watched the specialists remove the lifting gear. It was painful to see the sail so close. From below it had seemed a sign of destiny; on the ground there were gouges, traces of birds, an old nail driven in crookedly. In one place the wood gave beneath a workman’s finger and crumbled into dust.

“I wanted it to be whole,” Marta said quietly.

“So did I.”

“You wanted it to turn.”

“Yes.”

She turned her face towards me.

“So did I. I just didn’t say so.”

Then she wiped her nose on her sleeve and demanded a tape measure from Schyotchikov. The pale board had to be marked on the drawing before everything was covered up. She put the loose end of the tape in my palm and stepped back towards the pale board.

On its inner face we found three pencil strokes from an old marking-out. Marta passed her finger above them and offered no explanation.

Semyon climbed down from the cab. His shirt had darkened across the back.

“Well, are we still alive?” he asked.

“We’re checking,” Marta said.

He gave an approving grunt.

The man with the scarf photographed the sail on its supports, then checked it against the engineer’s record. He gave his name for the appendix to the report and asked whether he could come back in a month to see if the timber had disappeared.

“Come,” Marta said. “During opening hours. We’ll have a list of inspections there.”

He took the folded sheet away with him. I felt sorry for his wife’s labour and almost asked him to leave the cloth for the canopy. It

was just as well I stopped myself. Someone else’s hope did not become building material merely because it failed to fit me.

I took the bass, checked the strap and returned to the table. The removed sail lay beside the crane. The wheels were intact. The duel for which I had once been ready to ride across the entire town had not taken place, and Semyon was able to finish his second egg in peace.

25. A Song Without a Conductor

Gaspar Metronomovich arrived at ten forty.

A young man with a thin beard got out of the car with him. In his hands he held the familiar folder the colour of old butter and a new folding stand for papers. Only several years' service in an institution where paper must never touch the ground could have prompted anyone to bring such a stand up the hill.

The head of the Department of Completions looked at the mill without its sail.

"Started already?"

“Finished the preparations,” Marta said.

Schyotchikov handed him the records. Gaspar Metronomovich stopped at the page with the first unsuccessful call and read it twice.

I waited for a question about why we should go on at all. He asked:

“Will Roman get to the doctor in time?”

“He’s already gone. Lida and someone from her shift are at the river point. They’ve agreed to take part until half past eleven.”

Gaspar nodded and returned the sheet to the engineer.

Watching him read Roman’s name, I remembered the story of

his brother. I wanted to find a phrase that would acknowledge that old grief without using it to win us our new piece of paper. I found no such phrase. I offered him an empty chair.

He sat down.

At the market the wind had changed, and now a stallholder's voice came clearly over the phone:

"Who else wants half a kilo? I've got work to do till noon as well, you know."

Vera asked him to move away from the communications table. He did not move, because his scales were there. So Nika moved the phone. In reply, the school

reported that coal was being loaded beneath their window, and no one had agreed to stop the loading for the trial.

Ada sounded cheerful. She acquired that voice when things at last became imperfect enough to teach.

“Excellent. We’ll put the coal down too. This isn’t a concert hall.”

I took out the instrument. This time I was not given the central position. The communications table stood nearer the road, the signs could be seen from the lower terrace, and Natalya was sitting where she could look at people’s faces. We had left a wide passage. Some of the spectators

had gone after the sail came down, and there was more room on the hill.

“Should we wait for people?” I asked.

“Which people?” Marta said, surprised.

I looked round. The few dozen people present were not a crowd that would make a good story afterwards. Semyon was changing his shoes beside his bicycle. The man with the extension lead was checking his watch. A woman from the next street had come with a shopping bag and plainly hoped to get to the market as well.

“No one,” I said.

Marta smiled with one corner of her mouth.

Schyotchikov checked the points and the finishing time. The weather service's instruments worked separately; on our four sheets we were to record who had received the message and who had been able to reply. Natalya turned so that she could see the sign. I waited for her nod.

The young man from the Office began recording on his phone. Then, after a moment's thought, he laid a pencil beside it. He had the look of a man who did not entirely trust the future of his battery.

I played four notes.

The first, D, settled at the foot of the wall and returned as a brief hum. A went higher, through the space where the sail had been. On C the canopy fabric rustled. E was almost homely: in it I recognised the quiet sound from my room, the morning a week ago, the envelope on the table and the rest that nobody had yet occupied.

But now the rest was occupied.

There were van wheels in it, a teaspoon in a glass, someone’s cough. Natalya raised her hand to show that she could see the starting signal. The person beside the signs turned a sheet over. At the market Vera asked loudly whether everyone had understood the message and

received three different answers, one of which concerned the price of cabbage.

“Market in contact,” Nika said. “Message received. Have you put a tick by Natalya’s name?”

“Natalya’s here and putting in her own ticks,” she replied.

The river answered through the phone. Then a short metallic sound came from the bank, uneven, like a spoon striking the rim of a saucepan. Lida explained that the people by the far walkway had not heard all the notes, but they had seen the raised sign and knew where to ask.

The school was silent.

I watched the phone. Yesterday a whole destiny would already have grown out of that silence: Ada had turned away, the school had refused, the last chance had gone. Today a table stood beside me with the time recorded on it, and Marta was counting out the allotted interval.

“No confirmation from the school,” she said when it had elapsed. “We’ll contact them separately.”

She called. At first without success. The young official stopped writing and raised his head. Gaspar Metronomovich sat upright, both palms resting on his knees.

My mouth went dry. I let the bass hang lower on its strap so that it would not press against my stomach.

A minute later Schyotchikov's assistant handed Marta her phone. Someone answered at the other end: the school's main handset had run out of charge, and the adult responsible for the backup connection had gone out to meet a vehicle bringing materials. Ada was with the group at the far end of the schoolyard and believed that confirmation had already been sent.

The hill fell quiet.

"We're stopping this run," Schyotchikov said.

I nodded, though no one needed my nod. Marta drew a conspicuous line on the sheet. I had a foolish desire to hide it from Gaspar with my hand. Instead I pushed the sheet closer to him.

Ada came on the line a few minutes later.

“My mistake,” she said. “I didn’t check who was staying by the phone. I wrote ‘person responsible’ but no name. So we ended up with a person responsible who’s walking all over the building at once.”

She was not smiling. On the phone you can sometimes hear smiles better than you can when you meet.

“Have you time to repeat it?” the engineer asked.

“If the others agree. We need seven minutes. And my signature under this incident.”

Lida confirmed the time. From the market Vera said she could stay another twenty minutes, after which she had to go home: her neighbour had her keys, and the neighbour needed to leave for her shift. The man with the extension lead had to go. We thanked him. His lead was replaced with one the weather service had brought in advance; he checked that his cable had been coiled without knots and hurried downhill.

I suddenly felt how much effort it took for people simply to be in their places. Behind each of them waited somebody's lunch, a shift, an injured hand, an unfinished order. No one became free of their own life on hearing my music.

While the school put its communications right, we tested the message without sound. Nika raised a conspicuous board at the market and Vera repeated the text aloud. On the hill the signs were turned over in sequence. Natalya received the information at the same time as the people who had been allotted more hearing. She looked at me and gave me a thumbs-up.

It was the shortest review of my playing: on this occasion it had not been needed.

The second full run began at eleven seventeen.

Ada was at the phone herself, with a woman who had agreed to take responsibility for the backup. Before I played, I heard children's voices from the school. They were arguing over who would hold the cardboard sign. Ada appointed two and told them not to pull it between them, or their point would split in half.

I ran my fingers across the strings.

The replies did not arrive in the order I had imagined. First the

market, then the school, then the river. Lida did not repeat the musical sound: a trolley was passing beside the walkway, and she chose to confirm by voice. At the school someone managed to sing my four notes but forgot the pitch of the last, and Ada answered with another, her own. At the market one stallholder took up only the beginning, then immediately returned to his customer.

No collective song could have been recorded without long gaps, conversations and accidental knocks. Yet Schyotchikov marked each in turn: seen, heard, read, understood. Every reply had a human name.

By the far wall Semyon was whistling quietly. He was not in my key at all. Beside him Marta held an open drawing, and the sunlight shone through the thin paper. Her father’s coffee ring now lay across her wrist.

I did not know whether she could hear music or the creak of the removed sail she remembered whole. To go over and ask would be to demand an answer there and then. I stayed in my place.

Once every point had confirmed the end, Schyotchikov stopped his watch and asked us to keep the records of both attempts.

The call was still connected. A boy’s voice came from the school: he was searching again for the

note he had missed. Ada answered, and this time the answer meant neither “received” nor “checked”. She took up his imperfect tune. I recognised the short melody from Tuesday’s class and laid a bass line beneath it.

At the market the stallholder tapped a weight against his scales. Vera told him off, then laughed herself: the weight was falling between my notes. Lida listened in silence; water rustled beside her phone. Because of the delay the voices kept drifting apart. I stopped trying to catch Ada and began answering wherever there was room.

Marta turned the drawing blank side up, smoothed it out and tapped the familiar two beats with her fingers. We played like that for a few more minutes, until the market was the first to say goodbye. The schoolboy finished singing alone. I heard his sigh and the click of the phone disconnecting.

Gaspar Metronomovich stood up. I straightened involuntarily, waiting for the verdict.

“There’s no chair with a back in the documents,” he said.

Natalya raised her head.

“There. At last someone was listening.”

The young man with the thin beard opened the folder at the next sheet. I slackened a string a little, checking the tuning. Vera’s last message appeared on the phone: “Getting ready to go home.” The market was returning to trade. The school was opening its windows after the coal dust. The river had not stopped flowing for a moment.

26. The Last Signature

At a quarter to twelve we gathered under the canopy.

The papers were laid out on three tables. One had come from the workshop, the second had been lent by the market, and the third was not a table at all: a door without a handle rested on trestles. It was on this very door that we were to decide whether the mill would keep an entrance.

The young man with the thin beard sat on the edge of a crate and began laying out the appendices. In his presence sheets somehow aligned themselves more willingly. He moved my mug away, slipped a

clean folder under the damaged corner of a drawing and asked who had checked the duty roster.

“I did,” Marta said. “The confirmations are attached. Empty days have been left empty.”

“So no opening is proposed for those empty days?”

“None.”

He nodded and made a note.

Gaspar Metronomovich held the engineer’s report. His face had become the motionless face I had first met a week before.

“This states the possibility of limited trial use,” he said. “Not permanent operation.”

“Yes,” Schyotchikov replied.

“With the outdoor area available and the building closed.”

“Until the specified work has been carried out and a new inspection completed. Rotation of the sails is ruled out.”

“And a successful trial today does not demonstrate that it will work in all weather conditions.”

“It does not.”

It seemed to me that we were taking turns cutting pieces off the mill until nothing would be left on paper but a canopy and one authorised bench.

Marta bent over the plan.

“Here is the accessible area. Here is the workbench. People can bring small things here for repair by appointment, when a craftsperson is on duty. This is where we can meet. This is where the observation log is kept. We aren’t opening the tower. Father drew more. This is what we’re asking for now.”

She covered a pale patch on the drawing with her palm. I wanted to support her with a long speech, but the man sitting beside us would permit or forbid the use of a very specific piece of ground. I simply pushed the confirmed requests for the first workshop days towards him.

There were eleven requests. They included a broken toolbox, a child's chair, some garden netting with holes in it and two meetings of neighbours about the path to the river. Marta had crossed out one request in advance: the person needed work for which there was no equipment on the site.

Gaspar noticed the crossing-out.

"Turned them down?"

"Sent him somewhere they can do it," she said. "He isn't obliged to bring it to us."

The head of the Department of Completions turned the pages.

"Costs."

I pointed to the relevant sheet. Here I no longer wanted fine words. The money promised in compensation for the damage by the river was listed separately and played no part whatever in saving the mill. I had insisted on this during the night and checked it again in the morning. The bearing, which we could do nothing about before the deadline, had not been hidden under “other work”. Replacing it remained a question for the future, with no solution promised.

For the next ninety days the plan amounted to two short workshop days a week. We already had tables and tools; I could pay for

consumables from the money that remained. Marta and Semyon had confirmed their hours; inspections and necessary specialist work were listed separately and paid for. There was no money yet to open the tower itself. Funding for the weather station remained in the town project; the new address required separate approval.

“And if the volunteers stop coming?” Gaspar asked.

“We’ll reduce the hours,” Marta replied. “If there’s no one to work, we’ll close the site for that day. We won’t say it’s open.”

“And if the money runs out sooner?”

“We’ll stop the work we can no longer pay for.”

He ran a finger along the edge of the paper.

“You understand that a site like this may not survive its trial period?”

“We understand,” Marta said.

I heard how hard the word had been for her, and repeated it in my own voice.

Only those who were actually needed remained at the tables. The others had left or sat further away, not knowing whether they could rejoice yet. Semyon was checking his bicycle chain. Natalya was waiting for her bag, which someone had accidentally

taken over to the van. Nobody had a hand raised.

The young man produced a prepared report form.

Printed at the top were the words: “Work completed. Site fit for purpose.”

Gaspar looked at the first line for a long time.

“No,” he said.

My hands went cold.

“We can append the restrictions,” the young man hurried to explain. “As a note to the form.”

“Not to this form.”

The clock on his phone showed eleven fifty-two. There were eight minutes left of our seven-day

reprieve. I remembered the first form I had torn into quarters and pictured very clearly how I might now snatch up this new piece of paper. Once again there would be less paper and more mistakes.

Gaspar took off his glasses. Without them he looked like a tired man who had accidentally found himself in an expensive jacket on a dusty hill.

“I’ve signed ‘fit for purpose’ before when it was only what we intended to do that was fit for purpose,” he said. “That won’t happen here.”

No one answered.

He put his glasses back on and asked for a blank sheet.

The young man handed him three at once, as though hoping to insure against the blank sheet itself.

Gaspar wrote the heading by hand. Then he dictated slowly while the young man typed an electronic copy beside him. Limited public use of the outdoor area was permitted for ninety days, subject to the specified conditions, named persons responsible, costs and interim inspections. The decision to dismantle the mill was suspended for that period. The turning mechanism would remain locked, the damaged sail would be preserved in the marked location, and access to the interior was

prohibited until separately authorised. Siting the weather station on the adjoining plot remained a separate matter for the weather service.

All the trial records, including the unsuccessful ones, went into the appendix.

“Keep the word ‘successful’ only beside the particular run,” Schyotchikov said.

Gaspar amended the sentence.

“Agreed.”

My lip suddenly twitched. I almost laughed to hear that word without a hidden qualification, while I was still sitting on a crate, we were short of chairs and a

phone had run out of charge at the school.

Marta nudged me with her knee. Not as a warning, simply a touch.

There were many names on the page of responsibilities. Mine stood beside duties I could actually fulfil: help run some of the meetings, conduct the agreed communications sessions, help according to the rota, report faults. The engineer crossed “at all times” out of my offer to be present.

“You go to the river twice a week,” he reminded me. “And you sometimes get ill, even if you haven’t tried it yet.”

I signed the corrected version.

Gaspar picked up his pen. It would not write.

Very quietly the young man with the thin beard said something that was not in his official vocabulary, and produced another. A black line appeared in the margin. The department head signed the decision at eleven fifty-six. At eleven fifty-eight the young man showed us the registration mark and number.

Nobody applauded on time.

Then Semyon, seeing us sitting motionless, clapped his hands once, as though dusting them off. Natalya asked:

“So will there be a bench?”

“There will,” Marta said. “With a back.”

“Good, then.”

That became our ceremonial announcement.

Gaspar was gathering the remaining papers when I took out the old notice. It had worn thin along the fold, and the blue line had almost disappeared.

“What about this?” I asked. “Am I still the Last?”

He unfolded the sheet.

“The entry has not been revoked. You confirmed that you had business in progress a week ago. Today the arrangements for continuing it have been set.”

“So the title stays.”

“Does that trouble you now?”

I looked at Marta, who was arguing with Schyotchikov about the time of the next inspection. At Semyon, fastening a bag to his bicycle. At the young man carefully slipping cardboard under the sheets so that we could carry our copy away without crumpling the fresh signatures.

“Leave it,” I said. “Only don’t close anyone else’s forms because of it.”

Gaspar handed back the notice.

“Your title gives me no such right.”

“It would have been good to know that at the start.”

He inclined his head a little.

“Yes.”

That “yes” did not put our first meeting right. It remained beside it, displacing nothing.

The clock on the phone changed to twelve. The deadline expired in front of us, without the tolling of a bell. Down below a vehicle sounded its horn; lunchtime had arrived in the town.

Gaspar paused beside the removed sail. Marta went over to him, and they spoke briefly about the timber. I could not hear their conversation. Then he took out his phone, looked at the screen and said, loudly enough now:

“I need to call Denis.”

He walked away from us across the grass. I did not follow or compose his words for him.

Our copy of the decision lay under the canopy. The young man had weighted it with that same apple of the engineer's, of which less than half remained. A small ink blot was drying on the top sheet. I moved the paper further into the shade so that the wind would not fold it before its time.

27. A Name for the Next Road

The next day the mill site opened for two and a half hours instead of the promised three: Marta had a job at her workshop, and the second person on duty had caught a cold.

I wrote the new hours on the board. The letters sprawled because I still wanted to sleep. A woman passing by read it, sighed and asked whether she could collect her box today. We fetched it together. It smelt of machine oil and last year’s apples. I took it as far as the turning on a little trolley, came back, hung up the

“Closed” sign and set off to return someone else’s vehicle.

Yakov’s van stood outside the workshop. Marta had washed it the evening before; a dark, damp patch remained on the ground by the driver’s door. Back on Sunday Yakov had extended the original two-day loan until Thursday evening. After the trial Marta had called him again and asked permission to bring it back a day later: after two nights of short sleep, she no longer trusted her alertness at the wheel. Yakov had agreed to Friday evening. This time there were still several hours before it was due, and we asked for no further extensions.

“You go in front,” Marta said. “And don’t show me the short cut.”

“I respect it from a distance now.”

She slammed the left door, then opened it and shut it again. In a week that sound had become familiar to me.

We reached the inn towards evening. Two small tables that had not been there before stood by the entrance. Yakov was moving one into the shade. A leg wobbled; Yakov slipped a sliver of wood underneath, remained dissatisfied and carried the table back into the shed.

“You’ve brought it back,” he said when he saw the van. “Well, let’s have the keys.”

He walked round the vehicle, opened the back and looked inside. Marta listed what she had checked on the road, where she had topped up the fluid and what would need looking at during the next service. I stood beside Maybe and very much wanted someone to ask about our victory.

Yakov asked:

“Did you deliver the parcel on time?”

Marta confirmed that she had. The crease beside his mouth smoothed out.

“Come in, then. Tamara’s left you some pie.”

The inn smelt of apples and paint. A new timetable hung on the kitchen door. Two days were crossed out: Tamara was taking time off. The “Final Answer” sign remained in place, except that someone had now fixed a scrap of paper beneath it: “Pie orders taken until five.”

“Are you restructuring?” I asked.

“We’re making pies,” Yakov replied.

Marta laughed and at last sat down, stretching her legs under the table.

We told him about Thursday, the sail and the ninety days. Yakov

listened, breaking the burnt edge off his slice. Then he asked whether he could bring some stools to the site: two good ones, one in need of repair. Marta told him to send photographs first, so that he would not bring things they did not need.

“You’ve got stricter,” he told her.

“I’ve always been like this. You just call more often now.”

I left money for supper, and Yakov took it. I liked that we could thank one another without trying to abolish the bill for ever.

Marta rode home with me on Maybe. In the bag was pie for Nika and Vera Pavlovna. At one bend Marta tapped my shoulder

and pointed to a low strip of mist above the meadow. I slowed down. Nothing was happening there. We simply rode a little more slowly for a while.

On Saturday I went back to the river.

The faded flags of past celebrations still hung in the square. Someone had left a bucket of lime beneath one of the boards. I parked the motorcycle where it would be in nobody's way and walked to the shed.

Roman sat by the door. His right hand was still supported by a bandage; he held his cup in his left. When I came up he put it on the bench.

“Well, how’s your mill?”

“They’ve given us ninety days.”

“And the sail?”

“They took it down.”

He nodded.

“Saw the photograph. Took it down well.”

I laid my notebook of calculations in front of him. I had receipts for materials already paid for and the money for the next agreed instalment. We were recording the cost of treatment for his right hand and the earnings lost through the injury separately. I did not intend to settle those entries with my own work carrying boards. There was less money than I had wanted to

bring. At home I had counted it three times, as though a third count might add to my dignity.

Roman did not look at it straight away.

“They’re taking up the decking at Lyubov Fedotovna’s today. Go there first. Nothing needed here yet.”

By the next plot I met Boris. He was still coordinating the restoration: keeping the materials list, arranging things with the tradespeople, noting who needed what help. I showed him my notebook. He checked two sums, corrected a delivery date and put me down for Saturdays.

“If you can’t come, let us know beforehand,” he said. “So no one’s sitting with their floor taken up, waiting for you.”

I saved his number on my phone and went where I had been sent.

Lyubov Fedotovna recognised me and did not say hello. She showed me where to stack the dry boards and where to put the wet ones. I worked alongside her grown-up nephew. He said little, but corrected me every time I was about to take too much or put something in the wrong place. By lunchtime I had discovered that even a simple board-carrier can suffer from a bad imagination: he constantly wants to carry things faster than his back will allow.

The owner brought out water. She gave mine to me last.

“The money for the flowers will arrive on Wednesday?” she asked.

“Yes. As we agreed.”

“Good. Only don’t tell me again that it will all grow back. I know that myself. The customers have gone elsewhere.”

I said I would not.

In the afternoon my shoulders began to ache. This brought no comfort. Everyone who was helping had aching shoulders, although only I had broken the lever.

Over the following weeks I went to the river on Tuesdays and

Saturdays. Several times I was sent home because the work called for specialists. Once I was told simply to deliver the bills and keep out of the way in the cellar. The eight plots were each being restored differently. In one place soil had to be bought; in another, rooms needed drying out and cleaning; elsewhere the owners had decided not to plant anything more that season. I stopped thinking of an empty bed as a task I had the right to put straight at once.

Out of my house went the old amplifier I had meant to mend for years, two surplus cupboards and a record collection I had cherished chiefly in conversation.

The bass stayed. In the evenings I began playing more often in places that paid: a small hall near the station, two family celebrations, Yakov’s inn. Once Tamara said the music was good, but the customers wanted to talk. I played more quietly, and that evening I was invited back.

Roman began to move his fingers more confidently, but his hand tired quickly. One day he tried to open a tight jar and could not. I reached to help. He asked me to wait, then pushed the jar towards me himself.

“Now, go on.”

I opened it and handed it back. That was the end of the conversation.

Lida told me that no one was promising a full recovery yet. I wrote down the next expenses as we had agreed and kept paying. Roman knew I was coming, but did not come out to greet me every time. Sometimes a key to the shed was left for me; sometimes the door was locked. Gradually I learnt not to take either as a judgement on my entire soul.

At the end of the fifth week we sat together by the water. He held a fishing rod in his left hand; I had no rod and was therefore useful as a holder of sandwiches.

“I’m still angry,” he said.

“I know.”

“Not all the time. More when my hand seizes up.”

I looked at the water.

“If it makes things easier for you when I come, I will. If I’m in the way, tell me.”

“Come on Saturdays. No need on Tuesdays now. The work there’s finished.”

He took a sandwich, and we sat for a long time after that. The fish took no part in our reconciliation.

At home, life gradually grew around that Thursday and no longer fitted its ceremonial frame.

Nika brought new sheets to the workshop. They showed not only our four points but steps,

awkward gates, a passage that flooded, places where cars were always parked in the road. At the bottom she had written her name. Vera Pavlovna demanded that she add a date.

“Otherwise in ten years they’ll be saying my granddaughter left them the wrong path.”

“In ten years I’ll draw another one.”

“So write down when you checked this one.”

On one sheet her grandmother corrected the position of a staircase. It turned out that for years she had been visiting a neighbour by a route Nika considered impassable. They

argued for a good twenty minutes, then went to check together. Each returned pleased for her own reason: Nika had found a way through; Vera had proved that her legs still knew a thing or two without maps.

The town service took copies of several plans to clarify the pedestrian routes. Nika's signature was kept, with the surname of the adult who had checked the measurements and accessibility placed beside it. Corrections were sent to her, not to me. That was particularly pleasant: I could be absent altogether, and the work would still go on.

Ada began classes at her school for people who were afraid to sing. I came to the first without an instrument, expecting to sit at the back. She gave me a little bell and sat me between a woman in a work coat and a man who announced that he had been tone-deaf from birth, although he located an empty chair very accurately by its creak.

“Today we’re learning to come in later,” Ada said.

“That will do me good,” I replied.

“I know. But the class isn’t just for you.”

After the lesson she asked me to take copies of the notes to the mill. I asked whether she wanted

to move closer: it would make meeting and working together easier.

“It suits me to work here,” Ada said. “And we’ve already learnt how to meet.”

I did not relocate her again.

Meanwhile Marta had taken back her ordinary jobs. She kept two definite days for the mill, rather than all the time other people had managed to assign her in their minds. Someone was surprised that some of the work had to be paid for.

“Yes,” she said. “Otherwise I’ll have to take on more buses, and you won’t have anyone left at all.”

I helped her in the workshop in the evenings if she asked. Sometimes we simply ate at the low table by the gates. She told me about a customer who wanted to change the sound of his car's engine without changing anything in the engine. I told her about a man who had asked me to play a familiar song but could not remember a single sound of it. These stories lived very comfortably side by side.

One day Marta took out the brass compass with no needle. The glass was smudged, the hinge needed cleaning. She laid it on the table between us.

"Are you going to the river tomorrow?"

“Yes.”

“Can I come with you? Lida has some work for me. We’ll be free after lunch.”

I did not ask what “we” meant. We were already sitting at the same table, and that was enough for the evening.

At the turning to the mill Nika left a blank line on her new map.

“The road needs a name,” she said. “It’s just ‘access road’ in the documents again.”

I suggested three names. The first was too long, the second already existed, and Vera Pavlovna called the third funereal.

Marta looked at the map.

“Leave it as ‘to the mill’ for now. If we go further, you can add to it.”

Nika wrote it in pencil. Then she showed us a fine line beyond the hill which on the old plans broke off at the garden. It led to a little footbridge across a stream. Nika did not know whether the bridge was still intact and put a question mark beside it.

I noticed it and did not suggest setting off at once. We had work at the river on Saturday, and on Sunday I had promised to help Marta with the gates. I asked Nika to leave me a copy. She put the sheet under the compass to keep the corner from curling.

28. Not the Last Line

In three months the mill had learnt to smell of tea, wet jackets and fresh shavings.

Flour did not return to those smells. The sails did not turn, the bearing did not heal, and I stopped listening to every creak in the hope of hearing the old mechanism triumph. The tower's roof was made secure. After the necessary work and a separate inspection, the little room downstairs was opened, while the stairs above remained behind a locked door. The door said who had the key. Beneath the notice Nika drew an arrow, because people kept asking me anyway.

The removed sail lay on supports under the canopy. Some of the wood had to be taken away; the rest was treated and secured. We kept the pale cross-board with Pavel’s three pencil strokes. Marta wrote on a little card that these were repair marks and added an approximate date. We had no other information. Sometimes I saw visitors look at the three short lines for a long time and then move on without an explanation. Nobody complained.

In that time the weather service had secured approval for the neighbouring plot and built a weather tower there. It turned out slender, pale and rather

beautiful, which at the beginning of our story would have struck me as an insult. The sensors at the top looked like small kitchen utensils that had been granted permission to watch the sky. A separate service monitored them, checked and maintained them, and transmitted the readings. When a technician came, I no longer asked why he was interfering with our landscape. Usually he asked us whether he could put his mug down.

A timetable hung on the room's wall. It had empty squares. Twice in the first month we forgot to change the hours on the outside board in time, and once someone came from the other end of town

for nothing. He wrote a complaint. We called and apologised, and from then on appointed someone responsible for the sign alongside the person responsible for the premises. We kept the complaint in the folder, without hiding it beneath the thank-you notes.

Fortunately, we had collected a few thank-you notes too. Natalya wrote one in pencil on the back of a shop receipt: “Comfortable to sit on.” The bench acquired its back in the second week. We hung the receipt above the photographs of the trial.

I made the last of the agreed payments for the river damage shortly before the repeat

inspection. I put the confirmation in my notebook. The list still held the marks against completed work and, separately, a record of continuing expenses for Roman's treatment and compensation for lost earnings: his hand still needed monitoring. That evening Roman sent a new bill from the doctor. I tucked it in at the next page.

Roman's right little finger still responded less readily, and after prolonged work there was pain. He could return to some of his jobs by now, but handed the heavy work to someone else. At the crossing they no longer sent me to work every time I came. Sometimes they asked me to

deliver a board; sometimes they poured me tea. Once Lyubov Fedotovna gave me a bunch of greens and said it was for delivering the sacks, not for anything in general. I accepted it specifically for the delivery.

On the day of the repeat inspection Lev Schyotchikov arrived.

Again he began with the fence, and again the first thing he did was ask me to move from the spot where he intended to measure. I moved without explaining my historical role.

“A familiar procedure already,” he observed.

“I could go away altogether.”

“I’ll need you in ten minutes. In the meantime, don’t improve anything specially for the inspection.”

He had come two days before the ninety days expired. We had managed to carry out all the scheduled interim checks; none had allowed the drive to be unlocked. Sometimes I dreamt that the sail had turned after all. On waking I felt joy at first, then anxiety, and finally went to put the kettle on.

Marta was showing the engineer the log. Instead of our night-time heap of sheets, we now had a bound book and electronic copies. The handwriting in it varied. Semyon made short

entries in large letters, Natalya wrote long lines, and I left the margins too wide. There were water marks in several places: once the rain had reached beneath the canopy before the person on duty could close the box.

“Was that when the site closed for three days?” Schyotchikov asked.

“Yes. The official warning came in advance. Messages through our points were confirmed separately,” Marta replied. “The school wasn’t open that day. We recorded the absence instead of counting it as confirmation.”

“Consequences?”

“The log got wet. There was a leak by the new gutter. We fixed it; the photographs are here.”

He looked, then went over to the gutter.

During the three months of waiting I had often imagined that some terrible night would prove the mill’s usefulness once and for all: the water would rise, the electricity would fail, I would play, and everyone would be saved. In reality, when heavy rain came, the services warned of the danger in the usual way, people read the messages, Lida closed the necessary passage, and I sat at home worrying about wet pages. In the morning we dried the log on a line, and Vera Pavlovna said

we should have bought clothes pegs sooner. She was right without any storm at all.

While the engineer inspected the room, the first workshop participants arrived at the mill. A man brought a stool, a woman a basket with its handle torn off. Semyon was scheduled to help until lunchtime. He put his bicycle where the crane had once stood.

“There’s an inspection today,” I warned him.

“And is the stool going to mend itself?” he asked.

Marta heard and laughed.

Gaspar Metronomovich came without the ceremonial folder.

The young man with the thin beard was absent this time: he turned out to be on holiday. For some reason this news pleased me almost as much as the first permission had.

The head of the Department of Completions sat on the bench with the back and read the documents. We did not stand round him in a semicircle. Marta was finishing the basket, I was pouring tea, and Schyotchikov was checking his notes. Gaspar asked twice about costs, once about access to the site in winter, and looked for a long time at the list of missed shifts.

“There aren’t many,” I said.

“I’m interested in what you did when they were missed.”

I showed him the records of closures and replacements. For one shift we had never found a replacement, and the site had stayed closed that day. He put a small tick beside the line.

The decision to continue limited operations was made without a fresh trial of our patience. Another nine months, the same restrictions on the mechanism, an agreed spending plan and further inspections. The downstairs room would remain open within the limits of the permission already granted. We could go on working. It was written clearly enough for me to read it only twice.

“What about permanent?” I asked all the same.

Schyotchikov looked up.

“Every building requires maintenance and repeat inspections. A word on paper won’t replace a gutter.”

“I mean our permission.”

“So do I.”

Gaspar signed. This time his pen worked at the first attempt.

Marta took our copy, put it in the folder and returned to the basket. I stood nearby for a while, not knowing what to do with my suddenly idle hands. Then I went to take out the shavings.

At the exit Gaspar stopped beside the route map. Nika’s name stood beneath it, and alongside ran a short list of corrections made by other people.

“Denis asked for a copy,” he said. “There’s a path to the old house marked on it. He thinks the turning is nearer the stream.”

“Let him correct it.”

“That’s what I told him.”

He did not linger. His car went down the hill, and we stayed to collect the mugs. We had a new signature, our mistakes preserved and the opportunity to argue with him again if we needed to.

Ada came that evening. She brought some of her pupils' notes and asked permission to hold a class under the canopy. Three adults and a boy accompanied by his mother came with her. They sat at different distances from the wall. Each had an instrument; one woman had only two wooden spoons.

I brought the bass. Ada looked at it.

"No lead performer today. If you're tired, you can simply listen."

I was not tired.

Nika appeared with Vera Pavlovna. Her grandmother had a flask; her granddaughter had

an updated map with a ragged edge: the sheet had accidentally torn while being taken out of its transparent sleeve. Nika was upset at first, then mended it. The corrected road fitted on it in full.

“The footbridge is still there,” she reported. “Grandma and I walked to it on Sunday. Only the gate beyond it is locked. We need to find out whose it is.”

Vera poured the tea and settled in her favourite place. The bench’s back creaked. Semyon raised his head, listened and said he would look at the fixing after the class.

The boy who had come with Ada had large knees and a very new notebook. He watched me tuning

the strings for a long time, then came over.

“Why haven’t you got those metal things across it?”

“Frets?”

“Yes. How do you know where to press?”

I played one note, then moved my finger slightly. The sound drifted and came to rest.

“I listen. Sometimes I miss.”

“Can you put it right while it’s still sounding?”

I showed him. He leaned closer, but did not reach for the strings himself.

“Where does the road go beyond the gate?” he asked suddenly, looking at Nika’s sheet.

Nika said she did not know yet. There used to be a garden there, but on the new map it was missing altogether. The boy’s mother suggested first finding out who owned the plot and whether there was a way through. Vera Pavlovna promised to ask her neighbour, who had once worked nearby.

The boy opened his notebook and drew a gate. He made the handle too large. He looked at the drawing, added hinges and left room on the other side.

“Will you be the Last Don Quixote for ever?” he asked.

“There’s no time limit in the paper.”

He thought about it.

“Awkward.”

“Sometimes.”

“Do I have to be someone to come with you?”

“No. But you need to ask your mum.”

His mother nodded without looking up from the map.

Ada tapped a spoon against the edge of the table. People took their places. I played four notes: D, A, C, E. Waited through the rest. The woman with the spoons answered first, then someone’s bell, then Ada’s voice. On the

third round I missed my entrance. Nika looked at me but did not prompt me. The song went on, and I came in when there was room again.

A little weather vane turned above the neighbouring tower. The removed sail lay dark under the canopy. From the new gutter, freshly washed, the last drop fell onto the grass, and on the table, between the flask and an empty mug, lay the map.

After the class Marta handed me my jacket. She, Vera and I were going to walk to the lower bend; the others were still finishing their tea. The boy asked to walk with us, and his mother took his hand. At the gate of the mill yard Marta paused to adjust the compass clasp. I lifted the bolt and held the gate while they went out onto the road.